

Mary Barton



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF ELIZABETH GASKELL

Elizabeth Gaskell was born Elizabeth Cleghorn Stevenson to William Stevenson, a Unitarian minister, and Elizabeth Holland Stevenson in London in 1810. When Elizabeth Holland Stevenson died about a year after giving birth to her daughter, William Stevenson sent the baby to her maternal aunt, Hannah Lumb, in the rural town of Knutsford, Cheshire, England. Hannah Lumb essentially raised Elizabeth. In Knutsford, Elizabeth attended a young ladies' school from age 11 to age 16, where she studied not only social graces but also classical literature. At age 21, Elizabeth married a Unitarian minister named William Gaskell (1805–1884), and the newlyweds moved to the northern manufacturing city of Manchester, where William Gaskell became the minister at Cross Street Unitarian Chapel. The Gaskells had six children: one stillborn daughter, four surviving daughters, and one son who died as a baby. In 1837, the couple published in *Blackwood's Magazine* a set of poems called *Sketches among the Poor* that they had written together. Subsequently, Elizabeth Gaskell began writing short stories. In 1848, she published her first novel, *Mary Barton: A Tale of Manchester Life*, anonymously—but after the novel's commercial success, people discovered that Gaskell was the author. She went on to write seven more novels, the last of which, *Wives and Daughters* (1864–1866), was finished by English journalist and editor Frederick Greenwood (1830–1909) after Elizabeth Gaskell died of a sudden heart attack during its serialized publication in *Cornhill Magazine*.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

In *Mary Barton*, the eponymous heroine's working-class father John Barton becomes a Chartist. Chartism (c. 1830s–1850s) was an English working-class political movement named after the so-called People's Charter of 1838, a massively popular petition demanding reforms from Parliament that included a general right to vote for adult men whether or not they owned property; a right to run for Parliament whether or not the candidate owned property; and a salary for members of Parliament so that working-class men could afford to hold office. In 1848, after food-shortage protests in Manchester (where *Mary Barton* takes place) and other cities, the Chartists planned a march on Parliament to force England's government to listen to their demands. In response, Parliament revived a centuries-old law that radically limited (to 10) the number of people who could present a single petition to Parliament in person. Parliament also passed other laws to make mass demonstration more difficult. The Chartists had to cancel their

march, though a smaller number of them still brought a petition to Parliament. Though the Chartists lost many members after 1848, some of their demands later became law: for example, in 1867, Parliament extended the vote to working-class men in cities, though it didn't pass full adult male enfranchisement until the early 20th century.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Elizabeth Gaskell's *Mary Barton* (1848) represents class conflict between mill and factory owners and their working-class employees in the northern English manufacturing city of Manchester at the tail end of the Industrial Revolution (c. 1760–1840). Gaskell's later serial novel [North and South](#) (1854–1855) also represents class conflict in a northern English industrial town. Gaskell was personally acquainted with the more famous Victorian novelists Charles Dickens (1812–1870) and Charlotte Brontë (1816–1855); in fact, Gaskell wrote the first biography of Charlotte Brontë, *The Life of Charlotte Brontë* (1857). As such, it seems possible that *Mary Barton* may have influenced Dickens's representation of the working poor in [Hard Times](#) (1854), while Brontë's stubborn and self-determining eponymous heroine in [Jane Eyre](#) (1847) may have influenced Gaskell's portrayal of spirited young women in her subsequently published novels. In addition to these possible influences, Gaskell explicitly alludes in *Mary Barton* to William Shakespeare's history play *Henry IV, Part I* (c. 1597), Mary Shelley's proto-science fiction novel [Frankenstein](#) (1818), and the poetry of radical Samuel Bamford (1788–1872), indicating that Gaskell had read and may have been influenced by all these writers.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Mary Barton: A Tale of Manchester Life*
- **Where Written:** Manchester, England
- **When Published:** 1848
- **Literary Period:** Mid-Victorian
- **Genre:** Social Novel, Realism
- **Setting:** Manchester, England
- **Climax:** Jem is acquitted of Harry Carson's murder.
- **Antagonist:** Harry Carson
- **Point of View:** Various

EXTRA CREDIT

Change of Title. Elizabeth Gaskell originally intended to call her first novel *John Barton*, but her publishers insisted she instead name it *Mary Barton* after John's daughter.

Lost TV Series. Though the BBC aired a four-episode television adaptation of *Mary Barton* in 1964, the film was somehow destroyed or misplaced.



PLOT SUMMARY

When Mary Barton is 13, her aunt Esther disappears. Shortly after, her mother, Mrs. Barton, dies in childbirth along with the baby. Mary's widowed father John Barton throws himself into labor organizing among Manchester's workers. When Mary is 16, John decides she must work. As pretty Mary has secret pretensions to marry up, she doesn't want to be a factory girl or a servant. Her father agrees that she can apprentice to a seamstress, and she begins working for a woman named Miss Simmonds.

A year later, Mary's elderly family friend Alice Wilson introduces her to a girl her age, Margaret, who is plain but sings beautifully. Margaret lives with her grandfather Job Legh. Margaret and Mary become fast friends—though Mary doesn't tell Margaret about her new flirtation with Harry Carson, a factory owner's son. Meanwhile, Alice's nephew Jem Wilson is in love with Mary, but she isn't interested. One night while Mary and Margaret are sewing together, the girls hear a commotion outside. They run and see that a nearby mill owned by Harry's father Mr. Carson is on fire. Jem helps rescue his father Mr. Wilson and another worker from the burning mill. Mary, seeing Jem in danger, faints. Mr. Carson decides to keep his mill closed rather than employ workers while he makes repairs. Throughout the spring, other mills shorten workers' hours or close as well. Unemployed workers' families begin to starve.

The workers decide to petition for help from Parliament. John Barton is selected as one of their representatives. Mary, suffering from a guilty conscience about her flirtation, decides not to see Harry while her father is away. One evening, her coworker Sally Leadbitter, who acts as a go-between for Mary and Harry, visits Mary and finds her crying. Mary explains that she's crying because Mr. Wilson has died unexpectedly. The next evening, John returns from London defeated: Parliament refused to listen to the workers. Margaret and Job visit the Bartons, and Job reads them a poem by Samuel Bamford about the suffering of the poor. John, moved, asks Mary to copy down the poem for him. The following day, Mary writes the poem down on the blank half of an anonymous valentine that she suspects Jem sent her.

A year passes. John Barton, having lost his job when he traveled to London, can't find more work. The Bartons' home life becomes deeply unpleasant, and Mary spends more and more time outside with Harry. One night, when John is returning home from a union meeting, Esther—dressed like a sex worker—approaches and begs John to listen to her “for Mary's

sake.” John assumes Esther means the dead Mrs. Barton, who was also named Mary. As he blames Esther for Mrs. Barton's death, he furiously casts Esther away. Esther, sick and weak, falls. A policeman who assumes she's drunk arrests her.

Meanwhile, Jem musters the courage to propose to Mary. When Mary refuses him, he says that her rejection might turn him into an alcoholic and a murderer. When she still refuses, he flees. Then Mary bursts into tears, having suddenly realized—too late—that she loves Jem, not Harry. She decides to end her flirtation with Harry. When she tells Harry she doesn't love him, he assumes she is angling for a proposal—and he says he loves her so much he'll even marry her, though he never considered marrying her before. Shocked that Harry intended to “ruin” her, not marry her, Mary runs away.

Alice's godson Will, a sailor, visits Manchester on leave. At a gathering at Job's, Will falls in love with Margaret upon hearing her beautiful singing. Meanwhile, Esther is released from prison. Having watched her family from afar, she knows about Mary's flirtation with Harry and wants to save Mary from being “ruined” as Esther was. She ambushes Jem Wilson outside work and tells him how her flirtation with an army officer led to extramarital cohabitation, a daughter, the officer's eventual abandonment, her desperate entry into sex work to support her daughter, and her daughter's death. Now Jem has to save Mary from the same fate at the hands of Harry Carson. When Jem tries to convince Esther to return home and be rehabilitated, Esther tells him she can't be rehabilitated because sex work has driven her to alcoholism. She flees.

The factory owners receive a large manufacturing order, but they fear the client has sent the same order to factories in Europe and will only buy from the factories that fill the order at the lowest price. Therefore, they offer workers employment—but at extremely low wages, without explaining their fears that European factories will undercut them. The workers, outraged, go on strike. During the strike, Jem approaches Harry Carson on the street and asks him about his intentions toward Mary. When Harry refuses to answer, Jem prevents him from leaving. Harry whacks Jem with his cane, so Jem punches Harry. A policeman intervenes. Harry declines to press charges but threatens Mary as he leaves; Jem, in turn, threatens Harry if he hurts Mary.

Later, at a meeting between the factory owners and workers' representatives, the two sides fail to come to an agreement about wages. During the meeting, Harry Carson doodles a mocking **caricature** of the ragged, starving workers and throws it at the fire—but misses. One of the workers retrieves it later. The workers, John Barton included, are so outraged that the factory owners would mock their starvation that they decide to terrify the owners with an act of violence. They tear Harry's caricature into strips and mark one; whoever draws the marked strip will be the “assassin.”

Two days later, Will says goodbye to Mary—he plans to walk to

Liverpool and then sail to the Isle of Man to visit other relatives. When Mary suggests he travel partway with John, who is going to Glasgow via Liverpool on union business, Will admits that he's walking, not taking the train, because he's out of money. That evening, after John and Will both leave, Margaret comes crying to Mary's house and announces that Alice Wilson has just suffered a stroke. Later the same evening, Harry Carson's corpse is carried home by policeman—someone shot him in the head.

The following morning, Mary hears of Harry's murder and nearly faints. The police, who know about Jem's altercation with Harry, send an undercover officer to the Wilsons' house and ask Mrs. Wilson to identify a gun without telling her it was found at the crime scene. The unsuspecting Mrs. Wilson confirms that the gun belongs to Jem. The police arrest Jem at work.

Late Friday night, Esther knocks on a distraught Mary's door. Hiding her status as a sex worker, Esther tells Mary that she investigated the crime scene and found some **wadded shot** nearby with Mary's name written on it in Jem's handwriting. She has brought the wadded shot to Mary to protect her. Then, giving Mary a fake address, she quickly exits. Mary is too horrified to notice that Esther's behavior is strange: she recognizes that the wadded shot is made from the valentine that Jem sent her and that she repurposed to copy down a poem for her father. In that moment, she realizes that John killed Harry. Mary resolves to find an alibi to prove Jem's innocence without implicating her father. She learns from Margaret and Mrs. Wilson that Jem walked partway to Liverpool with Will the night of the murder. She decides to find Will after he comes back to Liverpool but before he ships out again; Will can testify that he was with Jem at the time of the murder.

Yet when Mary reaches Will's Liverpool address on Monday, Will's landlady tells her that his plans changed—he shipped out that morning. Mary rushes to the Liverpool docks, hires a small boat, and sails out after Will's ship, which can't leave the mouth of the river for open sea until high tide. When (with much shouting) the watermen in Mary's boat convey to the sailors aboard Will's ship what they want, Will appears and promises to return to Liverpool via the pilot-boat to testify—but it isn't clear whether he'll make it back in time.

The next morning in court, Mary is called to the stand. When the rude prosecuting attorney asks whether she liked Harry or Jem better, Mary announces that she loves Jem. After Mary descends from the stand, she begins to feel markedly unwell. When Will arrives, she screams that Jem is saved, then she has a seizure. Will testifies that he was with Jem when the murder took place, and Jem is acquitted.

While a delirious Mary convalesces in Liverpool, Jem figures out from her ravings that she knows her father killed Harry. (Jem had already figured it out because John Barton borrowed

the murder weapon from him, but he told no one because he didn't want to implicate Mary's father.) As Alice is dying from complications of her stroke, Jem travels back to Manchester to say goodbye and attend her funeral. After the funeral, Jem sees a wrecked-looking John Barton returning home from his "trip to Glasgow." Jem returns to Liverpool to see Mary, who is eventually cured of her delirium. After Mary and Jem take the train back to Liverpool, Mary lovingly tends to John Barton despite knowing he's a murderer, as he's very sick. Meanwhile, Jem is fired from his job because his coworkers don't want to work with a man who's been accused of murder.

One day, Mary returns home to find John confessing to Mr. Carson that he killed Harry. Mr. Carson announces that he plans to seek John's execution. John, recognizing Mr. Carson's suffering, throws himself at Mr. Carson's feet and begs forgiveness. Mr. Carson storms out. Yet rather than go to the police, he goes home and reads the Gospels. Later that night, Mary is tending to the sickly, dying John when Mr. Carson bursts in and holds John up to help him breathe. John dies. Later, Job and Jem receive a letter from Mr. Carson asking them to visit him. During the visit, Mr. Carson asks them why John killed Harry. Job explains that the employers' lack of humane, Christian care for their suffering workers drove John insane. Mr. Carson devotes the rest of his life to improving working conditions in Manchester.

Shortly after John's funeral, Mary gets a visit from her extremely sick aunt Esther, who later dies at home. Afterward, Jem and Mary get married and immigrate to Canada with Mrs. Wilson. In Canada, no one knows that Jem was once accused of murder; he and Mary live happily and have a son named Johnnie. One day, they receive a letter announcing Margaret and Will's engagement. Will plans to bring Job and Margaret with him to visit Mary and Jem on his next voyage to North America.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Mary Barton – Golden-haired, blue-eyed Mary Barton is daughter to John Barton and Mrs. Barton and the niece to Esther. A high-spirited girl, Mary decides young that she wants to use her beauty to marry out of working-class poverty and become a "lady." She strikes up a flirtation with mill owner's son Harry Carson, assuming that he'll marry her. She is too naïve, however, to realize that Harry only seeks to "ruin" her. When Mary's childhood friend Jem Wilson, who has loved her for years, proposes, she rejects him—only to realize too late that she loves Jem, not Harry. Mary breaks off her flirtation with Harry and waits for Jem to propose again. Shortly after, Harry is murdered with Jem's gun, and Jem is arrested. When Esther brings Mary the **wadded shot** used in the fatal encounter,

Mary recognizes the paper as a valentine from Jem that she repurposed to write out a poem for her father—meaning her father killed Harry. Mary burns the wadded shot, resolving to absolve Jem without implicating her father. She chases down and secures Jem’s alibi in the form of Will Wilson, a sailor who was with Jem at the time of the murder. At Jem’s trial, Mary declares her love for Jem, and Will’s testimony gets Jem acquitted. After the trial is over and guilt-sick John Barton has died, Mary and Jem marry and move to Canada with Mrs. Wilson, where they eventually have a son named Johnnie.

John Barton – John Barton is husband to Mrs. Barton and father to Mary Barton. A intelligent and strong-willed working-class Manchester man, he hates the rich because his baby son Tom starved to death during an economic downturn and no well-off person even tried to help the family. After his wife Mrs. Barton dies in childbirth, a grieving John throws himself into labor organizing and radical politics. During a severe economic downturn, he participates in a petition to Parliament to help working-class families. When the petition fails, he becomes even grimmer and more pessimistic. During a strike, after mill owner’s son Harry Carson draws a mocking **caricature** of the starving workers’ representatives, John and some other men resolve to terrify the employers with a murder. They draw lots to decide who will commit the murder. After John draws the murderers’ lot, he borrows a gun from Jem Wilson, shoots Harry to death one night, and briefly disappears. After committing the murder, John Barton is so guilty he is passively suicidal, wanting to die. He eventually confesses his guilt to Harry Carson’s father Mr. Carson and begs his forgiveness. Though Mr. Carson at first wants John executed, he ends up reading his family Bible and deciding to let the ailing John die at home. After John’s death, his friend Job Legh concludes that John was driven to homicidal madness by the lack of empathy or Christian charity the rich show the poor.

Jem (James) Wilson – Jem Wilson, son of Mr. George Wilson and Mrs. Wilson, nephew to Alice Wilson, is a passionate, brave, guileless young man who has been in love with Mary Barton since childhood. Early in the novel, he proves his bravery by saving his father and another trapped worker from Mr. Carson’s burning mill. After Mr. Wilson dies, Jem becomes his family’s breadwinner. Upon receiving a promotion at work, he decides that he is financially able to support a wife and proposes to Mary. When she refuses him, he begs her to reconsider, claiming—rather disturbingly—that Mary’s rejection could turn him into an alcoholic or a murderer. When she still refuses him, he flees—too quickly to hear Mary, who has just realized she loves him after all, calling after him. Shortly after, out of nowhere, he is approached by Mary’s estranged aunt Esther, who begs him to protect Mary from “ruination” by mill owner’s son Harry Carson. When Jem approaches Harry to ascertain whether Harry’s intentions are honorable, the young men get into a physical altercation. Shortly thereafter, Harry is

shot with Jem’s gun. Jem refuses to tell the police that he lent the gun to John Barton because he doesn’t want to implicate Mary’s father. During Jem’s trial, Mary proclaims her love for him. After Jem is acquitted due to an alibi provided by Will Wilson, he and Mary get married and immigrate to Canada with Mrs. Wilson, where they have a son named Johnnie.

Harry Carson – Harry Carson is son to mill owner Mr. Carson and his wife Mrs. Carson and brother to Sophy Carson, among other sisters. Perhaps because his entire family dotes on him, handsome Harry grows up vain, self-centered, and rather thoughtless. He conducts a flirtation with working-class Mary Barton without intending to marry her—either not knowing or not caring what happens to “ruined” girls in Victorian England. When Mary realizes that she loves Jem Wilson and breaks off her flirtation with Harry, Harry—desperate to possess Mary and unwilling to believe she doesn’t secretly care for him—offers to marry her but admits he’d never considered doing so before. This admission shocks naïve Mary, who hadn’t realized that Harry intended to ruin her. Even after Mary refuses to see Harry, he continues to pester her both in person and through an accomplice, Mary’s coworker Sally Leadbitter. Meanwhile, during a meeting between employers and employees during a strike, Harry draws a rather callous **caricature** of the ragged, starving workers’ representatives. When the workers discover the abandoned caricature, they are so outraged by Harry’s mockery of their starvation that they decide to murder him to terrify the employer class. Ultimately, John Barton shoots Harry to death with Jem Wilson’s borrowed gun.

Esther – Esther is sister to Mrs. Barton, sister-in-law to John Barton, and aunt to Mary Barton. A pretty, strong-willed factory worker, Esther “disappears” when Mary is 13 years old. In fact, Esther has run off with an army officer who has promised to marry her. The army officer doesn’t marry Esther but does impregnate her. After three years of cohabitation, the officer abandons Esther when he is stationed abroad in Ireland. Eventually impoverished, Esther turns to sex work to buy medicine when her daughter gets sick. Her daughter dies anyway. Esther, poor and devastated, becomes a homeless alcoholic sex worker. She moves back to Manchester and spies on her family from afar. When she learns of Mary’s flirtation with Harry Carson, she becomes convinced that Harry will “ruin” Mary as the army officer “ruined” Esther herself. Esther approaches John Barton to warn him, but John—who blames the shock of Esther’s disappearance for Mrs. Barton’s subsequent death in childbirth—refuses to listen to her. Esther then approaches Jem. After Jem is arrested for Harry’s murder, Esther goes to the scene of the crime, finds the **wadded shot** used in the gun, and brings it to Mary rather than the police. Mary, who realizes that the wadded shot could prove her father John was the murderer, burns it. Esther subsequently vanishes, appearing only at the novel’s end, delirious and confused, to die

in Mary's home.

Margaret – Margaret, granddaughter to Job Legh, is a plain young woman with a beautiful singing voice who is going progressively blind from cataracts. She becomes good friends with Mary Barton after Alice Wilson introduces them, in part because Mary appreciates Margaret's robust common sense. When Margaret can no longer sew due to her progressive blindness, she becomes a professional singer to support herself and her grandfather; in hard times, she also gives money to the Bartons for food. She judges Mary very harshly when she first learns of Mary's flirtation with Harry Carson—not beautiful herself, Margaret doesn't understand or empathize with the temptations of flirtation and vanity. Yet when Mary tells Margaret she knows she behaved wrongly and begs for Margaret to temper her judgment with mercy, Margaret quickly forgives her. Several years after the main events of the story, Margaret undergoes a successful surgery to remove her cataracts, restoring her vision; she also becomes engaged to Will Wilson, a sailor who fell in love with her upon hearing her beautiful singing voice.

Mr. Carson – Mr. Carson, husband to Mrs. Carson and father to Harry Carson, Sophy Carson, and other daughters, is a mill owner in Manchester. Though Mr. Carson comes from a working-class background, he is hard and unempathetic with his employees. When his mill burns down in an accident, he decides to keep the mill closed while he modernizes the equipment, leaving his former employees out of work in a bad economy. During a strike protesting extremely low wages the mill and factory owners have offered their workers to fulfill a big manufacturing order, Mr. Carson decides he won't be "bullied" into accepting any of the worker's demands—ignoring that the workers' demands come from the workers' real material suffering. After his only son Harry Carson is murdered, he becomes obsessed with revenge and nearly succeeds in pressuring the courts to speedily arrest, try, and execute the (innocent) Jem Wilson. When a dying John Barton confesses that he murdered Harry to Mr. Carson and begs Mr. Carson's forgiveness, Mr. Carson at first wants revenge and a public execution, but after reading the Christian Gospels, he ends up allowing John to die at home. After John's death, Mr. Carson has a long conversation with Jem Wilson and Job Legh about John's motives for the murder. After Job convinces Mr. Carson that the employers' lack of empathy for the working class drove John violently insane, Mr. Carson becomes devoted to improving working conditions and class relations in Manchester.

Job Legh – Job Legh, grandfather to Margaret, is a "little wiry-looking old man" obsessed with natural science and collecting specimens such as scorpions and flying fish. After Margaret and Mary Barton form a close friendship, Job becomes a friend to Mary and John Barton. Though Job initially believes that Jem Wilson is guilty of Harry Carson's murder, he agrees to help

Mary find an alibi for Jem. He also finds Jem a lawyer, Mr. Bridgnorth. Unlike John Barton, Job is antipathetic to unions and labor organizing, but after John's death, Job is still able to provide a curious Mr. Carson with such an eloquent defense of John's point of view and motives for murdering Harry Carson that Mr. Carson subsequently devotes himself to improving labor conditions and class relations in Manchester.

Will Wilson – Will Wilson is godson to Alice Wilson and childhood friend to Jem Wilson and Mary Barton. A cheerful, enthusiastic, and honorable young man, Will falls in love with Mary's plain friend Margaret after hearing Margaret's beautiful singing voice while he's visiting Alice on shore leave from his job as a sailor. The night that Harry Carson is murdered, Will walks to Liverpool, from which he intends to sail to the Isle of Man to visit relatives before shipping out as a sailor again. Jem accompanies Will part of the way; as such, Will is Jem's alibi for Harry's murder. Because Will doesn't know about the murder or Jem's need for an alibi, Mary has to take a train to Liverpool and boat down the river as Will's ship is sailing away to inform him he needs to appear in court. Due to Will's testimony, Jem is acquitted. Several years later, Will gets engaged to Margaret.

Alice Wilson – Elderly, unwed Alice Wilson is aunt to Jem Wilson, godmother to Will Wilson, and family friend to Mary and John Barton. A medicine woman with wide knowledge of herbs, Alice is also deeply religious, taking everything that happens to her as God's will and simply praying for patience and endurance. Early in the novel, she introduces Mary to Margaret, sparking the two girls' close friendship. The same night that Harry Carson is murdered, Alice has a massive stroke. She survives for more than a week afterward, but she believes she is a child again. Her peaceful and Christian reminiscences touch everyone who visits her sickroom. Shortly after Jem's trial, she dies.

Mrs. Wilson – Wife to Mr. George Wilson and mother to Jem Wilson, Mrs. Wilson is peevish in small matters but open-hearted in large ones. She suffered a factory accident in her youth that left her with permanent pain and a bad temper. She is frequently spiteful to Mary Barton because she resents Mary for spurning her beloved Jem, who she believes is too good for Mary. Yet once Mary realizes she loves Jem and the two plan to marry, Mrs. Wilson has a change of heart: she comes to love Mary as her own daughter and treats her with uncharacteristic tact and tenderness. When Mary and Jem immigrate to Canada, Mrs. Wilson accompanies them.

Sally Leadbitter – Sally Leadbitter, a "plain, red-haired, freckled girl," is Mary Barton's coworker at Miss Simmonds's seamstress business. Sally is friendly but immodest, romance-obsessed, and occasionally malicious. Her main redeeming quality is her love and care for her invalid mother. She serves as a go-between in Mary's flirtation with factory-owner Harry Carson. Aware—as Mary is not—that Harry wants to "ruin" Mary rather than marry her, Sally entertains herself by wondering whether

Harry will “win” and ruin Mary, or Mary will “win” and ensnare Harry in marriage. Her friendship with Mary deteriorates when Mary breaks off her flirtation with Harry. After Harry’s murder, however, Sally becomes intensely curious about Mary as the quasi-“heroine” of a public trial—much to Mary’s chagrin.

Bessy Witter/Mrs. Carson – Mrs. Carson is wife to Mr. Carson and mother to Harry Carson, Sophy Carson, and other daughters. Her maiden name was Bessy Witter. As a young working-class woman, she wanted to marry mill worker Mr. George Wilson, but George wouldn’t jilt his then-sweetheart Mrs. Wilson for her. She was once a factory girl but became a rich woman when the man she married, the formerly working-class Mr. Carson, succeeded in business and became a mill owner.

The Old Boatman/Ben Sturgis – Along with his wife Mrs. Sturgis, Ben Sturgis—a kindly old Liverpool boatman—gives Mary Barton shelter when she loses the address of the place she was supposed to stay in Liverpool during Jem Wilson’s trial for murder. He and his wife also provide Mary with a place to convalesce after she has a seizure and collapses at Jem’s trial.

Mrs. Sturgis – Mrs. Sturgis, wife of Liverpool boatman Ben Sturgis, gives Mary Barton shelter after Mary loses the address of the place she was supposed to stay in Liverpool during Jem Wilson’s trial for murder. She and her husband also provide Mary with a place to convalesce after she has a seizure and collapses at Jem’s trial.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Mr. George Wilson – Mr. George Wilson is father to Jem Wilson, husband to Mrs. Wilson, and good friend to John Barton, though he is less intelligent and better-tempered than John. He dies suddenly during an economic downturn, leaving Jem to support Mrs. Wilson and his aunt Alice Wilson.

Charley Jones – Charley Jones is the son of Mrs. Jones, Will Wilson’s landlady in Liverpool. An energetic and mischievous boy who wants to become a sailor, Charley tells Mary Barton to go after Will’s departing ship so that she can inform him he must provide Jem Wilson’s alibi for murder.

Mrs. Davenport – Mrs. Davenport is the poor wife of one of Mr. George Wilson’s unemployed former coworkers. After her husband dies of typhoid, she shows her gratitude for the help Mr. Wilson and John Barton give her family by repeatedly helping Mrs. Wilson and Alice Wilson in times of difficulty.

Sophy Carson – The most sensible and spirited of Harry Carson’s sisters, Sophy is the one to tell her father Mr. Carson that Harry has been murdered after the servants are too frightened to tell him themselves.

Miss Simmonds – Miss Simmonds is a seamstress who hires Mary Barton first as an apprentice and then as a paid employee. She also employs Sally Leadbitter, among other young women.

Mrs. Barton – Wife to John Barton and mother to Mary Barton, Mrs. Barton dies in childbirth when Mary is 13, shortly after Mrs. Barton’s sister Esther disappears. John blames Mrs. Barton’s death on the shock of Esther’s disappearance, which leads him to treat Esther very harshly when she reappears in Manchester.

Mr. Bridgnorth – Mr. Bridgnorth, a lawyer, represents Jem Wilson after Jem is accused of murdering Harry Carson.

Mrs. Jones – Mrs. Jones is Will Wilson’s landlady in Liverpool.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



EMPLOYERS VS. WORKERS

In *Mary Barton*, class conflict between capitalist employers and the workers they employ does not stem from economic principles or divergent class interests. Rather, the novel argues that employers’ and workers’ interests are intimately bound together—but that employers nevertheless alienate and embitter workers by failing to communicate appropriately with them.

Set in the first half of the 19th century in the English manufacturing town of Manchester, *Mary Barton* focuses on the conditions and effects of factory work during an economic downturn. The factory owners fear that clients will only buy from the factories that produce goods at the lowest cost. Therefore, the Manchester employers offer their workers extremely low wages in hopes of producing the goods at the lowest cost; according to their reasoning, this strategy will allow both employers and workers to make at least *some* money—whereas if another factory in Europe produces the order at lower cost, no one in Manchester will earn anything. At least in the employers’ view, then, it is in both the workers’ and the employers’ interest for the workers to temporarily accept lowered wages. Yet the employers never communicate to the workers the potential competition from European factories or the reasoning behind the lowered wages. Understandably, the workers see the offer of extremely low wages as exploitative, and so they go on strike. Even during the strike, the employers refuse to explain their original reasoning, believing that workers should simply obey them. This arrogant failure to communicate leads to ongoing striking and, eventually, a murder. Thus, *Mary Barton* attributes class conflict between employers and workers not to any kind of inherent tension or single economic principle, but to employers’ personal failings: arrogance, stubbornness, short-sightedness, and failures of

compassion.



SEXUALITY AND DANGER

Mary Barton represents sexuality as fundamentally dangerous—especially to women, but also to working-class men. The novel opens with a discussion of Esther, a young factory worker who has disappeared from her lodging house. Her brother-in-law John Barton immediately assumes that Esther has become embroiled in a premarital romance and will likely end up a sex worker. Subsequent revelations prove him right: Esther has eloped with an army officer who has promised to marry her. He fails to make good on his promise, impregnates her anyway, and eventually abandons her when the army stations him overseas. As a working-class woman with limited economic opportunities and no access to free childcare, Esther is eventually forced into sex work. Then her baby dies, and she becomes an alcoholic to deal with her grief and shame. Esther's tragic story hammers home that any premarital sexual activity came with extreme risk in the 19th century, especially for working-class women. Moreover, later events in the novel suggest that sexuality is dangerous not only to young working-class women but to the working-class men around them. After John's daughter Mary Barton engages in a brief flirtation with the pushy manufacturing heir Harry Carson, her working-class suitor (and eventual true love) Jem Wilson is arrested and nearly executed on circumstantial evidence for Harry's murder. Many characters around Mary blame her flirtatiousness for Jem's near execution, suggesting that in this society, flirtation itself can put disenfranchised people in harm's way. And even though Harry's murder in fact had nothing to do with his pursuit of Mary, the narrative does seem to hint that if working-class women stray from strict sexual propriety under these societal circumstances, it might impel working-class men to desperate acts or put them in legal danger through no fault of their own. Thus, the novel makes the (now quite dated) implication that any premarital sexuality is a threat not only to people's souls but to their very lives.



CHRISTIANITY

In *Mary Barton*, Christian religious virtues such as faith, hope, and love are presented as necessary to a good life and death. Without these virtues, characters go astray, sin, and suffer. For example, Manchester factory worker John Barton loses his religious faith due to the disjunction between the teachings he reads in the Bible and the way the so-called "Christians" around him behave, since these people seem to tolerate glaring forms of inequality. When John's baby son, Tom, dies of illness and starvation during an economic downturn, John becomes hopeless and embittered. He can no longer feel Christian love toward members of the rich employer class, whom he feels could help poor workers but

don't. During a subsequent workers' strike, John becomes so loveless and enraged at the employer class's behavior that he murders Harry Carson, the only son of the major manufacturer Mr. Carson. In turn, he ends up inflicting upon Mr. Carson the same horrific grief he himself suffered when Tom died. It is only when John realizes that he has committed an evil sin, confesses to the crime, recognizes that Mr. Carson loved Harry as he loved Tom, and begs Mr. Carson's forgiveness that his blighted life is even partially redeemed. Thus, *Mary Barton* suggests that adhering to Christian-inflected virtues is a path to peace and happiness, whereas deviating from these virtues leads to misery.



POVERTY AND MORALITY

Mary Barton represents poor people as more likely to act in moral ways than rich people—not because poor people have inherently better moral instincts, but because they are more likely to encounter, recognize, and thus react to others' needs. Throughout the novel, working-class characters see one another in distress and respond by giving generous aid. For instance, Margaret, a working-class girl with worsening cataracts, sews mourning clothes for an impoverished new widow for free even though the work hurts her eyes. Similarly, factory worker John Barton pawns his few valuables to buy food for his sick former coworker's starving children. Another example is Mrs. Sturgis, a boatman's wife who offers Mary Barton a bed for the night despite suspecting (in a disapproving way) she's a sex worker. Over and over, then, poor and working-class characters help one another as a matter of course. By contrast, rich characters who are removed from regular contact with the needy assume that they can do nothing to help—and so they do nothing. For example, factory owner Mr. Carson assumes and explicitly argues that he can't help his workers during economic downturns because he doesn't control the demand for goods and thus for labor; he never considers that he could simply and directly give the starving working-class families around him his own food or money, the way these families share food or money with each other whenever possible. Thus, *Mary Barton* argues that poor people are likely to perform more good deeds than rich people simply because they have more social contact with their needy neighbors and, as a result, see their neighbors' problems as practical, solvable issues.



EMPATHY VS. IGNORANCE

In *Mary Barton*, empathy springs from knowledge: when people understand the facts of one another's situations, they empathize with and help one another. By contrast, when people don't understand one another's situations, they are more likely to be unsympathetic, callous, cruel, or simply indifferent. Thus, the novel implies that people have a moral duty to be curious about one another's

lives. Frequently in the novel, one character will be hostile or cruel to another solely because they are ignorant of a relevant piece of information. For example, when Mary Barton receives a visit from her aunt Esther, she feels estranged from Esther due to Esther's long, unexplained absence, an estrangement intensified when Esther, a homeless sex worker, lies and tells Mary she's happily married far across town. Though Esther is desperate to warn Mary against the blandishments of rich suitor Harry Carson, she keeps Mary ignorant of her real reasons for wanting to help: she herself was seduced, "ruined," and abandoned by a charming army officer. But because Mary doesn't know this, she is subtly hostile to Esther, drives her away, and forgets about her for a large section of the book. Yet as soon as Mary's beloved, Jem Wilson, reveals to her the true facts of Esther's situation, Mary—counter to Esther's fear that the truth would repel Mary—immediately wants to find and help her aunt. By the time Mary does encounter Esther again, however, it's too late: Esther is already close to death. Had Mary been more curious about Esther's life earlier, this outcome might have been avoided. The relationship between Esther and Mary suggests that understanding is crucial to empathy and that, as such, people ought to be appropriately and sympathetically curious about one another's lives.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



CARICATURE

In *Mary Barton*, the caricature that mill owner's son Harry Carson draws of starving workers' representatives symbolizes employers' lack of empathy toward their working-class employees—and vice versa. The caricature first appears in the novel during a strike, when the mill and factory owners meet with the representatives of the starving workers to try to come to an agreement about acceptable wages. Harry, the wealthy son of a mill owner, sketches the caricature of the ragged, starving workers' representatives, writes a quotation from William Shakespeare's *Henry IV, Part I* (c. 1597) on it, and passes it around to the other mill and factory owners to amuse them. This incident shows the employers' lack of empathy for their starving employees: they see the working men not as fellow human beings but as objects of laughter or as pitiable minor characters in a Shakespeare play.

When the workers find the discarded caricature—Harry throws it at the fire and misses—they are desperate and outraged. They are unable to see Harry as he really is: one young, thoughtless, and occasionally cruel human being. Instead, they see him as a distillation of every employer who has exploited

them and all the suffering they have undergone as a result. The outraged workers decide to murder Harry to terrify the employer class. They tear up the caricature, mark one strip, and then draw strips to determine who will carry out the murderer. Thus, while the caricature initially represents the employers' lack of empathy toward their employees, it comes to represent the workers' violent dehumanization of the employer class in response to that original lack of empathy.



WADDED SHOT

In *Mary Barton*, the wadded shot used in the gun that kills Harry Carson symbolizes Mary Barton's confused loyalties to Harry, her father John Barton, and her true love Jem Wilson. The paper that will eventually be repurposed as the wadded shot first appears when John Barton asks his daughter Mary to copy down a poem by the radical dialect poet Samuel Bamford (1788–1872). Mary has been flirting with mill owner's son Harry Carson and ignoring working-class Jem Wilson, who loves her; as such, she uses the blank part of a valentine Jem sent her to copy down the poem and gives it to her father—showing her lack of interest in Jem's romantic overtures and her current loyalty to Harry. By the time the paper makes its reappearance, Mary has realized she loves Jem, not Harry—yet unfortunately, Harry has been murdered and Jem arrested for the crime.

When Mary's estranged aunt Esther finds the wadded shot near the crime scene, she brings it to Mary rather than the police because she sees Mary's name and address on the paper and fears it will implicate her niece. Upon seeing the wadded shot, a horrified Mary realizes that Jem didn't kill Harry—her father did, because he was the last one in possession of the valentine repurposed for the Bamford poem. Mary burns the wadded shot, even though she knows it could save the boy she loves, because it implicates her father in a hanging crime. When Mary burns the wadded shot, it shows her determination to remain loyal to her father and to absolve Jem in some other way, symbolizing how John's violent radicalism forces Mary to divide her loyalties between her family and her romantic life.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Wordsworth edition of *Mary Barton* published in 2012.

Chapter 1 Quotes

“Not but what beauty is a sad snare. Here was Esther so puffed up that there was no holding her in.”

Related Characters: John Barton (speaker), Esther, Mr. George Wilson

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 8

Explanation and Analysis

John Barton is talking about his young sister-in-law Esther to his best friend, Mr. George Wilson. Esther has recently disappeared, and John speculates that she has become involved in some socially ruinous romantic entanglement. He describes Esther's beauty as a "snare"—that is, a trap—because it made her "puffed up," arrogant, and therefore difficult to "hold[...] in" or control. John's attitude toward Esther, which the novel represents as more or less normal and sensible, introduces the fearful and sometimes misogynistic attitude of many of the novel's Victorian characters toward sexuality, especially female sexuality.

First, John implies that romantic entanglements are inherently bad: because beauty may make it more likely that a girl will have opportunities for romance, beauty is a "snare" or trap, something dangerous. Second, John assumes that young women like Esther ought to be "held in" or controlled by male heads of household like John himself; young women who rebel against male domestic authority imperil both the social order and themselves, John implies.

While John's comments about Esther may sound noxiously sexist to modern readers, the novel's subsequent events largely support his perspective: Esther ends up a homeless, alcoholic, self-loathing sex worker who dies an early death because she ran away with the man she loved, who promised to marry her but didn't. Thus, from its opening scenes, the novel casts female sexuality and romantic entanglements as inherently dangerous unless monitored and controlled by responsible men.

💬 "I tell you it's the poor, and the poor only, as does such things for the poor. Don't think to come over me with th' old tale that the rich know nothing of the trials of the poor; I say, if they don't know, they ought to know."

Related Characters: John Barton (speaker), Mr. George Wilson

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 10

Explanation and Analysis

When John Barton's friend Mr. Wilson comments with amusement on John's longstanding dislike of rich people, an annoyed John snaps that rich people have never done anything to make him like them: they have never helped him when he or his children were suffering from the effects of poverty (starvation, lack of heat, and so on), even though they have the means to do so. He announces that "it's the poor, and the poor only, as does such things for the poor"—meaning that only poor people give material aid to other poor people—and that the rich "ought to know" the troubles of the poor.

This quotation introduces two important themes in the novel: the practical morality of the poor and the moral obligation to be curious about other people. First, John argues that, contrary to what one might expect, the people with the fewest material resources to help others—poor people—are actually the ones who most often help others. The rest of the novel largely supports John's claim: throughout, poor and working-class characters give their starving neighbors food or money to buy food, nurse their sick neighbors during illnesses, and comfort their grieving neighbors however they can. By contrast, the rich characters for the most part demonstrate concern only for themselves and their immediate families. Thus, the novel suggests that poor people are quicker to recognize and respond to the suffering of others than the rich.

Second, John denies that rich people's ignorance of poor people's suffering excuses their failure to help the poor. This denial suggests that, precisely because responding helpfully to someone else's suffering requires knowing about them, people "ought" to be curious about and find out about the suffering of others.

Chapter 3 Quotes

💬 So with this consciousness she had early determined that her beauty should make her a lady; the rank she coveted the more for her father's abuse; the rank at which she firmly believed her lost Aunt Esther had arrived.

Related Characters: Mary Barton, John Barton, Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson, Esther

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 25

Explanation and Analysis

As working-class John Barton's daughter Mary grows up, she realizes from other people's reactions to her that she's

beautiful and decides to use her beauty to marry up, becoming a “lady.” The narrator claims that “her father’s abuse”—that is, John’s criticism of the rich and high-born—only makes Mary want to marry up “more.” Moreover, Mary is implicitly encouraged in her plot to marry up by the disappearance of her beautiful Aunt Esther, whom Mary “firmly believe[s]” made an advantageous marriage.

This quotation furthers the novel’s sexist depiction of romance and sexuality as dangerous in two ways. First, as John has correctly speculated, Esther has not married well—rather, she eloped with a man who promised to marry her but didn’t, and she subsequently became a homeless sex worker. By making the tragic “fallen woman” Esther a bad role model for young Mary, the novel suggests that female sexuality impropriety is dangerous and destructive not only for the woman who engages in it but also for other women and girls around the “sinful” woman who might be led astray by example.

Second, the novel portrays Mary’s beauty and interest in economically advantageous romance as leading her to defy her father: her father’s criticism of the rich not only fails to dissuade her from her plan but further motivates her. As the novel has already portrayed Esther’s defiance of patriarchal authority in her person of John as leading to her ruin, the echoes of Esther’s defiance in Mary’s attitude seem to promise trouble for Mary—and indeed, Mary’s flirtation with a rich young man, Harry Carson, nearly leads to the execution of her real love, Jem Wilson. Thus, the novel casts both female sexual activity and female defiance of male authority as bad and dangerous.

Chapter 5 Quotes

☞ “Every sorrow in her mind is sent for good.”

Related Characters: Margaret (speaker), Mary Barton, Alice Wilson

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 44-45

Explanation and Analysis

Mary Barton is talking with her friend Margaret about a recently widowed woman who is planning a relatively expensive funeral for her dead husband despite her family’s poverty. When Mary disapprovingly comments that their elderly, pious neighbor Alice Wilson wouldn’t grieve in such an ostentatious way, Margaret replies that Alice is a rare soul: “Every sorrow in her mind is sent for good.”

In the largely Christian context of Victorian England, the belief that every “sorrow” (or apparently negative event) “is sent for good” suggests a specifically religious reading: in Alice’s mind, God sends events that appear negative to effect “good” outcomes that human beings may not immediately perceive. The belief that apparently bad events have some good purpose allows people like Alice to cultivate Christian virtues like faith and trust in God, humility, and peacefulness.

While modern readers might worry that this belief would encourage oppressed people—like the exploited workers who are the novel’s central characters—to quietly accept their oppression as somehow “sent for good,” Mary and Margaret both take Alice as a Christian role model, suggesting that the novel sees Alice’s attitude as a commendable one and Christianity as a bedrock for virtuous living.

Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ The weekly drain of wages given for labour, useless in the present state of the market, was stopped. The partners had more leisure than they had known for years[.]

Related Characters: Mr. Carson

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 54

Explanation and Analysis

During an economic downturn in which demand for consumer goods has fallen sharply, a mill owned by Mr. Carson burns down. Due to the economic downturn, Mr. Carson and his partners decide to keep the mill closed while they make improvements, laying off the mill workers to save money on “wages given for labour” and enjoying the “leisure” time that the relative lack of business gives them.

Mary Barton often attributes class conflict between rich employers and working-class employees to employers’ personal failings, such as arrogance or callousness; only occasionally does the novel suggest that class conflict derives from structural factors such as the sharply divergent interests of employers and employees. In this quotation, however, both employers’ implied failings and divergent class interests are at play.

First, the employers feel that the mill closure is an opportunity for them to enjoy “more leisure”—failing to empathetically appreciate that “leisure” for them means

unemployment, poverty, and even starvation for their working-class employees. Second, the employers actually benefit economically from laying off their employees—they don't have to pay wages in a downturn while consumers aren't buying the goods the workers produce. Thus, in this moment, the novel implicitly admits that while some class conflict is due to employers' personal lack of empathy, other class conflict derives from real economic incentives that encourage employers not to consider the wellbeing of their employees.

☞ “Don ye think He’s the masters’ Father, too? I’d be loth to have ‘em for brothers.”

“Eh, John! donna talk so; sure there’s many and many a master as good or better nor us.”

“If you think so, tell me this. How comes it they’re rich, and we’re poor? I’d like to know that. Han they done as they’d be done by for us?”

Related Characters: John Barton, Mr. George Wilson (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 61–62

Explanation and Analysis

During an economic downturn in which many working-class employees of factories and mills have been laid off, John Barton and Mr. Wilson are trying to help the sick, impoverished family of one of Mr. Wilson’s unemployed former coworkers. When Mr. Wilson praises the religious faith of his sick coworker, who tried to comfort his wife by reminding her that God was their father, John ironically comments that God is also the Father of “the masters,” i.e. the employer class, whom John would “be loth to” have for brothers. When a shocked Mr. Wilson asserts that many employers must be “as good or better” than him and John, John retorts that income inequality disproves this assertion: if the rich had “done as they’d be done by”—that is, if they had treated others as they want to be treated—there wouldn’t be such distinct classes of rich and poor.

John’s comments serve two purposes in the novel. First, they castigate the rich in moral and religious terms. Christianity commands its followers to “do unto others as you would have them do unto you” (Matthew 7:12). Presumably, if rich people were poor and starving, they would want help—but the rich, nominally “Christian”

characters in the novel fail to help the poor and starving working classes in their city. Thus, through John, the novel draws attention to the moral and religious hypocrisy of the Christian rich in the novel—and, by implication, in real life.

Second, John’s blasphemous comments suggest that—though well versed in Christian doctrine—John is driven away from accepting Christian principles such as the brotherhood of all humanity as children of God precisely by the hypocrisy of rich “Christians.” Since the novel implies in various places that Christian virtue is the bedrock of a moral life, and since rich people’s hypocrisy damages John’s Christian beliefs, this scene suggests that rich people’s lack of generosity is partly to blame for John’s increasing irreligiosity and questionably moral actions.

☞ The coffee steamed upon the fire, and altogether the odours were so mixed and appetising that Wilson began to yearn for food to break his fast, which had lasted since dinner the day before. If the servants had known this, they would have willingly given him meat and bread in abundance; but they were like the rest of us, and not feeling hunger themselves, forgot it was possible another might.

Related Characters: Mr. Carson, Mr. George Wilson

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 63

Explanation and Analysis

Working-class Mr. Wilson has gone to his former employer Mr. Carson’s house to ask Mr. Carson to help his seriously ill former coworker. At this time, rich patrons of hospitals could give their employees “infirmity orders,” which would influence the hospital to treat the employees; by implication, Mr. Carson is a patron of a local hospital and can get treatment for the coworker. As a working-class man, Mr. Wilson enters Mr. Carson’s fancy house through the kitchen rather than the front door; while he waits for Mr. Carson to see him, he becomes extremely hungry, but none of the servants offer him anything to eat.

The servants’ failure to offer Mr. Wilson anything to eat emphasizes the novel’s idea that, in order for people to empathize with each other, they must have some sort of knowledge of what others are going through in the first place. The narrator states that the servants “would have willingly given [Mr. Wilson] meat and bread in abundance” if they had realized that the poor, unemployed man was

hungry—but because they themselves aren’t hungry, “they forgot it was possible” that Mr. Wilson might be. In other words, because they don’t know about Mr. Wilson’s suffering, they fail to imagine it or empathize with it.

The narrator refers to this failure of imagination as acting “like the rest of us”; in other words, the narrator is claiming that most people fail to notice the suffering of others if they aren’t suffering in a similar way. By implication, people don’t fail to help others because they are indifferent to others’ suffering but simply because they don’t notice it. It follows that, in the novel’s moral worldview, people have an obligation to try to find out about the suffering of others and alleviate it.

☝ “Tell me, Margaret,” said Mary, taking her apron down from her eyes, and looking at Margaret with eager anxiety, “what can I do to bring him back to me? Should I write to him?” “No,” replied her friend, “that would not do. Men are so queer, they like to have a’ the courting to themselves.”

Related Characters: Mary Barton, Margaret (speaker), Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 134

Explanation and Analysis

After rejecting Jem’s proposal of marriage, Mary belatedly realizes that she loves him. When her friend Margaret mentions Jem to her, she gives a mopey response. Margaret inquires further, and Mary eventually tells Margaret the whole story and asks her advice. Yet when Mary suggests that she might write Jem a letter, Margaret advises against it: “Men are so queer, they like to have a’ the courting to themselves”—a sentence that in contemporary English might read, “Men are so weird, they always want to be the pursuers, never the pursued.”

At this point, it is important to note that the novel’s plot hinges on Mary *not* confessing her love to Jem—at least until Jem, believing that Mary is in love with Harry Carson, asks Harry whether his intentions toward Mary are honorable and, when Harry won’t answer, gets into a public altercation with him that a policeman breaks up. The fight between Jem and Harry makes Jem the primary suspect after Harry is murdered, and Jem’s trial powers much of the novel’s plot. Yet, from a certain viewpoint, it would make perfect sense for Mary to tell Jem, who has proposed to her and been rejected, that she has changed her mind.

Thus, the novel must *rationalize* Mary’s silence about her feelings. It does so in two ways. First, prior to the above quotation, it claims that appropriate maidenly modesty keeps Mary silent. This rationalization pushes to an extreme the novel’s conservative sexual ideology: apparently, it would be too forward for a young woman simply to tell the man she wants to marry, and who wants to marry her, that she loves him. Interestingly, Margaret’s advice cuts against this prior sexual conservatism: she says that Mary should stay silent not because speaking out would be sexually immodest but because men are “queer,” i.e. weird, and don’t like it when women pursue them. The idea that male weirdness dictates female modesty undermines some of the novel’s earlier conservatism, indicating that the novel is, in a certain sense, conflicted about its own sexual politics.

Chapter 10 Quotes

☝ “How can I keep her from being such a one as I am; such a wretched, loathsome creature! She was listening just as I listened, and loving just as I loved, and the end will be just like my end. How shall I save her?”

Related Characters: Esther (speaker), Mary Barton, John Barton, Harry Carson, Mrs. Barton

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 117

Explanation and Analysis

After a long and mysterious absence, Esther—dressed in clothes that mark her as a sex worker—accosts John Barton on the street one night and tries to give him a warning regarding Mary. Yet John, who blames the shock of Esther’s disappearance for his wife Mrs. Barton’s death in childbirth shortly thereafter, refuses to listen to Esther, pushes her away, and leaves. Afterward, Esther nervously talks to herself, asking herself how she can “save” Mary from the terrible “end” or fate that Esther herself is suffering.

Esther’s monologue has two functions. First, it underscores that, according to the novel’s worldview, a terrible fate awaits girls and women who engage in premarital sexual activity or even in romantic entanglements not surveilled and controlled by their male heads of household. Esther is afraid for Mary solely because Mary has been flirting with a rich young man named Harry Carson on her walks home from work; Mary hasn’t told her father John because John hates rich people. Esther’s monologue suggests a direct line between this mildly rebellious flirtation and future sex work, which—according to Esther’s still-conservative

views—would render Mary “a wretched, loathsome creature.”

Second, however, Esther’s monologue underscores the pragmatic and altruistic morality that tends to characterize the novel’s poor and working-class characters. Though Esther considers herself “loathsome” and “wretched,” she still assumes she has the ability and the duty to take practical action to “save” Mary—a marked contrast to the hands-off approach of the novel’s rich characters to the suffering of others.

Chapter 11 Quotes

💡 What were these hollow vanities to her, now that she had discovered the passionate secret of her soul? She felt as if she almost hated Mr Carson, who had decoyed her with his baubles. [...] She had hitherto been walking in grope-light toward a precipice; but in the clear revelation of that past hour she saw her danger, and turned away resolutely and for ever.

Related Characters: Mary Barton, Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson, Esther

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 123

Explanation and Analysis

Jem Wilson has just proposed to Mary, and Mary, who has been planning to escape working-class poverty by marrying Harry Carson, has rejected him. Yet as soon as Jem leaves, Mary realizes that the material things marriage to Harry offers her are “hollow vanities” and mere “baubles,” i.e. worthless enticements—and that she loves Jem, not Harry.

When the narrator compares Mary’s flirtation with Harry to “walking in grope-light toward a precipice,” or in other words, wandering in the dark toward a cliff, the comparison insinuates that Mary was in mortal danger from her flirtation with Harry: falling off a cliff in the dark can kill a person. The novel will later reveal that Mary’s Aunt Esther engaged in a similar flirtation with a higher-class man, an army officer, which did not end with Esther “s[eeing] her danger” but rather with premarital cohabitation, pregnancy, abandonment, sex work, and ultimately Esther’s early death.

Thus, both in its figurative language of dangerous cliffs and in its implied parallel between Esther and Mary, the novel insists that Mary may have literally saved her own life by realizing “the passionate secret of her soul,” namely, her love for Jem and comparative distaste for Harry.

💡 For, be it remembered, she had the innocence, or the ignorance, to believe his intentions honourable; and he, feeling that at any price he must have her, only that he would obtain her as cheaply as he could, had never undeceived her[.]

Related Characters: Mary Barton, Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 126

Explanation and Analysis

Mary, having realized her love for working-class Jem, has decided to end her flirtation with rich young Harry Carson immediately. While at first she wants never to see Harry again, she eventually decides that she should meet him once more and apologize for leading him on. The narrator then explains that she feels she owes him an apology because she’s innocent or ignorant enough “to believe his intentions honourable”—in other words, she believes that Harry is pursuing her with the intention of marrying her. The narrator then says that Harry has “never undeceived” Mary, a statement that implies that Harry knows Mary thinks he intends marriage and has avoided telling her otherwise to manipulate her.

The narrator’s description of rich Harry’s attitude toward working-class Mary implies a parallel between the employer class’s exploitation of their employees and male sexual exploitation of women. The description is decidedly economic: Harry wants Mary “at any price” but also wants to “obtain her as cheaply as he could,” implying either that Harry sees Mary as a sexual consumer item or that he sees her as a sexual employee whom he wants to pay the lowest possible wage.

This dynamic—Harry wants to “have” Mary sexually without marrying her, which will materially harm her in a conservative Victorian culture that punishes female sexuality—suggests that, just as employers and employees sometimes have genuinely diverging and conflicting class interests, so Victorian men and women may have diverging and conflicting sexual interests due to the much greater social price women pay for having sex before marriage.

Chapter 14 Quotes

💡 To whom shall the outcast prostitute tell her tale? Who will give her help in the day of need? Hers is a leper sin, and all stand aloof dreading to be counted unclean.

Related Characters: Mary Barton, John Barton, Harry

Carson, Esther

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 149

Explanation and Analysis

Esther, having been ignored and shoved by John Barton when she tried to warn him about Mary's flirtation with Harry, is trying to figure out to whom else she can appeal to protect Mary from sexual ruin. In the middle of narrating Esther's frantic thoughts, the narrator pauses to ask rhetorical questions about and comment upon Esther's dilemma. This commentary subtly suggests that though Victorian society is nominally Christian, its treatment of sex workers like Esther fails to follow the example of Jesus Christ.

The narrator calls sex work a "leper sin." In various places in the biblical Old Testament, not only lepers but also people who touch lepers are "counted unclean"—and to be "unclean" is to be excluded from one's religious community. In the New Testament, one of Jesus Christ's major miracles, recounted in three of the four Gospels (Matthew 8:1–4, Mark 1:40–45, and Luke 5:12–16) is curing a man with leprosy so that he can reenter his religious and cultural community.

Thus, by calling sex work a "leper sin," the narrator is suggesting that just as Jesus Christ cured the leper, so Christians ought to be able to forgive and accept back into their communities repentant sex workers like Esther. Yet instead of doing this, nominal Christians "stand aloof" because they don't want to be seen as "unclean" or sinful by association. Despite the novel's sexual conservatism, then, it also critiques the hypocrisy of Victorian society's nominal Christianity that nevertheless treats people who have engaged in sex work as permanently beyond rehabilitation.

Page Number: 161

Explanation and Analysis

Here, the narrator is describing the reasons for a factory workers' strike in Manchester: the employer class has received a large manufacturing order but believes that "continental manufacturers" who produce goods more cheaply may undercut them, preventing either them or their workers from getting money for the order. Thus, the employers offer workers extremely "low wages" in hopes of producing the order cheaply—but they don't explain their fear of being undercut to the workers, who feel insulted and exploited by the low wages and so go on strike.

This quotation offers perhaps the clearest statement in the novel of its belief that class conflict derives from personal failings of employers and to some extent of working-class employees rather than from structural factors or genuinely diverging interests. According to the narrator, it is "want of mutual confidence"—i.e., a lack of trust between employers and employees—that causes both classes the "sorrow" of the strike.

The employers' lack of trust in their employees derives from arrogance: they feel that being asked to explain their low wage offers is tantamount to being "bullied" and "compelled," presumably because they feel that as employers, they have a right to order around the employee class. By contrast, the employees' lack of trust in their employers derives from their previous exploitation by employers combined with a lack of information: they assume that the low wages the employers are offering are part of a larger pattern of exploitation, not guessing the low wages have a particular reason behind them in this case. Thus, while each class mistrusts the other, the novel implicitly blames the employer class far more than the employees for the "sorrow" of the strike.

Chapter 15 Quotes

☛☛ So class distrusted class, and their want of mutual confidence wrought sorrow to both. The masters would not be bullied, and compelled to reveal why they felt it wisest and best to offer only such low wages; they would not be made to tell that they were even sacrificing capital to obtain a decisive victory over the continental manufacturers. And the workmen sat silent and stern with folded hands, refusing to work for such pay.

Related Themes:  

Chapter 16 Quotes

☛☛ While the men had stood grouped near the door, on their first entrance, Mr Harry Carson had taken out his silver pencil, and had drawn an admirable caricature of them—lank, ragged, dispirited and famine-stricken. Underneath he wrote a hasty quotation from the fat knight's well-known speech in Henry IV. He passed it to one of his neighbours, who acknowledged the likeness instantly, and by him it was sent round to others, who all smiled and nodded their heads.

Related Characters: Harry Carson

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 172

Explanation and Analysis

The Manchester mill and factory owners have arranged a meeting with workers' representatives in an attempt to end the workers' strike through bargaining. The domineering Harry Carson, who wants to refuse all the workers' demands, reveals his total lack of empathy for the starving workers through his mockery of them in caricature. The description of his mockery suggests that it derives from his class privilege: he draws the caricature with an expensive "silver pencil," and beneath the drawing he writes a quotation from William Shakespeare's *Henry IV, Part 1* (c. 1597), a highbrow literary allusion that shows off his presumably expensive education.

The speech that Harry quotes is likely that of "fat knight" Falstaff in *Henry IV, Part I's* Act IV, Scene 2, lines 11-49, in which Falstaff—who has taken bribes from men who want to avoid serving in the army and recruited poor men, drunks, and criminals instead—uses extremely vivid and insulting language to describe the lower-class men he has accepted into the army. The quotation implies that the poor Manchester strikers are like an army of drunks, criminals, and other supposedly despicable characters—though all the "famine-stricken" strikers want are wages high enough to support themselves and their families. Harry's willingness to mock and insult these starving men—and the amusement that the other factory and mill owners respond with—shows their unempathetic callousness in the face of the suffering of the poor.

☛ A number of pieces of paper (from the identical letter on which the caricature had been drawn that very morning) were torn up, and *one was marked*.

Related Characters: John Barton, Harry Carson

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 178

Explanation and Analysis

After the meeting between the factory owners and the

striking workers, one of the workers' representatives finds the mocking caricature that Harry Carson drew of them. At a subsequent workers' meeting, he shows it to the others. Harry's unempathetic mockery of the half-starved workers so incenses them that they decide to avenge themselves and terrify the employers by murdering Harry: they tear the caricature into strips, mark one, and each pull a strip. The man who selects the marked strip is designated Harry's murderer. When the workers use Harry's callous, unempathetic caricature to choose his murderer, it suggests that Harry's own lack of empathy is contagious: the workers have learned from his dehumanizing treatment of them to dehumanize and kill him.

The use of the word "marked," in the context of an impending murder, alludes to the Mark of Cain. In the Book of Genesis, Cain is the first murderer: he kills his brother Abel out of jealousy. In Genesis 4:15, after the murder, God places a mysterious mark on Cain that protects Cain from violent retribution for his crime but also identifies him as a murderer. This allusion has two functions. First, it reminds readers that murder is a sin in the Judeo-Christian context: the employers' lack of empathy for their employees has made their employees so desperate that they forget their religious commitments and lash out violently. Second, it foreshadows that Harry's murderer John Barton, like the biblical Cain, won't be executed for his crime but will bear the "mark" of it (psychologically and emotionally) for the rest of his life.

Chapter 18 Quotes

☛ To avenge his child's death, the old man lived on; with the single purpose in his heart of vengeance on the murderer. True, his vengeance was sanctioned by law, but was it the less revenge?

Are ye worshippers of Christ? or of Alecto?

Related Characters: Harry Carson , Mr. Carson

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 199

Explanation and Analysis

After Harry Carson's murder, his father Mr. Carson's "single purpose" in life is to get "vengeance on the murderer"—that is, to see the murderer killed (via legal execution) just as his son was killed. The narrator, through rhetorical questions, challenges the religious morality of Mr. Carson's desire for revenge—and implicitly condemns the death penalty. The

narrator's first rhetorical question, whether it is "the less revenge" to kill someone via legally "sanctioned" execution than by extrajudicial murder, implies that the answer is no: the death penalty is an act of revenge just as much as an extrajudicial murder would be. Thus, the death penalty is wrong in Christian terms.

The narrator's second rhetorical question, "Are ye worshipers of Christ? or Alecto?" pits Christian morality against pagan morality. In Matthew 5:38-40, Jesus Christ famously enjoins his followers not to strike back but to "turn the other cheek" if someone strikes them. By extrapolation, Christianity forbids violent revenge, encouraging nonviolent resistance, mercy, and forgiveness. By contrast, the ancient Greek goddess Alecto—one of the three goddesses known as the Furies, divinities of revenge—has the job of punishing mortal criminals by driving them insane. The contrast that the narrator draws between Christ and Alecto suggests that if the novel's readers are truly Christian, they will not morally sanction Mr. Carson's desire for violent revenge, which is a pagan and not a Christian behavior.

"a valentine sent to her by Jem Wilson" that she repurposed to write down a poem by radical labor reformer Samuel Bamford (1788-1872) at her father John Barton's request.

The actual history of the paper makes it a symbol for Mary's dangerously divided loyalties. Initially, she "did not treasure and hoard up" the valentine from Jem because she was engaged in a flirtation with Harry Carson—a flirtation that divided her loyalties between her working-class father John and her employer-class boyfriend Harry. This flirtation ultimately endangers Jem, whom Mary has since realized she loves, because police take Jem's love for Mary as a motive for him to murder Harry. Symbolically, by not "treasur[ing]" Jem's love for her from the get-go—by reusing his valentine and giving it to her father, the actual murderer—Mary has placed Jem at the scene of the crime.

The paper also symbolizes Mary's divided loyalties going forward: though she loves Jem and wants to clear him of suspicion, she doesn't want her beloved father John executed for murder. Thus, she ends up burning the paper that could prove her father committed the crime rather than Jem—protecting her father while keeping Jem in danger.

Chapter 22 Quotes

☝☝ The corner of stiff, shining, thick, writing paper she recognised as a part of the sheet on which she had copied Samuel Bamford's beautiful lines so many months ago—copied (as you perhaps remember) on the blank part of a valentine sent to her by Jem Wilson, in those days when she did not treasure and hoard up everything he had touched, as she would do now.

Related Characters: Mary Barton, John Barton, Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson, Esther

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 227

Explanation and Analysis

Mary's aunt Esther has brought her the makeshift wadding—the material that separates the gunpowder from the bullet in old-fashioned guns—from the scene of Harry's murder. Because the wadding was made from paper on which was written Mary's name in Jem Wilson's handwriting, Esther believes that it implicates both Mary and Jem in the murder investigation and wants to protect them from the police. In fact, Mary recognizes the paper as

☝☝ Gentle, reserved, and prudent herself, never exposed to the trial of being admired for her personal appearance [...] Margaret had no sympathy with the temptations to which loveliness, vanity, ambition, or the desire of being admired exposes so many; no sympathy with flirting girls, in short. Then, she had no idea of the strength of conflict between will and principle in some who were differently constituted from herself.

Related Characters: Mary Barton, Harry Carson, Margaret

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 233

Explanation and Analysis

Here, the narrator is describing Margaret's attitude toward Mary at their first meeting after Margaret has learned of Mary's flirtation with Harry Carson. Despite Margaret and Mary's close friendship, Margaret at first judges Mary very harshly—a judgment that emphasizes the importance of experiential knowledge to empathy in the novel's worldview.

In essence, the narrator claims that Margaret has "no sympathy" with Mary in this case because the two girls have

had very different life experiences. Because Margaret is not beautiful, she doesn't know what it's like to be tempted by "being admired for her personal appearance"; as such, she doesn't empathize with beautiful Mary's temptation to derive a sense of self-worth from Harry's attentions and compliments. (Note that, once again, the novel casts beauty and male attention as essentially dangerous to women because it exposes them to potentially sexual intrigue.)

Moreover, Margaret is "constituted" not to feel a "conflict between will and principle." In other words, it's natural to her personality to want to do the right thing. As such, she doesn't understand what it's like to be Mary, whose personality is such that she can understand in "principle" what the right thing is and still want to do something different. Thus, the novel suggests once again that knowing what others' lives are like is often central to empathizing with them—and that Margaret hasn't quite done the work to know what Mary's internal life is like.

Chapter 31 Quotes

☞ "I almost misdoubt thee, thou'rt so pretty. Well-a-well! It's the bad ones as have the broken hearts, sure enough; good folk never get utterly cast down, they've always gotten hope in the Lord; it's the sinful as bear the bitter, bitter grief in their crushed hearts, poor souls; it's them we ought, most of all, to pity and help."

Related Characters: Mrs. Sturgis (speaker), Mary Barton, The Old Boatman/Ben Sturgis

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 293

Explanation and Analysis

Mary has lost the address where she was supposed to stay in Liverpool. Luckily, a kindly boatman named Ben Sturgis notices her confused distress and takes her back to his house, where his wife Mrs. Sturgis cares for him. Mrs. Sturgis's commentary on Mary, while exemplifying Victorian misogynistic fear of female sexuality, nevertheless also models what the novel believes a Christian response to sexually sinful women to be.

When Mrs. Sturgis says that she "almost misdoubt[s]" (that is, fears or suspects) Mary because Mary is "so pretty," it implies that Mrs. Sturgis thinks that the young, beautiful, and visibly distressed Mary is probably a sex worker or another somehow sexually scandalous woman. Mrs. Sturgis's immediate inference from Mary's beauty to Mary

being one of "the bad ones" shows the way that many of the novel's Victorian characters fear female attractiveness and female sexuality as inherently dangerous and destructive to social order.

Yet despite Mrs. Sturgis's suspicions, she reasons that she owes "pity and help" to "the sinful" because the sinful need it most: only they suffer total despair, while all other Christians are able to "hope in the Lord." Through the prejudiced but ultimately sympathetic Mrs. Sturgis, the novel implies that Christianity requires people to be kind and helpful to sexual sinners rather than condemning and ostracizing them.

Chapter 32 Quotes

☞ I don't know that he exactly used the term vengeance in his thoughts; he spoke of justice, and probably thought of his desired end as such[.]

Related Characters: Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson, Mr. Carson

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 296

Explanation and Analysis

Here, the narrator—who occasionally comments on the novel's action from an unidentified first-person perspective—is describing Mr. Carson's restless night prior to Jem's trial for Harry Carson's murder. Though the narrator usually narrates in an omniscient fashion, accessing all characters' thoughts like a mind-reader, the narrator sarcastically pretends in this moment to find Mr. Carson's pre-trial thoughts opaque, using such phrases as "I don't know" and "probably" to describe whether Mr. Carson believes his "desired end" is "vengeance" or "justice." The narrator's sarcasm implies that Mr. Carson ought to know that he is pursuing vengeance, not justice, but that he is self-censoring not only when he speaks but even "in his thoughts" to avoid facing up to the unchristian reality of his desires.

By using sarcasm to suggest that Mr. Carson is self-deceived, pretending even to himself that he wants justice when he really wants revenge, the narrator indirectly challenges readers to examine their own consciences: if readers think that Mr. Carson's desire to see his son's murderer is legitimate, is that out of a concern for justice—or out of mere vengefulness?

Chapter 34 Quotes

☞ “You’ve set up heroine on your own account, Mary Barton. How did you like standing witness?”

Related Characters: Sally Leadbitter (speaker), Mary Barton, Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 333

Explanation and Analysis

After Mary returns from Liverpool to Manchester following her testimony at Jem’s trial and her subsequent illness, her superficial, romance-obsessed coworker Sally Leadbitter—who formerly served as a go-between in Mary’s flirtation with Harry Carson—shows up at Mary’s house, calls her a “heroine,” and asks her how she “like[d] standing witness.”

When Sally calls Mary a “heroine,” it’s a metafictional, fourth-wall-breaking moment: after all, Mary literally is the titular heroine of the novel *Mary Barton*. Yet Mary reacts with disgust to Sally’s casting of her as a romantic heroine at the trial in which her true love Jem stands accused of murdering her former partner in flirtation Harry. She is especially disgusted by the idea that she might have “like[d]” the attention of being the event’s protagonist.

Here, the novel is using “bad” Sally, who loves the idea of flirtation and publicity, as a foil to contrast with the flawed but “good” Mary: though Mary may have flirted with Harry Carson, she only did so because she thought they were going to get married, and she has no desire to flaunt her own beauty to the public at a trial. According to the novel’s (sexist) logic, Mary deserves to be its heroine despite her flaws because she is essentially a modest girl who doesn’t desire or seek “heroine” status, whereas Sally is consigned to a semi-villainous minor character because she’s interested in being a romantic protagonist, an attitude that the novel characterizes as fundamentally sinful and dangerous.

Chapter 35 Quotes

☞ The eyes of John Barton grew dim with tears. Rich and poor, masters and men, were then brothers in the deep suffering of the heart; for was not this the very anguish he had felt for little Tom, in years so long gone by that they seemed like another life!

Related Characters: John Barton, Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson, Mr. Carson

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 341

Explanation and Analysis

John Barton has summoned Mr. Carson to his home and confessed that he, not Jem Wilson, murdered Mr. Carson’s son Harry. When Mr. Carson vocally expresses his “anguish” over his son’s death, John Barton abruptly realizes that the employer class and the working class are “brothers in the deep suffering of the heart,” because Mr. Carson’s grief reminds him intensely over his own grief for his baby son Tom, who died of starvation during an economic downturn.

This realization marks a major turning point for John’s character. Previously, John wanted to deny that “masters and men,” i.e. employers and employees, were “brothers” in the Christian sense—all children of God and thus all equal under God—because he so deeply resented the failure of employers to give practical, material aid to their suffering employees during economic downturns. In particular, he bitterly resented that no employer or other rich man gave his family food when his baby son Tom was starving. Thus, prior to this point, John’s memories of Tom prevented him from recognizing rich people as “brothers,” from empathizing with them, or even from seeing them as fellow “suffering” human beings.

Once John realizes that Mr. Carson’s pain is like his pain, however—once he realizes that Mr. Carson feels the same grief over his dead son that John felt over Tom—he is able to use their shared experience to empathize deeply with Mr. Carson, thus making him feel even guiltier for having murdered Harry.

☞ “Let my trespasses be unforgiven, so that I may have vengeance for my son’s murder.”

Related Characters: Mr. Carson (speaker), John Barton, Harry Carson, Job Legh

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 342

Explanation and Analysis

John Barton has just summoned Mr. Carson to his house, confessed that he was the one who murdered Mr. Carson’s son Harry, and thrown himself at Mr. Carson’s feet begging

for forgiveness. John Barton's friend and neighbor Job Legh, who is also present, provides an approximate quotation from the Lord's Prayer, an ancient Christian prayer derived from Jesus Christ's words in Matthew 6:9-13 and Luke 11:2-4. The passage that Job quotes is often translated as, "Forgive us our trespasses as we forgive those who trespass against us." It means that genuinely repentant people can expect to be forgiven by God—but only in proportion as those people are able to forgive other people who have wronged them.

Mr. Carson's response—"Let my trespasses be unforgiven, so that I may have vengeance for my son's murder"—is an important turning point for the character. Previously, according to the narrator, Mr. Carson has been engaging in self-deception, describing what he wants as "justice." Now, however, he explicitly admits that what he wants is not justice but "vengeance." Moreover, his rejection of the Lord's Prayer shows him accepting out loud the fact that his desire for vengeance goes against central Christian teachings. Mr. Carson, by voicing his own unchristian desire for vengeance, destroys his own capacity for self-deception—and thus opens the door for him to change his mind, repent of his vengefulness, and return to Christian teaching, as he does shortly afterward in the novel.

Essentially, Job is contending that open communication between employers and working-class men does good because it allows them to understand one another's perspectives, "the view" from their respective social "place[s]." This contention bolsters the novel's previous representation of the workers' violent strike as driven by the employers' refusal to openly communicate their reasons for offering such low wages. That is, through Job, the novel suggests that violent class conflict can be diffused by mutual understanding and empathy even if the parties in conflict don't agree. While modern readers may be suspicious of this optimistic—and personal as opposed to structural—take on class conflict, it is the note the novel strikes as it nears its end.

☞ To those who have large capability of loving and suffering, united with great power of firm endurance, there comes a time in their woe when they are lifted out of the contemplation of their individual case into a searching inquiry into the nature of their calamity, and the remedy (if remedy there be) which may prevent its recurrence to others as well as themselves.

Related Characters: Harry Carson, Mr. Carson, Job Legh

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 361

Explanation and Analysis

The narrator is describing how Mr. Carson comes to help improve labor conditions and class relations in Manchester later in his life—even though he argued to Job Legh earlier in the same chapter that employers could ultimately do nothing to alleviate the economic suffering of the working class.

The novel attributes Mr. Carson's conversion and his success as a reformer partly to his personal virtues, partly to his empathy, and partly to his individual experience—all factors that emphasize the personal in political reform to the neglect of the social or structural. First, Mr. Carson's "large capability of loving and suffering" and "firm endurance" make him able to move past his individual grief to see the social "calamity" of poor class relations. Thus, the novel suggests that exceptional individuals are needed to perceive social ills and to effect their change.

Second, the novel argues that such individuals are motivated by empathy and individual experience: Mr. Carson wants social reform to "prevent" the "recurrence" of his own pain—the murder of his son as a result of class

Chapter 37 Quotes

☞ "You say our talk has done no good. I say it has. I see the view you take of things from the place where you stand."

Related Characters: Job Legh (speaker), John Barton, Jem (James) Wilson, Harry Carson, Mr. Carson

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 360

Explanation and Analysis

After John Barton's death, Mr. Carson summons Job Legh and Jem Wilson to come talk with him because he wants them to explain John's motives for murdering his son Harry Carson. After Job argues that nominally Christian employers' exploitative lack of care for their poverty-stricken employees drove John violently insane, Job and Mr. Carson debate whether employers have the ability to alleviate their working-class employees' economic suffering. Though Mr. Carson is dispirited that he and Job can't come to an agreement, Job argues that their "talk" has still done "good" because he can now see Mr. Carson's "view [...] from the place where [he] stand[s]."

conflict—"to others." In other words, Mr. Carson empathetically imagines that others will suffer as he has suffered if he doesn't act to improve class relations and labor conditions. Thus, to the very end, the novel insists on

the importance of personal history and individual empathy to address arguably structural social problems such as economic inequality and class conflict.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

One May evening, workers from Manchester make an excursion to beautiful fields outside the city. During that excursion, resolute-looking John Barton and his weeping, pregnant wife, Mrs. Barton, run into friends, Mr. Wilson and Mrs. Wilson, carrying their twin babies. Mr. Wilson greets John and asks, in a near whisper, whether he's heard anything about Esther. While the women sit and rest, the men stroll on together, and John tells Wilson that he believes Esther has run off—her beauty (which she shares with her sister Mrs. Barton) and resulting vanity having become moral dangers to her.

Mr. Wilson marvels that Esther moved out of the Bartons' house in the first place. John Barton says that financial independence is the “worst” part of factory work for girls. When Esther spent her income on clothing and started coming home late, he warned her—for her own good—that she'd end up a sex worker. Her anger motivated her to move out of the house into a rented room. Nevertheless, Esther and the Bartons remained on friendly terms, and Esther last visited the Barton household the previous Sunday.

Mr. Wilson asks whether Esther's demeanor had changed during her last visit. John says that at one point, Esther asked Mary whether she'd like it if one day Esther turned her into a lady. He scolded Esther for giving Mary the idea—he'd rather his daughter worked than live a life of selfish leisure. When Mr. Wilson, tickled, comments that John has never liked “gentlefolk,” John snaps back that no rich person gave him food when his son Tom was starving to death. Moreover, he doesn't believe that rich people are ignorant of poor people's suffering—and if they are ignorant, they should educate themselves.

When John says that Esther's beauty and vanity are dangers to her, he implies that she has “run off” to engage in some kind of premarital romance—and that such a romance is inherently perilous for a working-class woman in Victorian England like Esther. Thus, from the novel's beginning, it connects sexuality with danger for its female characters.



John seems to think that financial independence is the “worst” part of factory work for girls because it gives them more latitude to engage in sex-adjacent behavior: buying pretty clothes, staying out late, etc. John believes (and the narrator does not contradict him) that female sexuality ought to remain under the watchful eye and the control of male heads of household.



This passage hints that John thinks Esther may have been a bad influence on his daughter Mary, suggesting that uncontrolled female sexuality is dangerous not only to uncontrolled women but to the people around them. The passage also introduces a strong motive for working-class John to hate rich people and the employer class: at one point, John had a son who starved to death because people with resources were either too unempathetic or too culpably ignorant to help him.



Mr. Wilson wants to hear more about Esther. John explains that on Wednesday, the Bartons received a visit from Esther's landlady, who brought Esther's things because Esther had said that she was moving back in with the Bartons. According to the landlady, Esther left on Tuesday night. Upon hearing this story, Mrs. Barton screamed and fainted. John tells Mr. Wilson that he feels terrible for his wife, who has suffered so much since their son Tom died. Mr. Wilson suggests that his sister Alice, neighbor to the Bartons, might visit Mrs. Barton sometimes and keep her company. Then Mary Barton, a pretty 13-year-old, bounces up to them. When Mr. Wilson's son Jem rushes past and kisses her, she slaps him, blushing.

When John expresses a worry—that Mrs. Barton is suffering—Mr. Wilson immediately suggests that someone in their shared social circle, his sister Alice, could help. This suggestion exemplifies the communal care that poor and working-class characters show one another throughout the novel, even as rich characters largely ignore working-class suffering. In another vein, no adult seems bothered either by Jem “stealing” a kiss from Mary or by Mary hitting him—which suggests a view of sexuality according to which boys pursue girls however they like, while girls are forced to be moral “gatekeepers” preventing inappropriate sexual activity.



CHAPTER 2

The Bartons and Wilsons return to the Bartons' modest home to have tea together. John and Mrs. Barton tell Mary to go buy food and invite Alice Wilson to join them. After Alice arrives, she offers a toast to absent friends—and immediately realizes her gaffe: Esther is absent. Mrs. Barton weeps. At the end of the evening, Alice apologizes. Mrs. Barton hugs her, tells her she knows Alice didn't mean to trouble her, and blesses her.

Alice's apology to Mrs. Barton shows her empathy, humility, and desire to help others, while Mrs. Barton's decision to bless Esther—a religious response—shows the centrality of Christianity to the characters' personal and social lives.



CHAPTER 3

That night, Mrs. Barton goes into labor. John runs for a doctor. By the time he returns, Mrs. Barton has died. After examining the corpse, the doctor tells John that some “shock to the system” caused her death. The doctor leaves. John bursts into bitter tears, knowing that he'll have to return to work soon and thinking that the “shock” that killed her must have been Esther's disappearance. He feels new hatred for Esther.

Immediately after John's wife dies, he thinks that he'll have to go back to work soon, revealing that John expects no sympathy, consideration, or aid from his employers (e.g. a day off to grieve). John's belief that Esther's sexually connoted disappearance caused Mrs. Barton's death—a belief that the narrator does not cast doubt on—underscores the strong link the novel draws between uncontrolled female sexuality and danger to the community.



In the years after Mrs. Barton's death, John becomes very tender and trusting toward Mary, who handles their domestic arrangements—but he is taciturn and cold toward most other people. He becomes involved in labor organizing—and little wonder, as employees, who think of themselves as creating their employers' wealth, must question why the workers suffer so much in hard times while employers seem to live richly no matter what. John's mother died from privation, and in one trade downturn when John was unemployed, his sick, starving baby Tom died too. These experiences made John want “vengeance” against employers as a class. He becomes a Chartist.

John's backstory further fleshes out his hatred of rich people and the employer class: not only his baby son but also his mother died from conditions associated with poverty. Chartism was a political movement that lasted from approximately the 1830s to the 1850s in England. Chartists wanted all adult men, not only property owners, to be allowed to vote; they also championed other legal reforms that would have made it easier for poor and working-class men to participate in politics.



When Mary is 16, John decides that she must “do something.” He doesn’t want her to work in factories, and she doesn’t want to become a domestic servant—in part because she knows she’s pretty and, influenced by her lost Aunt Esther, whom she believes became a lady, she hopes to marry up, which she thinks working as a servant will prevent her from doing. Instead, she becomes a dressmaker’s apprentice to a woman named Miss Simmonds, who agrees to train her in exchange for two years of unpaid work. After two years, Mary will receive a tiny weekly salary.

The narrative has heavily implied that Esther’s beauty led her into some sexual impropriety that contributed to Mrs. Barton’s death. As such, Mary’s prettiness and her hopeful interpretation of Esther’s disappearance may foreshadow that Mary’s romantic life may likewise become a source of danger to herself and others. Meanwhile, the rather unfair terms of Mary’s apprenticeship—two years of unpaid labor in exchange for a tiny future salary—underscore the exploitation of working-class employees by their employers in mid-Victorian England.



CHAPTER 4

A year passes. John and Mary continue to mourn Mrs. Barton, but the rest of the neighborhood forgets her. John continues to organize for workers’ rights, and though Mr. Wilson isn’t interested in organizing, he and John remain best friends. Jem Wilson gets work at an engineering firm that makes various machines. Mr. and Mrs. Wilson are always praising Jem to Mary—which, she knows, is because he’s silently in love with her and wants to marry her.

Though the narrative has already illustrated the exploitation of the working class by their employers, Mr. Wilson’s lack of interest in John’s workers’ rights organizing shows that not all workers have the same response to their exploitation: some are angry and active, while others are passive, resigned, or uninterested in change.



One day in winter, Mary runs into Alice, who invites her to tea to meet Alice’s upstairs neighbor, a girl Mary’s age. After Alice has worked to make her humble dwelling comfortable, the neighbor—Margaret, shabby but kind-looking—enters. Mary, who has dressed carefully to impress the stranger, arrives after. Margaret is awed by Mary. Alice, serving the girls oat bread characteristic of the north, reminisces about how she left her northern home when young to work in Manchester—and never saw her mother again, as she couldn’t save the money to visit her first year in service, and then her mother died. She hopes to visit home again before she dies.

Alice’s hard work to make her poor dwelling a nice place for Mary and Margaret emphasizes the consideration poor and working-class characters show one another in the novel, in contrast with the callous or indifferent way rich people treat the poor. Alice’s reminiscences about how her low wages kept her from visiting her mother until her mother died yet again emphasize the hard lot of working-class employees in mid-Victorian England.



Mary asks why Alice hasn’t gone home since her mother died. Alice replies that she often lacked money, as she financially helped her “scapegrace” brother Tom and—after Tom’s death—raised his son Will. Will has since become a sailor and is now in South America. Changing the subject, Alice convinces Margaret, reputed to have a lovely singing voice, to sing a Lancashire ballad called “The Oldham Weaver,” which is about a poor, starving cotton-weaver. Then Margaret sings “Lord, remember David.” Mary is moved to tears by Margaret’s beautiful voice. After tea is over, Margaret invites Mary to come upstairs and meet her grandfather; Mary agrees.

Alice has voluntarily foregone trips home in order to help her “scapegrace” (irresponsible) brother financially, again showing the generous communal spirit of the working poor in the novel. The songs Margaret sings—a ballad about a poor worker and the Psalm “Lord, remember David”—emphasize the centrality of work and poverty on the one hand and religion on the other to the lives of the novel’s central characters.



CHAPTER 5

The narrator notes that, though readers may not believe it, there are working-class men throughout Lancashire whose beloved hobby is natural science. Margaret's grandfather Job Legh is one such: his room is full of specimens. When Mary comes to visit him with Margaret, she asks one question about the specimens, and Job bombards her with all their scientific names. To rescue Mary, Margaret cuts in with an anecdote about how Job once bought what he thought was a dead scorpion that turned out only to be in cold hibernation. When Mary goes home, she thinks how odd the two are: plain Margaret with her beautiful voice and druid-like Job.

Over the course of the winter, Mary and Margaret become close friends. Mary is perhaps attracted to Margaret's common sense. Mary admits many of her flaws to Margaret, but she hides that she has been flirting with a good-looking young man on her walks home from work—a young man whom she doesn't love but whom she hopes to marry. Meanwhile, Jem Wilson desperately loves Mary and hopes to marry her, though her coolness toward him daunts him.

In late February, Mary is walking home from work one evening when she runs into Margaret. Margaret mentions she's sewing mourning clothes, and Mary offers to help. While the girls set up the work at Mary's house, Margaret explains the clothes are for a new widow and her three older daughters, who are too busy preparing for their father's funeral to sew their own clothes. The family is poor, but the wife is still trying to give him a lavish funeral.

When Mary comments that Alice Wilson wouldn't grieve in such a fashion, Margaret says that Alice is different: she believes all ills are "sent" for some good. Margaret is about to tell Mary about some ill of her own about which Alice comforted her—but then she cuts herself off. Regardless, she relates to Mary that Alice told her anxiety is irreligious, which has helped her stop complaining about her woes.

Mary asks whether Margaret will be paid for sewing the mourning clothes. Margaret says she intends to do it for free to help the mourners who can't really afford to pay for it. Then she laments that sewing black cloth is hard on the eyes, admits she's going blind, and bursts into tears. When Mary tries to comfort her by suggesting she's wrong, Margaret tells her that she visited a doctor who told her that her vision would fail unless she stopped working—but she and her grandfather Job need the money. Her only comfort is that the old weaver who gives her singing lessons tells her she might make money by her singing.

When the narrator speculates that readers may not believe science enthusiasts exist among the working class, it suggests that the novel's intended audience is middle- or upper-class—in other words, the audience belongs to the class of people who either exploit the working class or, at minimum, benefit from the goods and services created by their exploitation. By taking these people as the intended audience, the narrator may be trying to open their eyes to the exploitation of the working class and, in doing so, increase their empathy for poor people.



That Mary hides her flirting from Margaret while sharing her other flaws indicates that she, consciously or unconsciously, judges her own flirting to be beyond the pale. This self-judgment shows the unacceptability and perceived dangerousness of female sexuality to the conservative Victorian culture in which Mary has been raised.



The widow's desire to give her husband a lavish funeral despite her lack of resources emphasizes again the morality and community-oriented nature of the poor, working-class Manchester community described in the novel.



Margaret takes Alice, who believes that every bad thing that happens is "sent" for some good, as a religious model. Margaret's desire to emulate the pious Alice shows her belief that Christian virtues such as faith and patient endurance are central to a good life.



Though Margaret needs money, she performs sewing work for free to help a poor widow, despite the fact that such work is exacerbating her progressive blindness. Margaret's altruism and self-sacrifice embody the community-oriented mutual aid that the poor, working-class characters give one another throughout the novel. On the other hand, Margaret's decision to continue working despite the damage to her eyes underscores the desperate economic situation of poor Manchester residents in mid-Victorian England.



The girls hear many people running past outside. Mary goes outside to ask about the commotion and learns that a nearby mill is on fire. To distract Margaret from her grief, Mary insists that they go see the fire. When they arrive at the burning mill and the surrounding crowd, they realize that two workers are still trapped in the building. Mary, terrified, wants to go home, but the girls are too hemmed in by the crowd to move.

Jem and another man arrive with a ladder; they push it from the upper floor of a neighboring building and through a mill window to create a bridge. Jem walks across the “bridge,” enters the burning mill, and carries out one of the trapped men—his father Mr. Wilson, who works at the mill. Jem goes to fetch the second trapped man, but on his way back across the bridge, he loses his balance and nearly falls. Mary, watching, faints. Jem manages to make it safely back to the neighboring building with the second worker.

The crowd disperses. Margaret lowers Mary to the cool pavement, where she regains consciousness. Margaret assures her that everyone is safe. The girls go ask a nearby fireman for more information. When Margaret asks why they let Jem rescue both men, the fireman says they couldn’t stop him from going. When the girls get back to Mary’s house, John is home. They tell him what happened, and he vows that he’d consent right away if Jem asked for Mary’s hand in marriage. Margaret laughs, but Mary is annoyed.

CHAPTER 6

The Carsons, who own the mill that burned, aren’t too sorry about the fire: they have insurance and wanted to replace the old machinery anyway. Moreover, demand for cotton goods is currently low. Thus, the Carsons decide to close the mill while they make repairs so they don’t have to “drain” their coffers paying their mill-worker employees. Indeed, they enjoy the closure as a sort of holiday from managerial work. Meanwhile, the workers go without food and heat. Some become vicious, while others display astonishing religious faith and self-sacrifice.

As soon as Mary learns that Margaret is blind, she latches on to any exciting event that might distract Margaret from her fear and suffering. Though Mary’s tactics may be questionable—it’s not clear that a burning mill will cheer Margaret up—her immediate action to help Margaret exemplifies the practical-minded altruism shared by many of the novel’s poor, working-class protagonists.



Mary faints when she sees Jem in peril, hinting that she may not be as indifferent to him as she seems. Yet given her flirtation with another, as-yet-unnamed young man, readers may wonder whether her confused emotions will lead to distress or even danger for her and Jem.



John talks about his daughter Mary as if she were his possession, which he could give to Jem as a reward for good behavior. Though modern readers may sympathize greatly with Mary’s annoyance, the novel itself takes as given that male heads of household would be deeply involved in girls’ romantic and sexual lives—especially given the novel’s suggestion that uncontrolled female sexuality is dangerous.



The mill owners enjoy the mill closure as a holiday while their poor employees, put out of work, begin to starve. The mill owners’ sanguine reaction shows either their unempathetic moral callousness or their ignorance of the workers’ suffering. Meanwhile, when the narrative mentions the role of religious faith in inspiring some starving workers to good acts, it emphasizes the importance that the text accords Christianity when it comes to living a good life.



In the spring, other mills, reacting to the same bad market, reduce workers' hours or close entirely. John, given reduced hours, and Mr. Wilson, unemployed, are both unhappy. One evening, Mr. Wilson visits John and asks whether he has any money to spare: Ben Davenport, who used to work at Carsons' mill, has contracted a fever and has no food in his house. Though John crankily informs Mr. Wilson that he has no money, he packs up his own supper and goes to visit the Davenports. The two men find Davenport, his wife Mrs. Davenport, and his small children living in a cellar in a filthy slum. The children immediately wolf down the food John has brought.

John tells Mr. Wilson to stay with the Davenports and hurries home. There, he grabs his only remaining valuables. He pawns them, uses the money to buy food, candles, and coal, which he brings back to the Davenports. He and Mr. Wilson light a fire and try to give Mrs. Davenport bread, but she is too starved and weak to eat. Mr. Wilson goes home to fetch her tea, while John cooks a thin gruel and spoon-feeds it to her. When Mr. Wilson returns with the tea, Ben Davenport snatches it and gulps it down "with a selfishness he had never shown in health."

After consulting with Mr. Wilson, John walks to a pharmacy in search of medicine. The juxtaposition of the Davenports' horrid cellar and the full shops he passes troubles him. He finds himself hating all the apparently cheerful people he passes—though he doesn't actually know their secret lives, which may be saintly, evil, or simply desperate. At the pharmacy, the pharmacist diagnoses Ben Davenport with typhoid from John's description, gives John a medicine unlikely to be effective, and tells him to ask for an "Infirmity order" the next day.

Later that night, while the Davenports sleep, Mr. Wilson and John talk. Mr. Wilson explains that Ben was his coworker at Carsons' mill for about three years and that, while Ben was gone looking for work, he read aloud to the illiterate Mrs. Davenport a lovely letter Ben had written to her: no complaining, only suggestions that they should remember God is their father and that they should bear hardship humbly. John comments ironically that God is also the father of the employers—whom he'd hate to have as brothers. When Mr. Wilson scolds John, claiming that some employers must be better people than they, John asks whether the employers have treated others how they'd like to be treated, given that they get rich and leave the poor to their poverty.

Though Mr. Wilson is unemployed and John is short of work, they both busy themselves to help the starving Davenports, who are even worse off than they are. Yet again, these actions exemplify how the novel's poor protagonists recognize one another's suffering and respond to it as a practical problem to be solved communally.



John pawns his only remaining valuables to help the Davenports, a gesture that both illustrates John's moral commitments to helping fellow working-class families and underscores that rich people in Manchester could help the poor if they wanted—simply by attending to their needs and buying them food as John does at greater cost to himself.



John's diligent attempts to help the Davenports show yet again how poor and working-class characters in the novel help one another despite their limited resources—in contrast to rich characters, who have more resources but generally fail to use them to help others. Yet John's rage at the cheerful crowds shows—as the narrator reminds readers—his lack of empathy for people outside his own class, based on his ignorance of their lives. (An "infirmity order" is essentially a pass that a rich hospital patron can issue to get one of their employees treatment at a hospital.)



In the dispute between Mr. Wilson and John, Mr. Wilson has the more orthodox Christian attitude: all men are brothers, regardless of their class status. Yet John makes the hard-to-argue point that whereas the poor often help one another, the nominally Christian rich generally fail to follow Christian teaching and aid their poorer "brothers." Thus, the novel suggests that the religious failings of the employer class are embittering John and turning him away from humane Christian doctrines.



John goes on to say that if employers earn interest on their capital, workers ought to earn interest on their labor, as employers get rich off of workers' labor: they grind the workers' down to become rich themselves, and now many of the workers are starving. When Mr. Wilson protests that Mr. Carson told him that the Carsons would have to economize after the fire, John asks whether the employers have ever seen one of their children starve.

Though elsewhere the novel represents employers' and employees' interests as intertwined, here John points out that in some sense employers and employees are enemies: employers try to get the most labor they can out of workers for the least pay to enrich themselves. Moreover, though the novel does tout the importance of empathy, John here suggests there are limits to shared experience across the employer and employee classes: the Carsons might have to cut back on some expenses during an economic downturn, but they've never seen their children starve the way John saw his baby son starve.



John and Mr. Wilson watch over the Davenports until dawn. At dawn, Mr. Wilson walks to Mr. Carson's house to ask for an Infirmary order. The house, on the edge of the city, is opulently beautiful. Mr. Wilson enters through the kitchen and waits for the servants to let Mr. Carson know he's there. Waiting in the kitchen, Mr. Wilson becomes terribly hungry at the food odors—but the servants, though they'd feed him if they knew of his hunger, don't guess he's hungry because they're not hungry themselves. Mr. Wilson becomes sick with hunger while the servants gossip.

Here, the novel underscores how ignorance thwarts empathy and moral action: the Carsons' servants don't know Mr. Wilson is hungry and don't even imagine he's hungry, since hunger isn't part of their personal experience; ergo, they fail to notice that he's half-starved.



Meanwhile, Mr. Carson and his son Harry Carson are eating a large breakfast in the library. Harry, the very handsome only son of the family, is so beloved by his parents and sisters that he has become arrogant. A servant enters and announces that a mill worker named Wilson wants to speak with Mr. Carson. Mr. Carson has the servant show Mr. Wilson in. Mr. Wilson, looking around nervously, enters and explains that he wants an Infirmary order for Ben Davenport. Though Mr. Carson doesn't remember who Ben is—he lets "the over-looker" deal with the employees—and can't spare an in-patient order, he gives Mr. Wilson an out-patient one. Meanwhile, Harry gives Mr. Wilson five shillings for Ben and rushes off, hoping to see Mary Barton on her walk to work.

This scene emphasizes the economic and social gulf between the Carsons and their employees: the Carsons have a large breakfast while their employees are starving; Mr. Carson doesn't remember his employees' names because he has middle management, "the over-looker," deal with them; and so on. Thus, while the Carsons are willing enough to help their employees in small things—Mr. Carson gives Mr. Wilson an infirmary order, and Harry gives him some money—they don't seem to recognize the extent of their employees' need and suffering.



When Mr. Wilson returns to the Davenports' cellar, Ben has taken a turn for the worse. After struggling to speak for a long time, Ben thanks God that his life of suffering will soon be done. Mrs. Davenport begs him to say something else, something that will comfort her, but he is unable to speak. He places a feeble hand on her head and dies. Mary knocks and enters, having been summoned by John. He asks her to comfort Mrs. Davenport. Mary embraces the new widow and weeps with her, forgetting all about seeing Harry. Mr. Wilson, unemployed, takes responsibility for organizing the funeral while John and Mary go late to work. After work, Mary lets out the hem of her old black dress to give to Mrs. Davenport for mourning.

Ben Davenport has been described as a pious man, and in dying, he thanks God—suggesting that, in the novel, religious faith helps people cultivate gratitude, accept their fates, and die without fear. Meanwhile, though the novel presents Mary as "flawed" in various ways, she immediately forgets about her selfish interest in seeing Harry when she encounters another working-class family in need of help, emphasizing yet again the practical morality of the working class in the novel.



CHAPTER 7

Mrs. Davenport moves out of the cellar with her children and begins minding others' children and sewing to earn money. Shortly after, the Wilsons' twins contract typhoid. When Mary hears they are gravely ill, she goes to visit the Wilsons. Upon entering their house, she sees Mrs. Wilson tending to one deathly ill child while Alice minds the other's corpse. Alice quietly tells Mary that the child still alive will soon die—but they need to get him away from his mother, who is “wishing” him: willing hard for him to live and thus extending his painful last moments. When Alice approaches Mrs. Wilson, the latter at first refuses to let her son go—but then she surrenders him. Shortly after Alice takes him, he dies.

While Mr. Wilson and Mrs. Wilson lay out the bodies upstairs, Alice tells Mary that Jem will be miserable when he returns from his overtime work and that it sometimes seems God intentionally ruins human plans so that humans will rely only on his will: Alice had been intending to visit her childhood home in the north until Mr. Wilson lost his job and needed her help.

Jem comes home from work with oranges for his sickly brothers. Alice, weeping, tells him that both have died. Jem shakes with grief. Mary, moved, touches his arm and tells him not to submit to grief, as it pains her to see him like that. Overcome by love, Jem squeezes Mary's hand and admits that he's happy in this moment despite everything—and she knows why. Mary looks repulsed. Jem drops her hand and internally calls himself a “selfish beast” for professing his love just then. He hurries upstairs to see his brothers' bodies.

Mary helps Alice clean the Wilsons' house. Near morning, she goes home, lies down, and wonders why Jem reacts to her kindness as if it's flirtation. She can't get her tone right: either she's cruel to him or she's too kind and it sounds “loving.” She's nearly engaged to Harry, a handsomer man even if she “like[s] Jem's face best for all that.” She wonders whether she can help Jem once she's Harry's rich bride. Mary falls asleep, dreaming of her wedding and how she'll help her father John once she has money.

The novel represents Alice as a morally good, highly religious character; as such, her sad yet resigned and peaceful reaction to the twins' deaths suggests that the appropriate reaction to grief and loss is not Mrs. Wilson's “wishing” against probability but rather humble, religious acceptance of the mysterious will of God.



When Alice explicitly references the will of God here, it underscores what was implied in the previous passage: the novel intends Alice as a positive model of religious humility and acceptance of whatever God gives, whether it seems good or bad.



Previously, the novel has represented sex and romance as inherently dangerous. Here, by having Jem indirectly proclaim his love for Mary right after he's learned of his brothers' deaths, the novel emphasizes that romantic love is powerful, unruly, and often socially inappropriate—thus implying again that romance and sex are dangerous and must be tightly controlled.



As in the previous passage, here sexuality is represented as confusing and dangerous: Mary doesn't understand why she sounds “loving” toward Jem when she's not actively trying to be cruel or why she “like[s] Jem's face best” even though Harry is better-looking—though readers can guess that Mary may be repressing romantic feelings for Jem due to the economic opportunity marriage to an employer like Harry would represent.



CHAPTER 8

Three weeks later, Jem visits the Bartons' in his best clothes with a flower in his buttonhole that he hopes Mary will praise so he can give it to her. Mary largely ignores him and soon flees to her bedroom, where she has more luxurious flowers from Harry. Jem is stuck listening to John talk about working conditions: once, when John was sick with fever, he helped the surgeon at the infirmary by copying his paperwork—and learned that most factory accidents occurred during the last two hours of work when workers were exhausted. John drops hints that the workers are going to do something about this. Jem, preoccupied with Mary, asks no questions and soon leaves.

For the past three years, the cost of food has risen while work has gotten scarcer. Many working-class families are slowly starving, which foments hatred of the rich. The workers suspect that Parliament doesn't know of their misery, so in spring 1839, a massive petition is created about economic conditions in manufacturing areas, and some worker-representatives are selected to bring the petition to Parliament. John is one of the representatives. He's excited to see London and hopeful Parliament will help.

The night before John leaves for London, many neighbors stop by. Various men ask John to petition Parliament to end starvation or pass a bill mandating shorter workdays. Mrs. Davenport comes and asks whether Parliament could repeal the law against children working in factories: her son Ben is strong and terribly hungry, and she has no money to send him to school, so she'd like him to go work rather than spend his days as a street delinquent. Several other men offer their own petitions for John to bring to Parliament, and John says he'll do his best, though he intends to focus on the workers' miserable poverty.

After the visitors have left, John mentions to Mary that Mrs. Wilson has been looking very sickly—though she hasn't been strong since a factory wheel damaged her hip in an accident as a young woman. Mr. Wilson married her shortly after the accident, though many thought he ought to have jilted her. John worries what will happen to Mr. Wilson if his wife dies.

The novel uses Harry's and Jem's flowers to insist on the economic dimension of their courtships of Mary: as romance in Victorian England is an economic proposition—men are expected to support their wives—rich men have an edge in romantic competition. In crude terms, Harry offers Mary more expensive gifts, which reminds her that he's a better economic proposition than Jem. Meanwhile, John is attuned to the ways poor labor conditions harm workers—but Jem, mired in his personal problems, doesn't care.



The Chartist movement (c. 1830s–1850s), which championed legal rights and political participation for working-class men, really did compose a petition to Parliament in early 1839 and bring it to the House of Commons in June 1839. The novel frames the problem in terms of empathy and ignorance: the workers believe that legislators simply don't know about their plight—but that if they did, they would do something.



That John's neighbors all ask and expect him to bring their opinions to Parliament shows the spirit of mutual aid and community animating the novel's working-class characters. Meanwhile, Mrs. Davenport's rather alarming desire that Parliament repeal laws against child labor shows that working-class characters have diverse political views and are not uniformly economically progressive.



Mrs. Wilson's factory accident points out again how Victorian employers, knowingly or not, accrue wealth from working conditions that harm their employees. John's casual admission that lots of people thought Mr. Wilson should have jilted his fiancée due to disability shows the penetration of romance by economics: people think wives should be domestic workers, which imperils disabled women in the marriage market.



Mary has decided not to see Harry while John is away, suggesting that she has a guilty conscience, though she tells herself her marriage to Harry will help John. Harry pays one of Mary's coworkers, the friendly but wholly superficial Sally Leadbitter, to carry messages for him to Mary. One evening, Harry gives Sally a letter begging Mary to reverse her decision and see him. When Sally enters the Bartons' house in search of Mary, she finds Mary weeping. Sally teases Mary for crying over her love of Harry. Mary, piqued, says she may not love Harry at all; she's crying over Mr. Wilson, who suddenly died that very day.

Sally gives Mary Harry's letter. Mary asks Sally to tell Harry she won't meet him while John's gone. While Sally is trying to change Mary's mind, Margaret enters. Sally quickly leaves. Mary, noticing Margaret's eyes are red, asks whether she's been crying. Margaret says yes, but for joy, and shows Mary a gold sovereign: she's had her first professional singing engagement at the Mechanics' Institute, and she's been hired to sing there again. Moreover, she finally admitted to her grandfather (Job) that she was going blind. He wept and began moving objects out of her way in case they tripped her, but he took it gently. Margaret, happily, sings a little of the song she is to perform next; Mary cries and laughingly predicts wealth in Margaret's future.

CHAPTER 9

The next evening, it rains. John returns from London drenched and utterly demoralized: Parliament has refused to heed the working men's petition. When Mary tells him that Mr. Wilson has died, he simply declares that that's "better" than the alternative. Mary, alarmed, quickly runs to Margaret and Job's and asks Job to come comfort her father. Margaret and Job come with Mary to the Bartons' and do succeed in cheering John somewhat. Though still doomily prophesying that the rich will suffer in the afterlife, John tells his curious audience about various things he saw in London. Yet when Job asks what exactly happened in Parliament, John can't bear to relate it.

Job, to break the gloomy silence, tells the others about the time he visited London. His only daughter, Margaret's mother, married a young joiner, Frank Jennings, who moved to London for a better-paying job. After moving, Job's daughter wrote him letters hinting that she was pregnant. Then Frank's father visited Job looking miserable and told him their children had caught a fever. The two fathers hurried to London, but by the time they arrived, their children were dead—though their grandchild, Margaret, had just been born and had survived.

Mary's guilty conscience over Harry hints that she too sees even the slightest hint of premarital romance as dangerous and sinful, even as she is repressing that viewpoint in herself. Mr. Wilson's sudden death, meanwhile, insists on the vulnerability and precarity of workers' lives in Victorian England.



Mary's insistence that she won't see Harry while John is gone again underlines that she consciously or subconsciously views her flirtation as dangerous. Her joy at Margaret's success, on the other hand, underlines her generous, community-minded spirit—emblematic of working-class morality in the novel. (The Mechanics' Institute was a working-class community center with cultural programming.)



In June 1839, Parliament really did vote not to hear the Chartists' petition on behalf of working-class men's rights. This refusal suggests that the ignorance that blocks empathy is sometimes culpable: fortunate people sometimes choose not to know or learn about the sufferings of the less fortunate. John's prediction that the rich will suffer in the afterlife shows his focus on vengeance rather than more traditionally central Christian virtues like mercy and forgiveness.



Frank Jennings's move for a job—and his and his wife's subsequent sudden deaths—again emphasizes how the lives of the poor and working class were ruled by economic necessity and highly precarious in Victorian England.



Going back to Manchester with baby Margaret, neither Job nor the other grandfather could get her to eat. The last day of their trip, they stopped at a cottage and offered to pay the woman who lived there if she could feed the baby. The woman—looking sad—unlocked a drawer of baby things, took some out, and cleaned and redressed baby Margaret before feeding her. When the woman’s husband came home and acted annoyed at her tending to the baby, Job offered to pay. She refused. When her husband scowled angrily, she said, “For poor little Johnnie’s sake.” Nevertheless, Job slipped some money onto the table before leaving; he believes he will see that woman “in heaven.”

Job’s story ends. He, John, and Margaret notice that Mary has fallen asleep. Almost immediately, she wakes—and claims she was awake the whole time. The others laugh. Job dares Mary to stay awake while he reads John a poem by Samuel Bamford about the sufferings of the poor. After Job recites the poem, John—greatly impressed—asks Mary to copy down the poem for him. The next day, Mary uses the blank half of an anonymous valentine (which she believes Jem sent her) to copy down the poem.

CHAPTER 10

Another year passes while the poor suffer, starve, and sometimes die. John, having missed work to petition Parliament, becomes unemployed. Though Mary receives two meals a day from Miss Simmonds, the Bartons have to pay rent, which eats up almost all of Mary’s salary. John and Mary are about to move when the landlord reduces the rent by three pence a week, just barely allowing the Bartons to remain. Yet Mary has to pawn some of their furniture and blankets to afford food. During this period, Mary derives more pride from having a rich, handsome lover. Sally, noticing Mary’s obsession with money, counsels Harry to “bring matters more to a point”—but he refuses, not wanting to wound Mary’s vanity, though he still intends to possess her “one way or another.”

Harry wouldn’t be so sure Mary was attracted to him if he knew that she spent time with him in part to avoid her unpleasant home life. John is dour and angry; once, when Mary answers back to him, he beats her—though afterward he apologizes, swears never to hit her again, and keeps his word. Mary also hears her father having clandestine meetings with other “desperate” men.

When the woman says “For poor little Johnnie’s sake,” it implies that she and her husband had a child that died in infancy and that she wanted to help baby Margaret in memory of him. This anecdote illustrates both the centrality of empathy to moral action in the novel—the woman, who understands what it’s like to lose a child, wants to prevent the death of another baby—and the pragmatic mutual aid that characterizes working-class relations in the novel. Job’s assumption that he’ll see the woman “in heaven,” meanwhile, reminds readers that Christianity underlies most characters’ moral worldview.



Samuel Bamford (1788–1872) was a radical poet from northern England who supported the rights of the poor and working classes. John’s enthusiasm for his poem bolsters John’s characterization as a working-class radical. Mary’s use of Jem’s Valentine as scrap paper reminds readers of her economically inflected lack of interest in working-class Jem and ongoing flirtation with rich Harry.



That Harry intends to possess Mary “one way or another” reveals that he doesn’t necessarily intend to marry her—meaning that Mary is in moral and social danger from Harry, as women who had premarital sex were not treated well in Victorian England. When Sally tells Harry to “bring matters more to a point,” context suggests that she’s advising him to offer Mary money, gifts, or some material goods in exchange for sex. The possibility that Harry could try to “buy” Mary implicitly parallels the employers’ economic exploitation of the workers with a rich young man’s economically coercive sexual exploitation of a working-class young woman.



Harry poses a romantic “danger” to Mary because he represents a more comfortable life rather than because she genuinely loves him. Though the passage doesn’t explicitly mention religion, John’s “desperate” actions and violence toward Mary contrast with the hope and peacefulness of characters like Alice Wilson, implying that John is desperate because he is focused on worldly, secular concerns rather than religious ones.



One evening, John asks whether Mary has gone to see Mrs. Wilson and scolds her for not having done so sooner. Mary decides to visit the next afternoon when Jem will be at work. When Mary arrives, Mrs. Wilson sarcastically pretends to barely recognize her—her grief has worsened her temper. Mary, who has no excuse for not visiting, shamefacedly turns to greet Alice, who (having moved in to help Mrs. Wilson) is knitting by the fire. Mrs. Wilson tells Mary she'll have to speak up—Alice is going deaf. When Alice agrees and says she'll likely die soon, Mrs. Wilson tells her not to forecast more deaths and starts crying.

Mrs. Wilson, weeping, recollects to Mary what a good husband Mr. Wilson was and how handsome he was as a young man. Bessy Witter—now Mrs. Carson—wanted to marry him when they were young, though now she and Mr. Carson are so much higher-status than the rest of the working Mancunians. Mary blushes, hoping that Mrs. Wilson will say more about the Carsons but fearing to ask. Instead, Mrs. Wilson reminisces about how badly she did the housework when she was first married—she had worked in a factory since age five and had no idea how to cook. She and Alice agree that married women shouldn't be allowed to work in factories; their houses get dirty and their husbands are driven to drink in gin shops.

Alice mentions that Jem has been promoted and ought to marry soon; moreover, she feels he deserves an excellent wife. Though Mary enjoys hearing Jem praised, she blushes and looks piqued. Seeing Mary's irritation, Mrs. Wilson—annoyed at Mary for not visiting, and thinking Mary inferior to Jem—lies a little to convince Mary that Jem doesn't prefer her, claiming that Jem may propose to a shopgirl, Molly Gibson, who's been making eyes at him. Mrs. Wilson goes to fetch a quilt Molly made her so that she can show Mary. While Mrs. Wilson is gone, Mary commiserates with Alice over her growing deafness. Mrs. Wilson returns with the quilt and insists Mary praise it. Mary, annoyed, leaves soon—and encourages Harry's flirtation more over the next few days.

A few weeks later, John is returning home at night from a Trades' Union meeting when a woman he immediately identifies as a sex worker tries to speak with him. He curses her and tells her to go away—until, suddenly, he recognizes her as Esther. Then, furious, he sarcastically reminds her that he told her she'd end up a sex worker. Esther begs him to listen to her “for Mary's sake”—meaning John's daughter Mary. John assumes that she means the dead Mrs. Barton, who was also named Mary; even more infuriated, he accuses Esther of having caused Mrs. Barton's death, shoves her away, and leaves.

Given the community-oriented nature of working-class morality as represented in the novel, Mary has violated important moral norms by failing to visit and comfort the Wilsons after Mr. Wilson's sudden death—hence Mrs. Wilson's anger. Alice's peaceful prediction of her own death subtly reinforces her characterization as a faithfully religious, peaceful, and resigned person, in contrast with the more troubled, grief-stricken Mrs. Wilson.



The novel partly undermines its own suggestion that failures of empathy generally derive from ignorance by reminding readers that Mr. and Mrs. Carson have working-class backgrounds. Given that they should understand the struggles of their employees, this detail implicitly asks, why don't they do more to help their employees? Alice and Mrs. Wilson's disapproval of working wives, meanwhile, emphasizes how hard life can be for working-class women: they may need to work outside the home to help support their families economically, yet they are also expected to create a welcoming environment for their husbands and blamed for working-class male drinking.



Mary likes to hear Jem praised—another detail hinting that she cares more about Jem romantically than she herself knows or admits. Her urge to flirt more with Harry upon hearing that Molly Gibson is chasing after Jem is similar to Jem's inappropriate declaration of feelings to Mary right after his brothers' deaths: it suggests that romance makes people act irrationally, inappropriately, and even self-destructively, and it implicitly argues that sex and romance need to be socially controlled.



John's cruel reaction to Esther indicates the social danger that premarital sexual activity poses to Victorian woman: unless they are virgins or wives, men feel justified in treating them badly. His vengefulness toward Esther due to Mrs. Barton's death also indirectly shows how he is straying further from the Christian principles that animate the “role model” characters in the novel (e.g. Alice Wilson).



Esther falls and struggles to rise. A passing policeman assumes she's drunk and takes her to jail. In jail, a sick and delirious Esther talks to herself, wondering what to do, since John didn't listen to her: she wants to save Mary from her own fate, as Mary is "listening just as I listened, and loving just as I loved." She longs to pray for Mary but believes that God won't listen to the prayers of a sinner like her. The next morning, the police move her from jail to prison for a month.

This passage connects the danger that flirtation with Harry poses to Mary with the harm that premarital sexuality has clearly caused Esther: Esther's lament that Mary is "listening just as I listened" suggests that Esther believed some young lover's promises—a belief that ultimately led her to sex work and social ostracism.



CHAPTER 11

Though John has acted as he planned to act if he ever saw Esther again, he regrets his behavior upon returning home, recalling how wretched she looked when he shoved her down. He wonders whether religion could redeem Esther and whether he could find her again—but though he looks for her for many nights, he never finds her and at last gives up. Due to Esther and Mary's resemblance, he begins worrying about Mary's fate and quizzing her about her whereabouts. Mary, annoyed, refuses to answer.

John's second thoughts about his cruelty to Esther, which he explicitly connects to the possibility of religion "redeeming" Esther from sex work, emphasize that his first reaction to her was "unchristian"—as well as counter to the mutual aid that characterizes working-class morality elsewhere in the novel. His fears about Mary's resemblance to Esther suggest that female beauty is inherently perilous—another way the novel links sexuality, especially female sexuality, to danger.



Wishing Mary were married, John starts asking her about Jem. When Mary replies that Jem may marry Molly Gibson, John snaps that Mary must have erred: Jem used to love her, and he was "better than [she] deservedst." Mary recalls how Harry was fawning over her that morning and tells her father, rather tartly, that perhaps some people think Jem is better than she deserves. Her father continues to scold her about Jem until, finally, he leaves and she bursts into tears.

The novel continues to suggest that Mary's attachment to Harry is primarily a matter of pride rather than love: she believes he represents an opportunity to improve her class status from worker to employer and that his attention might be able to bolster her ego when the people around her tell her that Jem, whom she may subconsciously love, is too good for her.



Meanwhile, Jem has decided to roll the dice and propose to Mary—he has enough money to support a wife, and though their home would have to include Mrs. Wilson and Alice, such arrangements are common among the poor. He knocks on the Bartons' door, and Mary calls on him to enter. When she realizes why he's come, she decides to refuse him: she'll show everyone who does or doesn't deserve whom. Yet she can't meet his intensely loving look. He gives a speech declaring his lifelong love and asks her to be his wife. When she can't reply for a second, he asks whether her silence means consent. Finding her voice, she says no: they can be friends, but not spouses.

Jem's consideration that he will have to support Mrs. Wilson and Alice as well as his future wife emphasizes yet again the community-oriented practical morality of the working-class characters in the novel. Mary's piqued decision to reject Jem, motivated by John having told her that Jem is too good for her, illustrates how Mary's ego and class aspirations rather than her heart are guiding her romantic choices vis-à-vis Jem and Harry.



Jem begs Mary to reconsider, saying he cannot be content as her friend. When she refuses, he tells her that her "cruelty" may turn him into an alcoholic or even a murderer. When she won't look at him, he rushes from the house. Though she abruptly calls after him, he's already gone.

Jem's manipulative claim that Mary's rejection will turn him into an alcoholic or murderer—a claim that narrator does not critique—illustrates how the novel not only represents sexuality as dangerous but also how it places the responsibility for men's sexuality and romantic behavior on female characters.



Mary begins sobbing. She feels split between her past and present opinions: she had planned to marry Harry, but she suddenly realizes that she loves Jem. Harry's wealth and handsomeness only temporarily concealed from her her own hidden desires. She goes to her bedroom to think, resolves to end her flirtation with Harry immediately, and decides to wait for Jem to propose again. Only "maidenly modesty" prevents her from pursuing Jem herself.

At this point, Mary's revelation that she loves Jem and only desired Harry for economic and egotistical motivations should come as no great surprise to readers. Victorian sexual mores—in the form of "maidenly modesty"—prohibit Mary from simply telling Jem that she returns his feelings after all. This prohibition shows how extremely limited the romantic options of "good" Victorian girls were: rather than directly communicate their own romantic interests, they had to wait for men to show interest and then simply accept or reject them.



For two days, Mary skips meetings with Harry and avoids Sally at work. On the third day, Sally comes to the Bartons' house after work and enters without knocking. When Sally finds Mary alone, John having gone out, she tells her that Harry is waiting at the end of the road and wants to come visit Mary at home because Mary has been avoiding him. Immediately frantic, Mary tells Sally that John will kill her if he learns a man has visited her alone at home. She also reveals that she doesn't love Harry. She begs Sally to make Harry go away. Instead, Sally says that Mary should come with her to speak to Harry in the street—or Harry will break the Bartons' door down. Mary agrees to come.

Here, flirtation and sexuality become not only a moral and social danger to Mary but also a physical one. Given that John has already beaten Mary once for talking back to him, readers should not assume that Mary is speaking figuratively when she says John would kill her for letting a young man into their house unchaperoned. In addition, Harry implicitly threatens physical intimidation—forcing his way into the Bartons' house—to get Mary to see him again. Men, the novel insists, are a potential danger to women.



Mary decides she should apologize to Harry for leading him on, as she naively believes he wants to marry her—a notion of which he has never disabused her, though he wants to "obtain her as cheaply as" possible. She, Sally, and Harry meet in the street and walk to a neighborhood of unfinished construction. There, Harry wraps his arm around Mary's waist, despite her angry struggles, and demands to know why she's avoiding him. Mary apologizes for leading him on, explains that she didn't understand her own mind, and tells him she no longer wants to see him.

The phrase "obtain her as cheaply as" possible suggests that Harry sees Mary as sexual consumer item rather than a true love: even if he won't literally offer her money for sex, he sees her as a potential sexual possession for which he wants to pay as low a price as he can. Thus, the novel again emphasizes the sordid economic dimension to Harry and Mary's flirtation: he sees her as an exploitable object, while she sees him as an escape from the working class.



Harry arrogantly assumes that Mary is "coquetting," but when she firmly repeats herself, he asks how he offended her. She says she doesn't want to explain and tries to leave. When he physically prevents her and demands an explanation, she bursts out that she can't love him. Refusing to believe her and wondering how to change her mind, Harry claims that he loves her so much he'll even marry her—though Mr. Carson and Mrs. Carson would hate the idea so much that he's "never thought of it till now." He promises to marry her that very night and shower her with riches. Mary—relieved—tells him that she felt guilty when she thought he was honest, but now that she realizes he meant to "ruin" her, she holds him in contempt.

To "coquette" is to flirt—with a connotation of coyness or insincerity. Harry, in his arrogance, has difficulty believing that Mary sincerely no longer wants to see him. Perhaps not realizing the depths of Mary's naivete and conventional Victorian sexual morality, Harry admits that he "never thought of [marriage]" before this conversation—thus revealing that he wanted premarital sex, allowed for him but socially ruinous for a girl like Mary. Mary's contempt for Harry after this admission shows that in the conservative sexual view of the novel, she is a "good" girl despite her former flirtatiousness.



Mary breaks Harry's grip and runs away. Sally bursts out laughing. When Harry, annoyed, asks why, Sally says it's comical how Mary has "outwitted us"—really meaning how she has outwitted Harry. She asks why Harry outright stated that he had no intention of marrying Mary until that day. Harry says that he implied to Mary that he didn't intend to marry her and had no idea she didn't understand: Mr. Carson would sooner forgive a "temporary connection" than a bad marriage. When Sally points out that Mrs. Carson once worked in a factory, Harry snaps that there's a larger social distance between him and Mary than there was between his parents. Yet when Sally asks whether Harry will stop pursuing Mary, he says no, though he won't offer to marry her again.

Sally shows deference to higher-class Harry by saying that Mary has outwitted "us"—when, really, Sally was laughing at Harry's sexual defeat. Harry's casual claim that his father would forgive a "temporary connection"—that is, premarital sex—before an economically disadvantageous marriage shows Victorian England's sexual double standard: men who have premarital sex aren't "ruined," but women who do are. Harry's claim also shows the thorough interpenetration of economics and romance in the novel: his father wouldn't want him to marry a poor girl despite his father and mother's own working-class background.



CHAPTER 12

Jem never believes that Mary will have second thoughts about rejecting him. Only his duty to support Mrs. Wilson keeps him from joining the army or drinking himself insensible. Meanwhile, Harry insists on believing that Mary's rejection of him is a passing whim. He has Sally deliver Mary love notes at work and pesters Mary on her walks home. Mary feels wretched that Jem never visits and that Harry pesters her.

Despite Jem's despair over Mary, he continues to behave responsibly because he has family duties to fulfill, showing the community-oriented nature of working-class morality in the novel. Harry's harassment of Mary, meanwhile, underscores the danger that male sexuality poses to women in the novel's worldview.



One evening while Mary is sewing at home, Margaret—returned from a singing tour—comes to visit. Margaret mentions that she ran into Jem in Halifax; he was constructing an engine there. When Mary responds sadly, Margaret asks whether she and Jem have fought. Mary, crying, explains how she rejected Jem's love but now bitterly regrets it. Margaret counsels Mary not to write to Jem because men "like to have a' the courting to themselves." Mary will just have to wait—and patience is something everyone must learn from God.

Margaret confirms Mary's conservative intuition that women shouldn't pursue men, though Margaret frames the intuition in terms of male preference rather than required female modesty: men "like to have a' the courting to themselves." As another religious role-model character, Margaret advises Mary to have patience and trust in God, emphasizing that Christianity underpins her worldview.



Margaret asks whether Mary has visited Mrs. Wilson recently. Mary says no, explaining that Mrs. Wilson was very annoyed with her on her last visit. Margaret suggests that Mary make a visit, as Jem will hear about it and approve. Then, on her way out, Margaret awkwardly mentions John's unemployment and offers Mary some of her singing money. Though at first Mary demurs, she thinks of her father's hunger and accepts the money. After Margaret leaves, Mary goes to buy food, and she and John have a real supper.

Margaret uses her riches to help her hungry friends, the Bartons, exemplifying both her Christian charity and the practical, generous, community-oriented morality that the novel often imputes to its working-class characters.



The next day, Mary visits Mrs. Wilson, who tells her that Alice has gone to the post office looking for a letter from her foster-son Will and that Jem has used the money he earned from his engineering invention patent to set Mrs. Wilson and Alice up with an “income” of 20 pounds a year. Alice returns and announces that she hasn’t received a letter, which upsets her; she wishes she knew for sure that Will was safe—or drowned, in which case she could accept God’s providence. Waiting bothers her. Mary, thinking of her own situation, says that she feels better knowing Alice experiences impatience too. Alice apologizes if she has weakened Mary’s faith in any way by expressing impatience.

An “income,” as used in this passage, refers to a sum of money received at intervals due to some capital, labor, or other valuable item. Essentially, Jem is giving the money that accrues from his patent to his dependent female relatives, raising their class status somewhat. This action shows Jem’s family-mindedness and moral generosity. Meanwhile, the conversation about Alice’s acceptance of poverty and momentary patience casts her once again as a Christian role model.



Someone knocks on the door. Alice rushes to the visitor and hugs him—it’s Will Wilson! Alice weeps for joy. Between her tears and her dimming eyes, she can’t see Will’s face, so she pats it with her hands. Mary decides to leave the reunited family alone. As Mary goes, Alice urges her to “wait patiently on the Lord, whatever [her] trouble may be.”

Virtuous Alice’s advice to “wait patiently on the Lord” underscores again that Christian virtues such as humility, patience, and submission to God undergird the novel’s sense of what it means to live a good life.



CHAPTER 13

Several days later, Will invites Mary to Job’s for a gathering. When Mary asks who else will attend, Will says Jem won’t—he’s too mopey. At Job’s, Job quizzes Will on the flora and fauna of the countries he’s sailed to. Will tells a story about a sailor friend who saw a mermaid, to Job’s disbelieving scorn. When an awed Mary asks what else Will has seen, he tells her about flying fish. Job, who has heard of flying fish, credits this story, and Will offers a dried flying fish specimen to him. Ecstatic, Job tries to think how to thank Will and asks Margaret to sing for him. Will is enchanted by her singing.

Jem’s refusal to attend gatherings hints at his ongoing emotional wounds from Mary’s refusal, despite his ability to continue working and supporting his older female relatives. Meanwhile, Will’s generous gift to Job shows yet again the communal spirit that animates the working-class characters’ relations with one another.



Will—trying to be friendly to Job—asks whether Job would like a tailless Manx cat for Margaret, as Will is going to visit his mother’s friends on the Isle of Man before he ships out. When Mary goes to sit with Alice, she notes sadly Alice’s dimming eyes. Alice tells her not to be sad: as she loses her hearing and sight, she feels as though God is “lulling [her] away to [her] long sleep.” Mary goes home and thinks sadly of her predicaments, including her father’s illness and her regrettable flirtation with the pestering Harry.

Will’s friendliness to Job is ambiguous: he may be trying to repay Job for the gift of Margaret’s singing—or he may be attracted to Margaret and trying to befriend her male guardian as a result. Alice’s peaceful, positive resignation to losing her senses shows her Christian faith and hope—which contrasts with Mary’s worry and fear as she considers Harry’s ongoing harassment of her.



CHAPTER 14

A month has passed since Esther's arrest, and she is released from prison. She is still obsessed with the idea of saving Mary, but she doesn't know whom to petition to help Mary. Then she decides that Jem, Mary's childhood friend, could help. She lurks outside his job; when he exits, she grabs his arm. Though at first he tries to shake her off, she tells him it's about Mary Barton—and he stops, shocked, to ask how she knows Mary. When she explains that she's Mary's aunt Esther, Jem asks where Esther has been all these years. Esther tells him sharply that he should be able to guess—and that she wants him to save Mary from her own fate, as Mary now loves someone above her station just like Esther did. Jem becomes raptly interested.

Esther explains that she fell in love with an army officer. When his regiment decamped to Chester, she didn't want to lose their relationship—so she came with him. Though he had promised to marry her, he didn't. They cohabited for three years, during which Esther had a baby daughter. Then, one day, the officer was sent to Ireland—and he wouldn't take Esther and their daughter with him, though he left some money.

Esther used the money to set up a little shop, but when her daughter got sick, she couldn't work and tend her child: she sold everything for medicine and wrote to the officer begging for aid, but he never replied—she thinks he must have changed addresses. Eventually, she was so behind on rent that her landlord was going to evict her in the middle of winter—so she “went out into the street.” Wildly, Esther says that she'll never see her child again, even in death.

After collecting herself, Esther tells Jem that after her child died, she traveled back to Manchester and, though she never contacted the Bartons' directly, learned from spying and gossip that Mary was apprenticed as a dressmaker. This apprenticeship seemed like a bad idea to Esther—it required Mary to be out late and so might lead her astray—and Esther decided to look out for Mary from afar. She saw a young man, Harry Carson, accompanying Mary on her walks home, is afraid for Mary, and wants Jem to protect her—Mary's better off dead than ruined. Jem morbidly replies, “Better we were all dead.”

Esther approaches first John and then Jem to help Mary rather than approaching Mary herself—a strategy that reveals she sees Mary as essentially unreasonable and in need of male guardianship. Esther's claim that she wants to save Mary from her own fate—sex work—indicates that she sees selling sex as the inevitable outcome of any premarital sexual activity for women, an assumption consonant with the novel's fearful attitude toward female sexuality outside the confines of marriage.



The army officer's abandonment of Esther implies that men will ultimately desert any woman who is willing to have sex before marriage—another way that the novel casts premarital sexuality as socially and economically dangerous to women.



Here, “went out into the street” is another euphemism for “streetwalking,” i.e. sex work. Having engaged in premarital sex and cohabitation, Esther believed herself ostracized from the mutual aid of the working-class community—and so, rather than asking her family for help, she had to support her daughter entirely alone, a situation that pressured her into sex work.



Esther's decision not to contact her family, despite her desperate straits, reveals that she sees herself as rightfully ostracized for her premarital sexual activity and for her sex work. Nevertheless, she still wants to help her remaining family, showing her community-oriented moral sense. Jem's alarming claim that they're “all” better off dead if Mary is ruined, meanwhile, shows the vehemence of romantic and sexual feelings in the novel—and thus of their potential dangerousness.



Jem promises to help Mary and asks Esther to come home with him, so that he can help her find an “honest” job. Esther blesses him for his generosity but tells him that redeeming her is impossible: her life has driven her to drink, and now she is an alcoholic. Yet she insists that he promise to save Mary from such a fate. Jem promises. Afterward, Esther begins to leave when Jem asks how he can contact her again. Esther tells him she has no fixed address—he’ll have to find her in the street—and hurries away. As soon as she’s gone, Jem bitterly reproaches himself for not having urged her to come with him for as long as it took to convince her.

That night in his bedroom, Jem fantasizes about killing Mary rather than letting her marry another. Yet he recognizes that killing her—who simply loved someone else—would be terribly unjust. Then he fantasizes about killing Harry, but a “still small voice” tells him that that would break Mary’s heart. Then he contemplates suicide—but he reminds himself that he promised Esther to protect Mary. He decides that he must live and keep his promise. Esther might have jumped to conclusions about Harry’s malign purposes—Harry might want to marry Mary. After all, his own mother (Mrs. Carson) was a factory girl. With this in mind, Jem plans to ask Harry outright what he means to do.

CHAPTER 15

Meanwhile, John Barton has suffered first the shock of his petition’s failure in London and then a stretch of semi-starvation, which he used opium to cope with. In these trials, he has become obsessed with the gulf between the rich and the poor. He does not believe God intends this gulf, and so he wants to know whose fault it is. Eventually, he comes to hate the rich. The narrator compares the poor with Frankenstein’s monster: the rich have created them but deprived them of “inner means for peace and happiness.”

A recent event has disturbed the workers. The mills have received an order from a foreign market, but the owners fear that the market sent the same order to mills on the continent and will buy from whichever manufacturer produces the order more cheaply. As such, they plan to reduce workers’ wages so that both workers and employers may ultimately benefit. But the employers don’t explain the circumstances to the workers, only expect them to accept reduced wages. The workers, angered that the employers would use their starvation to exploit them, go on strike.

Despite Esther’s belief that she is irredeemable due to her sex work and alcoholism, Jem tries to help her and curses himself for not persuading her to come home. His reactions implicitly model both working-class, pragmatic, community-oriented morality and the Christian virtues of forgiveness, mercy, and generosity.



Jem’s violent and disturbing jealous fantasies hammer home the novel’s contention that sexual and romantic feelings are volatile and potentially dangerous. The phrase a “still small voice” is a biblical reference to God’s voice (1 Kings 19:12); through this allusion, the novel implies that Christian virtue prevents Jem from carrying out any acts of jealous violence against Harry. His decision to ask Harry about Harry’s intentions rather than assuming the worst shows his fair-minded generosity.



Mary Shelley’s 1818 novel [Frankenstein](#) tells the story of a scientist who arrogantly creates a self-conscious, suffering, lonely monster. Here, the novel analogizes the rich to the scientist and the poor to the monster, thereby arguing that the employer class negligently creates the conditions for workers’ suffering. John’s religious confusion over income inequality shows the ways that worldly injustice and the problem of evil can impede people’s belief in Christian tenets like universal brotherhood and the necessity of loving one’s enemies.



This passage suggests that employers’ and workers’ interests are entwined: if the workers accept lowered wages, both employers and workers get something; otherwise, no one gets anything. Yet the employers’ arrogant refusal to explain the situation to the workers ultimately causes a strike, suggesting that employers’ personal flaws and ego—rather than structural phenomena like differing class interests—lead to conflict between employers and workers.



John is elected to a committee organizing the strike. The mill owners, in turn, meet to bolster one another's decision not to yield to the workers' demands. Mr. Carson and Harry Carson are among the harshest of the owners, Mr. Carson with the passion of a "convert" because he used to be a worker himself, and Harry because he enjoys the idea of a fight. Rural workers and workers from neighboring counties come in to answer the owners' advertisements—and many are beaten by the striking workers for interfering with the strike.

The workers write to the owners asking for a meeting at which they will communicate terms for ending the strike. The masters agree, though they aren't sure how much to concede. Some with "sympathy" want to concede; others, including Harry, want to refuse everything. Yet despite how busy Harry is with the strike, he still finds time to pester Mary, insisting that he will possess her one way or another. Meanwhile, Mary never runs into Jem.

If it weren't for Mary's troubles, she would be amused that Will has fallen in love with Margaret. Afraid to approach Margaret, Will nervously gives gifts to Job. Meanwhile, Jem has been looking for an opportunity to speak to Harry but hasn't found it—until, five days after Jem's meeting with Esther, the two young men meet by chance in the street during the workman's lunch hour. Jem politely waylays Harry and asks whether he knows Mary. Harry is momentarily suspicious that Mary jilted him for Jem, though he can't imagine her choosing a dirty worker over him. He says he knows Mary as a pretty "hussy."

When Harry tries to walk off, Jem puts his hand on Harry's arm. Harry shakes him off and ostentatiously brushes his sleeve, rousing Jem's temper. Jem says outright that he has heard Harry is courting Mary and he wants to know whether Harry intends marriage. If not, Harry needs to leave her alone. Harry, trying to understand Jem's motives, speculates that perhaps Jem is a friend of Mary's that she using to "bully" him into marrying her. He asks what right Jem has to interfere in his and Mary's affairs. Jem announces that he loves Mary more than a father or brother could, which gives him the right.

Usually, the novel suggests that understanding and shared experience lead to empathy. Yet Mr. Carson's behavior is a counterexample: he seems motivated to bully the workers either to distance himself from his own working-class background or to bolster his own belief that if he escaped poverty through hard work, anyone theoretically can.



The employers able to feel "sympathy" for the workers want to agree to some of the workers' demands, underscoring the idea that sympathy and empathy lead to cooperation and mutual aid. This passage juxtaposes Harry's lack of sympathy for the workers with his sexual harassment of working-class Mary, perhaps suggesting that his class-based entitlement fuels both behaviors.



Will, a positively represented character, is too shy to approach Margaret and tries to indirectly court her through her male guardian—showing how the novel believes sexual and romantic feelings can be appropriately expressed, in contrast with Mary and Harry's former unsupervised flirtation. When Harry calls Mary a "hussy" (a derogatory term for a bold, flirtatious girl) it shows him weaponizing Victorian conservatism and sexism against her, even though it is precisely her sexual conservatism that has thwarted Harry's desire to see her.



Harry and Jem's respective class statuses heavily influence their interaction: when Harry brushes his sleeve after Jem touches his arm, he is implying that Jem is dirty—and, by implication, lower-class and unworthy of Harry's time. Moreover, Harry's guess that Jem is trying to "bully" him into marrying Mary indicates that Harry sees himself as an advantageous match for Mary due to his class status, one that her whole working-class family would want her to pursue—even though, in fact, Mary doesn't want Harry and her family would hate him. Jem's declaration that he has a right to interfere in Mary's romantic life because he loves her—even believing that she doesn't love him back—shows his arguably disturbing possessiveness of her.



Having decided that Jem is a spurned admirer of Mary's, Harry is no longer interested in him and tries to leave. Jem refuses to let him until he announces his intentions regarding Mary. Harry strikes Jem across the face with his walking cane—and in response, Jem punches Harry flat. A policeman, having spied the two young men, runs up, restrains Jem, and asks Harry whether Jem should be taken to jail. Harry says no, since he hit Jem first—but before he leaves, he tells Jem that things may go worse for Mary because of Jem's actions. Jem snaps back that if Harry hurts Mary, policemen won't prevent Jem from holding Harry to account. The policeman leads Jem away.

Though Harry hit Jem first, the policeman takes Harry's side in the fight, implicitly because Harry is obviously the richer and more socially influential of the two young men—indicating how the criminal legal system unfairly privileges the rich in the world of the novel. Meanwhile, Harry's threat to harm Mary due to Jem's actions insists yet again on the dangers of flirtation and sexuality: Mary is in peril from Harry solely because she engaged in mild flirtation with him and because another man took it upon himself to intervene.



CHAPTER 16

On the appointed day, the mill owners gather at the hotel where they are supposed to discuss the strike with representatives of the workers. Some, very angry over a poor weaver beaten for attempting to take work during the strike, are determined to give the workers nothing. None consider explaining the circumstances that led them to reduce wages in the first place. Then five workers' representatives arrive. One representative reads the workers' rather extreme demands to the owners, and then the representatives leave the room so the owners can deliberate.

Once again, the novel takes care to remind readers that the employers haven't told the workers their reasons for offering such low wages. By arrogantly preventing the workers from understanding their reasoning, the employers are shooting themselves in the foot—precluding mutual understanding, empathy, and a possible resolution.



By a single vote, the owners refuse to advance any income to workers but agree to make a concession: one more shilling per week than they had originally offered. The representatives come back, hear the concession, and refuse the offer—they want all their demands met. Harry Carson, infuriated, puts forward a different resolution: the owners should stop talking to the Trades' Union, refuse to hire any worker in a Trades' Union in the future, and protect any workers who accept the owners' original salary offer. Harry's proposal passes. The owners announce it to the representatives, who leave in grim silence.

The employers' concession is stingy and not enough to alleviate the widespread poverty and food insecurity the workers are experiencing. Because the employers have not revealed the reasons behind their desire to keep operating costs as low as possible—they think that otherwise they won't get paid for the manufacturing order, essentially—the workers find their stinginess offensive and reject the "concession." This rejection leads to an unempathetic hardening of the employers' position. In other words, because the two parties start from a position of misunderstanding, their attempts at bargaining only lead to increased bad feeling.



Meanwhile, Harry drew a **caricature** of the ragged workers' representatives when they first came in and wrote a quotation "from the fat knight's well-known speech in *Henry IV*" on it. The owners passed it around, smiling; when it returned to Harry, he threw it nonchalantly at the fire, not realizing he'd missed. A worker who noticed Harry drawing comes back to the hotel after the meeting and retrieves the caricature.

*This passage alludes to William Shakespeare's *Henry IV*, Part I (c. 1597), specifically a scene in which "the fat knight," Falstaff, gives a speech about how, after receiving the task of conscripting soldiers, he took bribes from men wanting to avoid army service and recruited extremely poor men and criminals instead. Harry's caricature is comparing the workers' representatives to Falstaff's immiserated, pathetic, criminal, and despicable recruits. His mockery of the starving workers—and the other factory owners' amusement at it—shows the employer class's lack of empathy for the working class.*



The workers meet at a pub that evening to discuss the meeting with the masters. Then a sleazy union man from London gives a speech advising how the Manchester workers should handle the strike, after which he gives them a little money. After the meeting breaks up, some workers stay behind, and the man who retrieved Harry's **caricature** passes it around. One of the workers caricatured announces that he can take a joke when he's not starving, but it infuriates him that someone would mock the workers when his starving family is begging for food at home.

John, who is at the meeting, says the **caricature** makes him furious: it's hideous that someone would mock workers who only want enough food, warm clothes, and roofs for themselves and their dependents. In a low voice, he says he knows of a "tender-hearted man" who killed his own child rather than let the child starve to death. Then he says that the workers are only asking for their rightful portion of the manufacturing earnings, which they would spend on necessities, not luxuries the way the owners would—and he wants revenge on the owner who drew the caricature.

John explains that he missed the meeting with the owners to visit Jonas Higginbotham in prison, a man who threw acid on a rural weaver who came to Manchester for work during the strike. Jonas, repenting what he'd done, asked John to sell his silver watch and give it to the weaver's family. John sold the watch, but when he visited the weaver in the Infirmary to find out his family's address, the man was screaming his wife's name and lamenting that he was blinded for trying to support his baby—too deliriously for John to get the address. John asked the nurse to find out the address, but now he wants to tell the other workers that they should never again attack workers who try to break the strike.

When a few workers grumble disapproval, John announces that he's not a coward—but he wants to fight the owners, not fellow workers. The idea of terrifying the owners catches on, and the furious group discusses what they might do. Finally, the assembled men tear the **caricature** into strips, mark one of those strips, and then pull them from a hat. Then they leave in silence—but the man who, unknown to the others, pulled the marked strip has "drawn the lot of the assassin."

The caricatured worker's fury at Harry's mockery suggests that the workers do not resist the employers' offer of lowered wages solely due to economic or class interest but also out of a sense of dignity—they feel that the employers do not recognize their humanity or care about their suffering, a feeling that stiffens their resistance to concessions or bargaining.



The caricature, which represents the employers' lack of empathy for the working classes, spurs John to demand revenge on the employers. John's thirst for revenge—a fundamentally unchristian desire—shows how, in the novel's view, the cruelty and callousness of the rich tends to damage the goodness, empathy, and religious faith of the suffering poor.



Though John may have rejected Christian teachings against vengeance, he is not bloodthirsty or indiscriminate in his desire for revenge. He cautions the other workers not to attack members of their own class who are desperate enough to break the strike, a caution that shows his class solidarity, empathy, and residual moral qualms about violence.



Harry's caricature, torn up, becomes the method by which the workers choose who among them will kill a member of the employer class. Symbolically, the use of Harry's caricature to choose "the assassin" indicates that Harry and the other employers' lack of empathy has infected the workers, making them callous, desperate, and violent.



CHAPTER 17

Two days later, a Thursday, Will visits Mary at the Bartons' and says he must say goodbye: his ship sails on Tuesday, and he still needs to visit family on the Isle of Man. When Mary suggests he travel part of the way with John, who's going to Glasgow for the Union, Will says he plans to walk to Liverpool that night to catch his boat. Abruptly, Will asks after Margaret. When Mary says Margaret seems happy, Will says he wishes he could "comfort" and "cherish" her somehow—as it is, she seems so superior to him that he can't imagine proposing. Mary laughs at him a little; though Will laughs too, he says Mary's laughter proves she's never been in love. Mary blushes and tears up, but Will doesn't notice.

Will says that he might receive a promotion to second mate on his upcoming voyage, after which he'd "have something to offer Margaret." He asks Mary whether she thinks Margaret might return his feelings. Mary says he should ask Margaret, not her—but she advises him to speak to Margaret before he leaves. He says he can't, but he shows Mary a tacky little accordion he bought and asks her to give it to Margaret once he's gone. After Mary promises, Will asks her to look in on the ailing Alice from time to time.

John enters, looking grim and distressed. When Will announces that he's come to say farewell, John gives him a gruff goodbye—so Will shakes hands with Mary and leaves. Mary tries to make conversation with John and tempt him to eat, but he answers her tersely and claims to have gotten used to starving. Then Job comes in to pay John a visit before John catches the train to Glasgow. John, annoyed, stomps upstairs, but Job stays and chats with Mary. He admits that he only belongs to the Union and adheres to the strike because the union men would violently pester him if he didn't—on the whole, he'd rather accept bad pay: "half a loaf is better than no bread."

John comes downstairs and says goodbye to Job and Mary. When Mary begs John to pause and eat something, he brushes her off and leaves—but when she stands in the doorway, crying, he turns around, hugs her, and blesses her. She begs him one more time to eat, but he says he can't and leaves. Afterward, without knowing why, Mary feels devastated. Meanwhile, as a miserable John walks away, his thoughts turn to his baby son Tom.

Will, a positively connoted character, sees the duty of a lover to "comfort" and "cherish" his beloved—in stark contrast with Harry Carson, who wants to "possess" or "obtain" his love object (Mary) as if she were a consumer item. Thus, while the novel generally represents romance and sex as dangerous, it gives Will's chaste and respectful love of Margaret as a counterexample illustrating what "good" romance looks like.



Again, in contrast with Harry Carson, who wants to possess or obtain Mary "cheaply," Will believes that he shouldn't approach Margaret romantically until he has "something to offer" her economically. Through this contrast, the novel suggests that good and honorable men want to support their beloveds materially, while bad men want to give their beloveds as little as possible.



Job's claim that "half a loaf is better than no bread" indicates that, if he knew that the employers were offering such low wages to ensure that everyone got paid at all, he would be on the employers' side. Assuming that other workers might share Job's view, the novel is bolstering its implicit argument that the employers made a mistake not by offering their workers exploitatively low wages but by arrogantly failing to explain the reasons behind the wage decrease.



Previously in the novel, John has alluded to his baby son Tom, who starved to death, as an example of the sort of suffering that the rich employer class doesn't understand and has failed to alleviate it. When he thinks of Tom here, it suggests he is fortifying himself to take some action against the employers.



Margaret, crying, enters the Bartons' and announces that Alice has just had a stroke. Mary asks where Jem was, and Margaret replies that he went out and hasn't come back. She went and told Mrs. Davenport what happened, and Mrs. Davenport tended Alice while Mrs. Wilson fetched a doctor. Job laments that Will left just before this happened. Job and Margaret leave the Bartons' house. Mary, left alone, feels a sudden fear that Harry will learn she's unprotected—and a sudden despair that Jem may no longer love her.

Mrs. Davenport's immediate aid to Mrs. Wilson after Alice's stroke shows once again the community-minded morality and mutual aid that characterize the working-class community in the novel. Meanwhile, Mary's fear that Harry will know her father has left reminds readers that Harry is a sexual and social threat to Mary, not merely a former boyfriend.



CHAPTER 18

The same evening, the three Carson sisters are lazing around their drawing room discussing Harry's attentions to a girl named Jane Richardson. One sister, Sophy, condemns Harry's flirtations—poor Jane doesn't know he isn't serious, and he'll break her heart. Then their nurse enters, sobbing, and announces that Harry has been carried home dead—he was shot walking home. She begs Sophy to bring the news to Mr. Carson. Sophy, stunned, enters the dining room where her father has drifted off to sleep. She wakes him and, attempting to explain what has happened, bursts into tears. The nurse, following, says that Harry has been harmed. When Mr. Carson asks whether they've sent for the doctor, Sophy says it's "no use."

When Sophy condemns Harry's romantic behavior toward Jane Richardson, it suggests that Harry's romantic exploits are harmful to more girls than just Mary—while also revealing that members of Harry's own class and even his own family dislike his behavior. Thus, contrary to John's tendency to paint the employer class as universally callous, Sophy serves as an example of an employer's daughter who is sensitive and sensible. The novel uses the sympathetic Sophy as a vehicle to drive home how tragic a brother and a son's murder would be to a family—even if that brother and son is the unlikable character Harry Carson.



Mr. Carson, utterly devastated, asks where Harry is. The nurse explains that two policemen and a helper have brought his body into the servants' hall and would like to speak with Mr. Carson. Mr. Carson and the nurse walk to the servants' hall. There, Mr. Carson kisses dead Harry's face and asks the policemen how Harry died. One policeman explains that he (the policeman) heard a gunshot on Turner Street, ran toward the noise, and heard a man running away but didn't see him. Then he found Harry, who seemed to have died very quickly.

When Mr. Carson tenderly kisses the face of his dead son, it illustrates his paternal love and his emotional devastation. In a way, Mr. Carson is experiencing the same grief and trauma at Harry's murder that John Barton experienced at his baby son Tom's starvation.



Mrs. Carson, drawn by the noise, walks into the servants' hall to investigate. Mr. Carson tells the nurse to take her away, but soon enough the whole house can hear Mrs. Carson breaking down. After a doctor comes and examines Harry's body, the police superintendent asks Mr. Carson for a private conference. In the dining room, Mr. Carson says he will offer any reward to have his son's murderer caught and executed. The superintendent says that they've already found a gun near the crime scene and that, a few days ago, the same policeman who found Harry's body broke up a fight between Harry and a working-class young man on Turner Street.

Previously, the novel has suggested that John's vengefulness results from the employer class's lack of empathy for the workers but that this vengefulness is nevertheless condemnably unchristian. Now, in the aftermath of his son's murder, Mr. Carson displays the same kind of vengefulness, wanting his son's murderer executed. Given the policeman's reference to a fight between Harry and a working-class young man, readers may guess that the police suspect Jem of the murder. This suspicion shows how the romantic intrigue involving Mary, Jem, and Harry endangers not only Mary but also Jem, who as a working-class young man is also socially vulnerable.



Sophy knocks on the dining-room door and asks Mr. Carson to speak with Mrs. Carson, who is acting bizarrely. Sophy and Mr. Carson walk to Harry's room, where his corpse has been laid out on the bed. The two other Carson sisters are there with Mrs. Carson, who is holding Harry's hand. Mrs. Carson announces that he's such a joker—he's faking sleep from which she can't wake him. Once Mr. and Mrs. Carson leave, the sisters break down crying. Sophy gets control of herself first and tells the others they should go attend to their mother.

The superintendent is waiting in the dining room when Mr. Carson returns. The two men talk for the rest of the night. When the superintendent is leaving in the early morning, Mr. Carson announces that his sole life goal now is to see Harry's murderer caught and executed and that he wants to offer a reward of a thousand pounds. Once the superintendent leaves, Mr. Carson cries out Harry's name and promises him that he'll have vengeance. The narrator rhetorically asks whether legal vengeance is any less vengeance and whether "ye are worshippers of Christ? Or Alecto?"

By showing Mrs. Carson's desperate denial that Harry is dead, the novel solicits empathy from readers for the Carson family. Thus, it implicitly encourages readers to see the employer class as consisting of real human beings, not cartoon villains, despite the exploitative and callous way in which the employers treat the workers for much of the novel.



Alecto is an ancient Greek goddess, one of the three Furies, whose function is to punish mortal crimes. By asking readers whether they are worshippers of Christ or Alecto, the narrator is asking them whether they believe in pagan vengefulness of Christian injunctions to forgiveness and mercy. Thus, the novel condemns Mr. Carson's attitude toward his son's murder as unchristian—and suggests that any reader who thinks Mr. Carson is acting rightly is unchristian as well.



CHAPTER 19

The next morning, Mary rushes to see Alice before work. At the Wilsons' house, Mrs. Wilson and Mrs. Davenport say Alice's condition hasn't changed, and the latter shows Mary into Alice's bedroom while warning her that Alice no longer recognizes anyone. Margaret is already there. The two girls listen to Alice talk aloud about her childhood as if she were still a child. Mary offers to watch over Alice through the coming night, and Margaret says that would be good—Mrs. Wilson had to watch Alice almost all last night, as Jem was out until very late. Mary is hopeful that she'll see Jem later, though she judges herself for hoping such a thing while Alice is so sick.

Mary hurries to work, where Sally asks whether Mary has heard. When Mary asks what Sally means, Sally tells her that Harry was killed the previous night. Mary, utterly shocked, almost faints. Though she gets to work, she's crying: she feared Harry but feels terrible that he's died. All day, Mary's coworkers gossip about the murder—and criticize Mary for dumping Harry.

Mary, Mrs. Davenport, and Margaret all volunteer to help Mrs. Wilson care for Alice in the aftermath of Alice's stroke, illustrating the practical mutual aid that animates working-class morality throughout the novel. Mary's self-judgment for thinking of Jem while Alice is sick recalls Jem's self-judgment for proclaiming his love for Mary immediately after his brothers' deaths; both incidents suggest that romantic love is unruly, often socially inappropriate, and sometimes dangerous.



Mary, who knew Harry, feels immediate empathetic grief over his murder even as she also acknowledges that she feared him as a real danger to her. Mary's grief and empathy suggest her innate goodness, in contrast with the superficiality of her judgmentally gossiping coworkers.



Meanwhile, the police have plans to arrest Jem, and they send out an officer to determine who owned the murder weapon—though Mr. Carson, impatient and raging, thinks they are moving too slowly. That afternoon, someone knocks on the Wilsons' door. When Mrs. Wilson answers, a policeman disguised in workers' clothes shows her a gun and asks whether it belongs to Jem. Mrs. Wilson says it does and asks how he got it. Shortly thereafter, he rushes away without explaining. Mrs. Wilson supposes he was probably a friend of Jem's and goes to take a nap.

Though the policeman feels a little sorry for Mrs. Wilson, he takes what he's learned to the superintendent, and soon the police arrest Jem at work. Though Jem is shocked, he just asks a coworker to let his mother know he's in "trouble" and won't be coming home—and no more. The coworker goes and tries only to tell Mrs. Wilson what Jem asked, but Mrs. Wilson badgers the truth out of him. Distraught, she calls Mary a "dirty hussy" when he tells her that Jem was fighting Harry over Mary and refuses to believe that the man who asked about Jem's gun was undercover police. After the man leaves, Mrs. Wilson feels devastated though she is certain of Jem's innocence.

CHAPTER 20

After work, Mary walks to the Wilsons', guiltily glad that she no longer has to worry about Harry harassing her and that she might see Jem. When she enters, she sees Mrs. Wilson cooking and asks to help. Mrs. Wilson, furious, demands whether Mary knows where Jem is because of her—in prison on suspicion of murdering Harry. Then she asserts her son's innocence and accuses Mary of being a dirty flirt not good enough for Jem. Mary, horrified, agrees that she isn't good enough. She remembers how Jem told her that her rejection might turn him into a murderer and blames herself for the murder, which she immediately believes he committed.

Though Mrs. Wilson is somewhat appeased by Mary's self-criticism, she reasserts that if Jem is executed, his death—and Mrs. Wilson's death to follow—will be Mary's fault. Mary covers her face and announces, "My heart is breaking." Mrs. Wilson bursts into tears at the prospect of Jem's execution. Mary begs to stay and help with Alice, but Mrs. Wilson insists that she leave: she can't bear to have Mary around when her "giddiness" caused Jem's arrest.

The police act very quickly on Mr. Carson's behalf, which reinforces the readers' suspicion that the employer class receives preferential treatment from the criminal legal system in the world of the novel. Mr. Carson's rage at the speed of the investigation underscores his unchristian desire for immediate vengeance. Meanwhile, the police's suspicion of Jem emphasizes that romantic entanglements, though primarily dangerous for young women, are also potentially dangerous for young men; after all, Jem is a suspect primarily because he fought Harry over Mary.



Mrs. Wilson blames Mary for Jem's arrest and calls her a "dirty hussy," an insult suggesting boldness, flirtatiousness, and even sexual promiscuity. This insult suggests that even though Mary did not engage in premarital sexual activity with anyone or encourage the fight between Jem and Harry in any way, the mere fact of her having flirted with Harry is enough, in Victorian England's conservative and sexist society, to endanger her reputation in the aftermath of Harry's murder.



Mary's guilty happiness that she doesn't have to fear Harry anymore reveals just how psychologically oppressive and frightening she found his ongoing harassment. Meanwhile, her meek agreement with Mrs. Wilson's sexualized insults of her and her self-blame over Jem's arrest shows her internalized sexism, which the novel in no way challenges: Mary believes that because Jem loved her and she flirted with someone else, she is somehow at fault for any acts of violence Jem's love may have motivated him to commit.



There is a cause-and-effect relationship between Mary's flirtation with Harry and Jem's arrest for Harry's murder, but that relationship does not make Mary morally responsible for Jem's arrest or possible execution. That Mrs. Wilson blames Mary anyway shows Victorian cultural misogyny, which demands that girls and women act as romantic-sexual gatekeepers to control men's bad behavior.



On Mary's way home, a beggar boy asks her for food. At first, she brushes him off but, repenting, she runs home and fetches him what food she has. Charity complete, she returns home, falls to the floor, and sobs. She blames herself for Jem's crime and is horrified by the prospect of his execution. She is remembering the past—when she and Jem were innocent playmates, Mrs. Barton was alive, and John was happy—when she falls asleep on the floor. Later, a knock on the door wakes her. She opens the door and falls into the arms of the woman outside—mistaking her aunt Esther for her dead mother.

Despite her own dire situation, Mary makes time to give a beggar her remaining food. Through this action, the novel not only gives another example of practical working-class morality but also insists on Mary's essential goodness despite her flirtation with Harry. Thus, while the narrator never directly contests the misogynistic blame that Mrs. Wilson hurls at Mary for flirting with Harry, the novel does take care to indicate that condemning Mary wholesale would be unfair.



CHAPTER 21

The morning after the murder, Esther—having heard about Harry's death—is curious enough to investigate the crime scene, where she finds a paper ball: **wadding** for the shot that killed Harry. Smoothing the paper, she sees Mary's name and address on it; the handwriting looks like Jem's, who used to write letters for Esther because she was ashamed of her ugly script. Esther assumes that Jem killed Harry—and that it's her fault: because she is sinful, even her attempts to do good end in evil. Esther spies on Jem's workplace and sees him arrested. Remembering how he wanted to help her, Esther wholly sympathizes with him.

At first, the wadding with Mary's name on it in Jem's handwriting seems to confirm the idea that Jem killed Harry over Mary, thus suggesting that Mary's divided loyalties between her working-class origins and her social-climbing aspiration to marry Harry indirectly caused the murder. Meanwhile, Esther blames herself for the murder because she asked Jem to protect Mary; the narrator makes clear that she blames herself solely because, as a sex worker, she sees herself as irredeemably tainted despite her good intentions. Thus Esther, like Mary, blames herself for men's violent actions due to her internalized misogyny.



Esther, wondering how Mary has taken the news, lurks in Mary's neighborhood eavesdropping but only learns that John has left town. Eventually, she comes up with a plan. She pawns her "finery," borrows some plain, respectable clothes, and goes to visit Mary—which is when Mary, disoriented, mistakes her aunt for her mother. Esther, pretending to be married to a working man, claims coldly that she hasn't visited for a long time because she lives a busy life far away. Mary, weakly, asks whether she is "Aunt Hetty." Esther agrees and says that she's come because she heard a friend of Mary's was in trouble.

Esther's continued attempts to help her niece despite her own self-hatred and despair strengthen even further the novel's portrayal of working-class characters like Esther as community-oriented, helpful, and moral in a pragmatic way. ("Hetty" is an old-fashioned nickname for Esther.)



Mary doesn't want to talk about the trouble with the oddly cold Esther. Instead, she apologizes that she has no food to offer. Esther, who's been eating barely enough to live, claims that her husband is well-employed and that she has more than enough food—a lie that further turns Mary against her, as Mary remembers Esther as "loving and unselfish" and can't understand why she would fail to visit and bring aid to the half-starving Bartons. Esther longs to tell Mary the truth but doesn't want to face her disgust.

Esther assumes that the truth—that she is an impoverished, starving sex worker—would revolt Mary, so she lies and claims to be a well-off wife. Yet the lie backfires: without an understanding of Esther's real situation, Mary can't understand why a "loving and unselfish" person would fail to visit relatives or to help them during lean times. Thus, it's not Esther's sex work but her dishonesty that alienates Mary from her.



Esther, swallowing sobs, says she heard about Harry's murder, went to the crime scene, and found **wadding** with Mary's name on it. Mary abruptly changes her attitude toward Esther, feeling it's kind of Esther to save Mary from the police summons and questioning that the wadding would have occasioned. Esther identifies the handwriting on the wadding as Jem's and gives the paper to Mary. Mary takes it, examines it, and looks utterly horrified. She makes Esther promise never to tell anyone about it. Esther promises.

Esther suddenly notices a likeness between her dead daughter and Mary. When she announces that Mary looks like her daughter, Mary has no idea of the heartbreak Esther is alluding to: she is too absorbed in thoughts about the **wadding** to even ask about Esther's children. Esther, feeling unwelcome, says she has to go and makes Mary promise to destroy the wadding. Mary promises. Then she asks for Esther's married name and address. Esther claims her name is now "Fergusson" and gives Mary an address. Mary tries to kiss her in parting, but Esther wards her off, saying Mary must never kiss her, and flees.

CHAPTER 22

Once Esther leaves, Mary bars the door and covers the windows. She has recognized the **wadding** as made of paper from the valentine Jem sent her—the valentine she repurposed to copy a Samuel Bamford poem for John. Thus, the wadding proves to her that John murdered Harry. She goes to search John's things for the rest of the paper—hoping that she won't find it, that John gave the poem away to a friend prior to the murder—and finds it in John's coat pocket, along with bullets and a packet of gunpowder.

Mary is sure that Jem never told John about Harry, so she has no idea what John's motive for murder was. While she is horrified by her father's crime, she feels relief that Jem is innocent. She resolves to prove his innocence—somehow without implicating her father. She burns the **wadding** and, feeling that she must gather all her strength, goes to sleep. The next morning, she wakes up determined to provide Jem with an alibi for the murder.

Neither Esther nor Mary seems to have any qualms about hiding material evidence in a murder investigation from police, which hints that while employers like Mr. Carson have the police at their beck and call, the working class sees the criminal legal system as a nuisance or even an adversary from which they must protect other working-class people. Meanwhile, Mary's horror when she sees the wadding seems to imply that she recognizes it and wants to hide it out of loyalty to the murderer.



Presumably if Mary knew that Esther's daughter had died young, she would express interest and sympathy when Esther mentions her child. Yet without the relevant facts about Esther's life, Mary remains unempathetically focused on her own immediate problems. Thus, the novel suggests that to be appropriately empathetic toward another person, one needs the relevant facts about that person's life.



The wadding implicates John, not Jem; thus, it comes to represent Mary's potentially divided loyalties: while she could use the wadding to exculpate the young man she loves, she would have to condemn her own father to do so. Thus, once again, romance leads Mary into intense emotional turmoil.



By burning the wadding, Mary reveals her intense loyalty to her father despite his crime. Her determination to save Jem, meanwhile, seems to derive not only from her love of him but also from her misogynistic guilt and self-blame at having flirted with Harry, which—through no fault of Mary's own—led to Jem's arrest.



Mary goes to Job's, hears Job and Margaret talking, and realizes they must be discussing not only the murder but Mary's blamable flirtation with Harry, which Mary never told Margaret about. Mary greets them in a small voice. Job greets her with excessive formality, while Margaret says nothing. Mary says she's come to ask their help in proving Jem innocent. When Job suggests that Jem did commit the murder because Mary "jilted" him, Mary begs him to help anyway, asking how somebody produces an alibi. Job suggests that the best way to clear Jem's name is to find the real murderer, terrifying Mary—but then he adds that she needs to figure out where Jem was the night the murder was committed.

Meanwhile, Margaret still sits silent. Because she has never had her vanity appealed to and finds it easy to do the right thing, she can't understand why Mary flirted with Harry, judges her harshly as an immodest girl, and thinks of ending their friendship. Then, abruptly, Mary asks whether Margaret was with Alice the night of the murder and heard Jem come home. Margaret says she remembers something about Jem escorting Will partway to Liverpool. Mary immediately resolves to go ask Mrs. Wilson about it.

When Mary reaches the Wilsons', Mrs. Wilson announces that Jem's trial is on Tuesday, bursts into tears, and says she'll blame his execution on Mary. Mary asks where Jem was Thursday night. Mrs. Wilson explains that he accompanied Will partway to Liverpool. Mary says that they must contact Will, who can swear that Jem was with him. She is horribly pained by her conviction that John murdered Harry, but she feels her "first duty" is to focus on Jem.

CHAPTER 23

Mary rushes home, hoping desperately that she can prove Jem's innocence without implicating John. She thinks that she'd rather die or go insane rather than choose whether to give up John to save Jem. She knows that Will is supposed to return to Liverpool from the Isle of Man the day before the trial, and she needs to find out where he's staying and which ship he's sailing out on. She feels that she can't go ask Jem. Not only is he in jail, but also, he must know that the person to whom he lent his gun is the murderer: since he hasn't said anything, he must be refusing to prove his own innocence at that person's expense. Suddenly, she remembers that Will's ship was called the John Cropper—and realizes that Margaret might remember where Will was supposed to stay.

It's not only Jem's frantic mother Mrs. Wilson that blames Mary for Jem's arrest; it's also Mary's own close friends Job and Margaret. Their cold greetings to Mary and Job's suggestion that Jem only killed Harry because Mary "jilted" him show that they see Mary's flirtation as not simply Jem's motive for murder but also a reason to hold Mary morally responsible for Jem's supposed violence—an unfair judgment revealing Victorian misogyny and the danger of sex and romance to Victorian girls and women.



Here, the novel suggests that Margaret can't empathize with Mary's foibles due to a lack of experiential knowledge: Margaret doesn't know what it's like to be pretty or to be particularly tempted by the wrong thing, and so she condemns her friend. Interestingly, by contextualizing Margaret's lack of empathy in her lack of knowledge, the novel suggests that Margaret would empathize with Mary's foibles if she knew more. Thus, the novel implies that readers, who have been given access to Mary's consciousness, ought to empathize with Mary and forgive her faults.



Yet again, Mrs. Wilson's insistence on blaming Jem's legal peril on Mary exemplifies Victorian misogyny and so reveals the dangers for Victorian women and girls of any involvement in sexual or romantic intrigue. Meanwhile, Mary's sense that her "first duty" is to Jem shows her growing loyalty to him even over and above her father, while her practical determination to secure Jem's alibi once again characterizes the novel's working-class protagonists and pragmatically moral and prone to mutual aid.



Mary's belief that she will go mad if she has to choose between her father and the man she loves underscores yet again how John's act of violence has divided her loyalties. Meanwhile, in reasoning through Jem's silence on the matter of the murder weapon, Mary implicitly realizes that Jem won't tell the police that he lent his gun to John because he doesn't want to implicate John—suggesting that he's risking his own execution out of loyalty to his beloved Mary's father, another way in which his love for Mary imperils him.



A neighbor enters the Bartons' and gives Mary a piece of paper the police left for her: a summons to Jem's trial. Mary, frightened, refuses to believe that she must really testify and decides to take the paper to Job for interpretation. Yet when she finds him at home, he tells her that the paper is indeed a subpoena: she must testify at Jem's trial. When Mary expresses terror, Job tries to comfort her by suggesting that her testimony won't have much effect one way or another. Margaret comes home, and the three have a silent dinner together. Afterward, Job asks whether Jem has a lawyer. Margaret says he doesn't—Mrs. Wilson is too distraught, though she's convinced Jem is innocent.

Mary announces that Jem is innocent, and Will's testimony will prove it after she finds him in Liverpool on Monday. Moreover, she announces that God will help her due to Jem's goodness—even if she herself has "done so wrong." Margaret's heart begins softening toward Mary when she sees Mary's self-blame and determination to help Jem. When Mary asks Margaret where Will stays in Liverpool, Margaret remembers the street and the landlady's name. Job says he'll pray for Mary—but he'll also pay a lawyer acquaintance of his a visit now.

After Job leaves, Mary gathers her bravery and says that she knows how Margaret must judge her. Margaret tries to say she has no right to judge, but Mary interrupts her, saying that judgment is natural but, according to the Bible, should be tempered with mercy. Then she cries out that she had no idea what would happen when Harry first started flirting with her—and she cares more about him now that he's dead than she did when he was alive. She feels she is being punished for her sins. Margaret is entirely won over by Mary's grief and repentance.

Mary asks whether Will's alibi can save Jem. Margaret suggests that perhaps Mary relies too much on the claim of the distraught Mrs. Wilson that Jem was with Will that night, given the evidence against him: his fight with Harry, the gun, his absence from home, etc. When Mary insists on Jem's innocence, Margaret says she hopes Mary's right and offers money she's earned singing to pay for Jem's lawyer. She also refuses Mary's thanks, saying that if people take the golden rule seriously, they should also follow the rule, "Let others do unto you, as you would do unto them"—and not refuse help out of vanity. Jesus, after all, allowed others to help him.

The silence that presides over Job, Margaret, and Mary's dinner together heavily implies that Job and Margaret still misogynistically blame Mary and her flirtation with Harry for Jem's arrest, underlining yet again Victorian misogyny and thus the social dangers of engaging in romantic or sexual activity for Victorian women.



In this scene Mary displays Christian religious faith, which is positively connoted in the novel, while also explicitly condemning herself for the "wrong" she has done—an indirect reference to her flirtation with Harry. That Margaret becomes more sympathetic to Mary at this point suggests that Christian fellow-feeling can partly mitigate a lack of natural empathy between people: Margaret responds to Mary's Christian faith and desire to help Jem even if she still can't understand why Mary would have flirted with Harry.



Here, Mary directly appeals to Margaret's Christian beliefs in a bid to temper Margaret's harsh judgment of Mary's flirtation. That Margaret does indeed temper her judgment suggests that, in the novel's view, Christian teachings commanding people to be merciful and forgiving can supplement or replace natural empathy where the conditions for empathy do not exist.



Margaret's doubt of Jem's innocence suggests how much danger he is in: if even his friends believe that sexual and romantic feelings might have impelled him to violence, what will a jury think? Yet despite her doubts, Margaret offers to help Jem by paying for his lawyer, showing her practical morality and her generosity, which she couches in terms of the Christian Golden Rule, which enjoins helping people and which, Margaret believes, also requires people to accept help.



Through the window, Mary sees Job talking with another man across the street. They part. Job, reentering his home, tells Mary that his lawyer acquaintance has referred him to a defense lawyer who's going to go visit Jem. Mary and Will are supposed to go find the lawyer at 2 p.m. on Monday in Liverpool. Mary, though terrified by the whole situation, thanks Job for his help before she leaves.

By this point, Job and Margaret have both fully committed to helping Jem despite their doubts about his innocence. Once again, the novel insists that poor and working-class characters tend to help one another because they see and respond directly to their fellows' sufferings and needs.



CHAPTER 24

To distract herself from her fears, Mary decides to go help Mrs. Wilson. She finds Mrs. Wilson at home, sitting dumbfounded with a piece of paper in her hands, asking what the paper is. Mrs. Davenport, also present, tells Mary that the paper is a subpoena and that Mrs. Wilson is devastated that she must testify to the ownership of the gun. Mary gently takes the subpoena from Mrs. Wilson and tells Mrs. Davenport that they should try to get her (Mrs. Wilson) to rest. They guide Mrs. Wilson to a pallet in Alice's room, where she falls asleep. Mary spends the night watching over her and Alice, taking some imperceptible comfort from Alice occasionally singing religious songs from her childhood.

In this scene, too, the novel emphasizes working-class morality and mutual aid by having Mary and Mrs. Davenport help Mrs. Wilson in her distress and Alice in her illness. Meanwhile, Mary also derives comfort from Alice's religiosity, bolstering the importance of religious faith to the Christian characters' peace and happiness in the novel.



In the morning—it's now Sunday—Mrs. Wilson wakes and asks Mary whether all her troubles have been a dream. Mary quietly says no. She makes Mrs. Wilson breakfast and explains about Jem's lawyer, Mr. Bridgnorth, and about her plan to find Will to provide Jem's alibi. Mrs. Wilson bemoans that she, Jem's mother, isn't doing more to help him. Mary wonders whether there might be a way to spare Mrs. Wilson from having to testify and resolves to ask Mr. Bridgnorth about it.

Mary tries to help Mrs. Wilson as well as Jem, thus revealing not only her love for Jem but also her practical goodness and moral uprightness.



When Mrs. Davenport returns from church, Mary goes to fetch Alice's doctor to check on Mrs. Wilson as well as Alice. The doctor comes, intimates sadly that Alice will soon die, and then examines Mrs. Wilson. Afterward, the doctor—unsure what Mary wants to hear—says that it's natural for Mrs. Wilson to be weak after the shock of her son Jem having murdered Harry Carson. Angrily, Mary tells the doctor that people who know Jem are sure he's innocent.

The doctor's casual claim that Jem murdered Harry reinforces the readers' sense that Jem is in real danger of execution: most bystanders seem to assume that the romantic intrigue among Harry, Jem, and Mary—though it's only circumstantial evidence—is enough to confirm Jem's guilt.



Mary asks whether Mrs. Wilson is healthy enough to travel to Liverpool. When the doctor says yes, Mary bursts into tears and admits she'd hoped Mrs. Wilson was too weak to travel. The doctor, rather confused, says of course travel might be a risk. Mary eagerly asks him for a certificate saying as much that she could give to a lawyer. The doctor agrees that she can come get a certificate from him any time. Then he leaves. Afterward, Mary visits Job to explain what she's done. Job worries that it may harm Jem somehow if Mrs. Wilson doesn't testify and says he'll ask Mr. Bridgnorth.

In her eagerness to help Mrs. Wilson, Mary persuades the vacillating doctor to excuse her from testifying at Jem's trial. This incident shows Mary's practical morality and goodwill toward others, but it may also reveal her legal naivety, as Job worries that Mrs. Wilson's non-appearance at the trial might hurt Jem's chances of acquittal.



CHAPTER 25

After Mary returns home, Sally visits to gawp at her, curious to see the girl at the center of a murder case. When Sally asks why Mary hasn't come to Miss Simmonds's, Mary says she's quitting. Shocked, Sally says that Mary should certainly return to work after the trial and tell her coworkers about testifying. Sally goes on about how Mary might find a new boyfriend in Liverpool and how she should dress to testify. When Sally tries to lend Mary her black silk scarf, Mary asks how she could think about clothes when Jem might be executed. Sally speculates that Mary jilted Harry for Jem and asks why Jem felt the need to shoot Harry. Mary snaps at Sally for assuming that Jem did it—but then, melancholically, says it's worse when people who know Jem assume the same.

Mary is grateful when Job enters, interrupting the conversation and driving Sally—who can't stand him—away. After criticizing Sally as an evil influence, Job tells Mary that Mr. Bridgnorth thinks it might look bad if Mrs. Wilson doesn't testify but that if she's too sick to travel to Liverpool it can't be helped. Mary asks Job to visit Mrs. Wilson with her and see what he thinks of her health. They go to the Wilsons' house. After a short conversation with Mrs. Wilson, Job tells Mary that Mrs. Wilson seems far too ill to travel. Mrs. Wilson overhears them, stands up, and announces that she will go to Liverpool to support Jem and pray for him at the trial—no matter what.

Job suggests, in that case, that he should go find Will while Mary and Mrs. Wilson travel together afterwards. Mary hates this idea because she doesn't trust Job or anyone to be as desperate and determined as she is to save Jem—and because she doesn't want to sit and wait for others to resolve the problem. On the walk back home from the Wilsons', she and Job fight bitterly about who should do what. Then Margaret meets them and persuades Job to let Mary seek out Will. (Margaret is secretly motivated by belief in Jem's guilt: she's hoping that if Will can't provide an alibi, it will help persuade Mary of Jem's guilt.)

Sally's focus on what Mary will wear to testify and her possible romantic feelings for Jem—in the context of Harry's murder and Jem's possible future execution—show her superficiality. At the same time, her assumption that Jem committed the murder (coming after similar assumptions by Job, Margaret, and the doctor), emphasizes that the circumstantial evidence of Jem and Harry's fight over Mary has placed Jem in terrible danger.



Job's harsh condemnation of Sally, a silly and superficial girl obsessed with romance, indirectly suggests how socially dangerous an interest in sex and romance can be for girls and women in a misogynistic society like Victorian England. Meanwhile, Mrs. Wilson's insistence on praying for Jem at his trial exemplifies the centrality of Christian religion to the characters' lives, especially regarding their reactions to adversity.



Both Mary and Job intensely desire to help Jem in some immediate, practical way. Yet Mary is the more determined of the two: even as she blames herself for the danger Jem faces, she also believes that her love for him makes her his best advocate. Margaret, meanwhile, wants to help Jem but still believes he committed the murder—a belief that yet again shows how public opinion is against Jem, putting him in great danger of execution.



CHAPTER 26

On the train to Liverpool—Mary’s first train ride ever—Mary overhears two lawyers’ clerks gossiping about the trial, suggesting that Jem’s conviction is certain and that Mr. Carson pressured the authorities to hurry the trial. Once in Liverpool, Mary gets directions from a policeman to the house of Will’s landlady Mrs. Jones. When Mary knocks on Mrs. Jones’s door and asks for Will, Mrs. Jones is initially annoyed and suspicious, thinking perhaps Mary and Will are engaged in a scandalous love affair. Nevertheless, she informs a shocked Mary that Will never actually traveled to the Isle of Man and that he sailed off on the *John Cropper* this very morning.

The clerks’ gossip further emphasizes that nearly everyone believes Jem is guilty of Harry’s murder, putting Jem in real danger of execution. The gossip also shows the influence of rich employers like Mr. Carson over the criminal legal system, suggesting that the trial of working-class Jem for upper-class Harry’s murder won’t be fair and reminding readers of Mr. Carson’s unchristian desire for vengeance. Finally, Mrs. Jones’s suspicion that Mary is somehow sexually scandalous shows the death grip that sexual propriety has on the minds of the novel’s mid-Victorian characters.



CHAPTER 27

Utterly horrified, Mary begins addressing her absent father John in disjointed phrases, finally concluding that it will “come right in the grave.” When Mrs. Jones speculates that Mary is going insane, Mary pulls herself together and asks about Will’s ship. Mrs. Jones explains that Will didn’t know the ship’s departure time had changed till he arrived in Liverpool. He boarded the boat the previous night to be ready for the morning tide. Mrs. Jones calls her son Charley, who confirms he saw a steamboat towing Will’s ship downriver that morning. Mary, horrified, bemoans that someone will die because Will is not present to provide an alibi. Charley, stirred to action, says they should try to catch Will by boat before high water arrives and allows his ship to sail over the high sandbanks at the river’s mouth.

When Mary believes that she won’t be able to secure an alibi for Jem, she begins speaking aloud to John, who isn’t there. This speech may suggest that she is considering implicating her father to save Jem, indicating her divided loyalties; however, her claim that the situation will “come right in the grave” suggests that she cannot see a good resolution to the situation in life, only in an implicitly Christian afterlife. Meanwhile, Charley’s enthusiasm for helping Mary—though he only just met her—continues the novel’s representation of working-class characters as essentially and unselfishly willing to help one another.



Mary asks Charley where she should get a boat. Charley volunteers to take her to the pier where she can hire one. He runs off, Mary following. While they hurry, Charley asks Mary her name, her relationship to the man who needs an alibi, and her hometown. When they reach the pier, Charley asks a sailor to climb a mast and see whether Will’s ship is still on the river. The sailor, who approves of Mary’s apparent modest poverty, agrees and discovers that the ship is still on the river. Mary and Charley hurry to the water, where watermen, sensing Mary’s desperation, make her promise them all her money and her shawl as payment for boating her to Will’s ship.

The sailor who finds out for Mary that Will’s ship is still on the water approves of her modesty and poverty, suggesting that he helps her out of working-class solidarity. Yet the watermen exploit Mary’s desperation to take economic advantage of her; thus, not all the working-class characters display solidarity with one another or conform to the practical, helpful morality that usually characterizes working-class relations in the novel.



CHAPTER 28

The watermen row hard, but the boat moves slowly, and Mary becomes terrified that they won't reach Will's ship in time. As the boat gets close, Will's ship starts pulling up its anchor. Mary explains what she needs to communicate to the watermen, and they yell to the ship's sailors that they need "William Wilson" to testify in court in Liverpool to provide an alibi for Jem, accused of murder. The captain yells back that he won't pause his ship's journey or let any of his sailors leave. Mary is despairing when Will runs up beside the captain and yells that he'll return to Liverpool even if he has to use the pilot-boat.

Mary asks the watermen what a pilot-boat is. When the watermen explain, she asks how long it will take the pilot-boat to return to Liverpool. As the watermen argue over the answer, Mary feels disoriented—and suddenly despairs. She falls into an exhausted sleep as her boat makes its way back to the pier. When the boat arrives at sundown, the watermen shake her awake. She tries to offer one old boatman her shawl, but he refuses it, saying they only asked for it to make sure she wasn't hiding any additional money. He asks where she's staying. She looks for the card with the address in her pocket but can't find it (unbeknownst to her, she dropped it while pulling out her purse on the pier earlier). The old boatman, annoyed and worried, insists that she come with him.

The captain's ungenerous reply to a genuinely serious situation—one of his sailors could exculpate an innocent man who will otherwise be executed for murder—underlines the point, made in the previous passage, that while many of the working-class characters display solidarity, practical morality, and mutual aid, the novel does not portray the working class as uniformly moral and altruistic.



Though the watermen initially exploited Mary's desperation to make money, the old boatman ultimately refuses to take her shawl and gives her a place to sleep; thus, in this passage, the novel returns to representing its working-class characters as—for the most part—practically moral, helpful, altruistic, and responsive to the needs and sufferings of others.



CHAPTER 29

At 2 p.m., Job is supposed to meet Mary and Will at Mr. Bridgnorth's Liverpool office but doesn't find them. Mr. Bridgnorth tells Job that he interviewed Jem in the morning and found him uncooperative: Jem simply refused to answer some of Mr. Bridgnorth's questions. Yet when Job asks whether Mr. Bridgnorth thinks Jem is guilty, Mr. Bridgnorth says no—but he thinks Jem knows some secret about the murder that he won't share: when he asked Jem how Harry came to be shot with Jem's gun, Jem wouldn't say anything.

After a long wait during which Mary and Will don't arrive, Mr. Bridgnorth tells Job he has to go to the courts—and in any case, perhaps there was a miscommunication and that's where he'll find Will. After Mr. Bridgnorth leaves, Job walks to Mrs. Jones's. When Mrs. Jones explains that Mary came by but that Will had already sailed, Job asks where Mary is now. Mrs. Jones says she doesn't know, though her son Charley would. Then Charley walks in. When his mother asks him about Mary, he explains that she went boating after Will's ship. Job promises Mrs. Jones and Charley a sixpence if Charley will bring Mary to his address, supposing Mary comes back to the Jones's—but Mary doesn't.

Jem's refusal to speak to his own lawyer about the murder weapon strengthens the implication that he is trying to avoid casting guilt on his beloved Mary's father. Jem's dangerous self-sacrifice for Mary's sake shows yet another way that love, romance, and sex can end up imperiling working-class Victorian men as well as Victorian women and girls.



Job's alarmed search for Mary and Will reemphasizes that Jem is in danger of execution if Will does not provide an alibi for him, while the aid that Mrs. Jones and Charley provide to Job reemphasizes the practical, communal nature of working-class morality as represented in the novel.



CHAPTER 30

Job goes to the house where Mrs. Wilson is staying and admits that Will has sailed but that Mary went after him to retrieve him. Mrs. Wilson drearily announces that Jem will be executed—his happy ending will be his afterlife with God, Mr. Wilson, and his brothers. She just wishes people knew Jem was innocent. Job goes to look for Mary and Will at Mr. Bridgnorth's—but doesn't find them. Mr. Bridgnorth tells Job that, given Mary and Will's absence, the case looks very bad for Jem. Then Job goes to Mrs. Jones's, where Charley tells Job that he heard Mary went out in a boat and likely won't be back till the next morning. Job unhappily announces that she needs to be in court the next morning at nine.

Unable to think what else to do, Job goes back to the lodging house where he and Mrs. Wilson are staying. When Mrs. Wilson asks him whether he found Will, he decides to lie to help Mrs. Wilson sleep; he tells her they found Will and Mary, though he feels terribly guilty for his deception. Then, too restless for bed, he goes to sleep in an armchair.

Mrs. Wilson's prediction that Jem will be happy only in the afterlife with God suggests that, while the novel's working-class characters are genuine in their religious beliefs, their Christianity also serves to compensate psychologically for the exploitation and misery inflicted on them in this life. Meanwhile, Mr. Bridgnorth's warning reminds readers yet again that unless Mary can produce will at Jem's trial, Jem is likely to be convicted, thus heightening the novel's suspense.



Here, Job's Christianity and his practical morality pull him in different directions: while Christianity generally forbids lying, Job feels that he is powerless to help Mrs. Wilson except by lying to her. In this case, Job's desire to be a practical help overcomes his religiously inflected qualms about lies.



CHAPTER 31

Meanwhile, the old boatman takes Mary back to his house, where she abruptly faints. The boatman and his wife anxiously attempt to rouse Mary, but she doesn't wake until the boatman pours spirits into her mouth. As soon as she wakes, the boatman leaves her alone with his wife, who speculates that Mary is a "bad one" because she's so pretty, but she insists that Mary stay the night because sinners need the most help. Mary says she's not a "bad one" and explains how she met the old boatman and how her friend Will, who needs to provide an alibi, is returning in a pilot-boat. She starts crying. The boatman's wife, whose name is Mrs. Sturgis, comforts her, makes her tea, and puts her to bed. Yet Mary stays up all night watching a weathercock outside the window to check the wind.

Mrs. Sturgis immediately assumes that Mary is a "bad one"—that is, a fallen woman, a sex worker—simply because she is alone in the city and good-looking. This assumption shows how restrictive Victorian sexual mores were for women and girls, placing them in danger of social blame and ostracism even when they weren't engaging in sex work or premarital sexual activity (as Mary is not). Yet Mrs. Sturgis resolves to help Mary, despite her doubts about Mary's sexual virtue, implicitly because Christianity upholds that Christians should help sinners. Mrs. Sturgis's resolution shows once again the practical, altruistic morality of the working class in the novel—and, perhaps, suggests how (in the novel's view) real Christians ought to treat sex workers.



CHAPTER 32

Mr. Carson is sleepless the night before Jem's trial. He is obsessed with obtaining vengeance—or "justice," as he might think of it—and can't sit still. At nine on the morning of the trial, he goes to court, where the judge, lawyers, and various spectators have gathered. Job still hasn't let Mrs. Wilson know he lied about finding Mary and Will; as he enters the court, a clerk hands him a letter from Jem. In the letter, Jem predicts that he will be convicted despite his innocence. He also asks Job to support his mother emotionally after his execution—and to let Mary believe that he, Jem, shot Harry rather than telling her the truth, at least until many years in the future.

Job goes to the witness room to look for Mary. He finds her with her head in her arms and Mrs. Wilson sobbing nearby—suggesting that someone has told Mrs. Wilson about Will. Job returns to the courtroom, where Jem pleads not guilty. Spectators in the courtroom examine Mr. Carson and search for murderousness in Jem's face. After a few policemen testify, Mrs. Wilson takes the stand. When she is shown the gun and asked whether it belongs to Jem, she asks Jem what she should do. He asks her to tell the truth. She identifies the gun as Jem's. Then she turns to the judge, tells him she knows as Jem's mother that he's innocent, and admits she will be unable to credit the outcome to God's will if Jem is executed.

After several other witnesses, Mary is called to the stand. Mr. Carson is both interested and repelled by the thought of seeing "the fatal Helen." As Mary begins to testify, she is terrified. She answers the first few questions in a rote manner. Then the lawyer asks her whether she preferred Harry or Jem. Mary is offended by the prying question, but when Jem lifts his head from his hands to look at her, she puts aside her "feminine shame" to stand up for him against society. She turns to the judge and explains that Harry flattered her, and she thought he might save her from poverty by marrying her—but she realized she loved Jem after rejecting Jem's marriage proposal, at which point she cut off relations with Harry.

The novel refers to Mr. Carson's obsession as vengeance before sarcastically noting that Mr. Carson might think of vengeance as "justice." The sarcasm makes clear the novel's lack of sympathy with Mr. Carson's desire for violent retribution, which it has throughout represented as undesirable and unchristian. Meanwhile, Jem's desire that Mary believe he's guilty further implies that Jem knows John is the murderer and is trying to protect Mary from that knowledge because he loves her—for which reason he is putting himself in danger of execution rather than exculpating himself by admitting (as seems likely) that he lent his gun to John.



Some characters in the novel, such as Alice Wilson, demonstrate extreme submissiveness to what they see as the will of God. Other characters, like Mrs. Wilson, are Christian believers but cannot submit to accepting every event that occurs as God's will. Here, Mrs. Wilson's assertion that she'll refuse to believe her son Jem's execution is God's will shows the (very understandable) limit to her Christian humility and faith.



The phrase "fatal Helen" is an allusion to Helen of Troy, the mythological Greek beauty whose abduction by Trojan prince Paris started the Trojan War. Just as Helen was blamed for the war between the Greeks and the Trojans despite her relative lack of agency in the matter, so implicitly Mr. Carson blames Mary for his son's death despite Mary's lack of agency in same. Meanwhile, Mary makes explicit here that she saw Harry as an escape hatch from working-class poverty—that he tempted her not sexually but economically. By clarifying this point, the novel may be trying to make its heroine more sympathetic to a conservative and judgmental Victorian audience.



The judge asks Mary whether she ever saw Harry after rejecting Jem. Mary says she only spoke to him once, to tell him she didn't love him—but she never mentioned Jem to him. Then the judge asks whether Mary ever told Jem about Harry to make Jem jealous. Mary denies it forcefully. Finally, the judge asks whether Mary knew that Jem knew Harry was pursuing her. Mary says she didn't and, her physical and mental strength failing, asks whether she can leave the stand. As she descends, Mrs. Sturgis tries to convince her to leave, but Mary, though disoriented and suffering a terrible headache, insists on staying.

When Will bursts into the courtroom, Mary shrieks that she and Jem are saved and then has a seizure. Mrs. Sturgis removes her from the court, while Will is allowed to testify. He tells the court that Jem walked with him toward Liverpool all the way to Hollins Green on the night Harry was murdered. When Mr. Carson sees that the jury is beginning to doubt Jem's guilt, he's furious—Will's testimony doesn't change his own belief that Jem did it. Seeing the furious look on Mr. Carson's face, the prosecuting attorney attempts to pander to him by asking Will, in cross-examination, how much he was paid to provide the alibi. Will, furious, asks how much money the lawyer received to slander someone telling the truth. Then he says the pilot of the pilot-boat, O'Brien, can corroborate the details of how Will learned he needed to testify. O'Brien does.

Mr. Carson feels utter despair when he considers how unlikely juries generally are to convict people with death sentences even in clear-cut cases. He fears that his son Harry's murderer is going to walk free. The jury files out, deliberates, returns, and announces its verdict: though they weren't entirely convinced that Jem was innocent, they weren't entirely convinced that he was guilty, given his alibi—and they aren't going to condemn him to death under those circumstances, so they pronounce him not guilty.

Jem sits frozen, utterly shocked. He had predicted his own execution and felt sick of life, in any case, on the assumption that Mary hated him and loved Harry, whom she thought he'd killed. Once he learned that Mary loved him, however, he was full of hope for survival. Now, acquitted, he's simply stunned. Job, crying, approaches Jem, hugs him, and leads him out of court. Well-wishers swarm him. Finding his voice, he asks, "Where is she?" People lead him to his mother, Mrs. Wilson, who embraces him and says they couldn't possibly have convicted him after she described his excellent character. Jem hugs his mother back but asks again, "Where is she?"

At this point, readers are aware that Mary's romantic links to Harry and Jem in fact have nothing to do with Harry's murder. Given the actual irrelevance of Mary's testimony to the case, the judge's close questioning of Mary illustrates how sexual and romantic intrigue lead to public shame and danger for working-class young men like Mary and Jem even when they have actually done nothing wrong.



Mrs. Sturgis's prompt aid to Mary shows yet again the pragmatic morality and mutual aid with which the novel characterizes the working class. Meanwhile, Mr. Carson's insistence on believing in Jem's guilt despite his alibi shows how an unchristian desire for vengeance has made him irrational. Finally, the lawyer's insinuation that Will took a bribe to testify on Jem's behalf shows the contempt that the criminal legal system has for the poor and working-class, while Will's indignant response asserts working-class dignity.



Mr. Carson is in despair at the thought that the jury won't vote to execute Jem—even though Jem has a clear alibi for Harry's murder. Mr. Carson's despair shows his vengeful and—in the novel's worldview—unchristian bloodthirstiness. If he is really afraid that Harry's murderer will go free, after all, he ought to carefully consider whether the court is trying the wrong defendant.



This passage implies that Jem felt passively suicidal when he believed that Mary loved someone else, yet another detail that illustrates how, in the novel's worldview, passionate romantic love is potentially dangerous and destructive when not socially controlled. Jem's repeated question after his acquittal, "Where is she?", implies that, for Jem, "she" can only refer to one person: his beloved Mary.



CHAPTER 33

Back at the Sturgis home, Mary is delirious and hallucinating, convinced Jem is still in danger even when he comes to visit her. From her wild murmurings, Jem—but no one else—realizes that she knows her father is the real murderer. Though unsure of John's motive—perhaps Harry's pursuit of Mary, perhaps the struggle between workers and employers—Jem figured out John's guilt because John borrowed Jem's gun, the murder weapon, two days before the murder took place. Jem was unwilling for Mary's sake to prove his own innocence by damning Mary's father, however.

While Jem is waiting anxiously in the Sturgis house, listening to Mary's delirious ravings, Job visits. Job has received a letter from Margaret suggesting Alice will die soon; he proposes that he watch over Mary while Jem accompanies Mrs. Wilson and Will back to Manchester to see Alice. When Jem wants to protest, Job tells Jem that Jem owes it to his mother even if he loves Mary. Worried that Mary might betray John's guilt, Jem hurriedly tells Job that Mary in her illness is mixing up the thought of her father with the trial she just attended. Job says it's no wonder.

Jem takes a last look at Mary, terrified that she'll die or never recover her wits after finally confessing her love for him. Job, guessing Jem's thoughts, tells him he has to trust in God. Jem returns with Mrs. Wilson and Will to Manchester, where Alice—still convinced she is back in her childhood—diffuses a peaceful religious atmosphere before dying. At Alice's funeral, Margaret comforts Will, and though he feels utterly bereft, he also feels a "golden thread" within "the darkness of his sorrow." Meanwhile, Jem plans to return to Mary in Liverpool the day after the funeral.

When Jem discusses his plans with Margaret on the way home from the funeral, she notes how odd it is that John hasn't returned even during Mary's illness. She wishes aloud that John were home. Jem, silently, does not concur. Jem asks Margaret to look after Mrs. Wilson while he is in Liverpool. Margaret doesn't want to spend too much time at the Wilsons' for fear it would look like she was throwing herself at Will, but she reluctantly agrees.

This passage implies that Mary's divided loyalties—her desire to protect both her father and Jem—have worn her out so thoroughly that they've made her seriously ill. It also makes explicit that Jem refused to save himself from execution by revealing the real murder, John, out of love for Mary, another indication that romantic and sexual love may make people endanger themselves.



When Job advises Will that he has a duty to his mother—and implicitly to Alice—to travel back to Manchester, the advice shows how working-class morality cuts against ideals of romantic love: as represented in the novel, working-class morality is essentially about giving aid to one's family and larger community, whereas romantic love is an obsessive, individual fixation on one other person.



Job's advice to trust in God and the religious peacefulness of Alice's death both underscore the importance of Christian faith to a good life in the novel's worldview. The "golden thread" that Jem feels in the midst of grief is presumably his love for Mary; this imagery brings to mind earlier scenes in which Jem and Mary felt inappropriately excited for their love of one another during somber occasions, (like when Jem proclaimed his love for Mary right after his brothers' deaths).



Precisely because Margaret likes Will, her modesty and sexual virtue caution her to avoid him—another example of the extremely strict sexual conservatism of the novel's Victorian milieu, which represents sexual attraction as dangerous and shameful.



Once Jem and Mrs. Wilson are alone at home—Will having retired to a bedroom—Jem announces that he plans to return to Liverpool to see Mary. When Mrs. Wilson asks hostilely who Mary is to him, Jem replies that he'll marry her if she lives and won't even be able to speak his grief if she dies. Mrs. Wilson, jealous that her only surviving son loves another, snipes at him that he's abandoning her—that he's forgotten how she testified to his innocence at trial. Jem tells her he could never forget but that his love for Mary doesn't mean he loves his mother any less. He begs her to bless his journey to Liverpool and to look on Mary as a daughter.

When Mrs. Wilson complainingly asks why Jem can't just stay home and out of trouble, a frustrated Jem asks her whether she wants him to be happy the way Mr. Wilson was happy with her. Sadly, Mrs. Wilson wishes she had made Mr. Wilson happier; her debilitating accident worsened her temper and sometimes made her nag him. Jem reminds her that she and Mr. Wilson had as happy a marriage as most people manage. Then he asks her, for Mr. Wilson's sake, to love and accept Mary. Mrs. Wilson, crying, puts her hands on Jem's head; then she blesses him and asks God to bless Mary for Jem's sake. Jem, overjoyed, tells Mrs. Wilson that if she shows Mary her true personality, Mary will love her as much as Jem does.

Jem goes to visit Margaret. When he tells her about his conversation with Mrs. Wilson, she comments gloomily that he's hoping for an engagement on Alice's funeral day: "the dead are soon forgotten!" Jem gently chastises her, saying that new happiness need not mean forgetting the dead, any more than Margaret's blindness requires her to forget the faces she once knew. At eleven o'clock, after Jem leaves Margaret's, he sees a weak-looking silhouette—it's John Barton! After John vanishes into the Barton house, a shocked Jem decides not to tell him about Mary's illness, unsure how a visit from her beloved father might affect her given her knowledge of the murder.

CHAPTER 34

Jem returns to Liverpool and waits impatiently at Mary's bedside for her recovery. Eventually she is no longer delirious, simply exhausted. One day she wakes up, sees Jem, beams happily—and then blushes deep red. An overjoyed Jem runs to find Mrs. Sturgis. After that, Mary recovers rapidly. Yet while Jem has many reasons to return with her to Manchester—for example, he needs to start clearing his name of lingering guilt at work—he worries about the effects of a reunion with John on Mary. One day, on a slow outdoors walk, Mary tells Jem that she must go home alone—and begs him not to explicitly discuss why. He agrees, though he vacillates over whether his agreement is right.

Through her sniping, Mrs. Wilson implies that Jem's romantic love for Mary is incompatible with the family- and community-oriented morality that has characterized the working-class throughout the novel. By contrast, Jem implicitly wants to neutralize the conflict between selfish romantic love and family-oriented morality by marrying Mary, thus making her a member of his family and Mrs. Wilson's "daughter."



Mrs. Wilson attributes her bad temper to the factory accident that left her permanently weak and in pain. This backstory shows how economic conditions and class exploitation affect the private and emotional lives of the novel's working-class characters. After all, Mrs. Wilson, who was injured on the job, becomes less kind to her husband than she wants to be. Meanwhile, Jem appeals to Mrs. Wilson's community- and family-oriented working-class morality to get her to accept Mary; when he asks Mrs. Wilson to accept Mary for his sake, she marshals her Christian charity to bless Mary.



In this passage, Margaret and Jem model two different views of the relationship between romantic love and community-oriented morality. Whereas Margaret thinks that Jem's joy in his individual romantic love is selfish in light of Alice's recent death, Jem argues that he can simultaneously delight in Mary's love and grieve Alice—that is, simultaneously pursue sex and romance within the bounds of social acceptability while discharging his social and emotional duties to his community. As Jem gets the last word in the debate, the novel seems to side with him.



Mary's deep red blush upon seeing Jem suggests her maidenly shame at having proclaimed her love for him in court. Her shame and modesty around Jem contrast with her easy flirtation with Harry Carson; given the novel's conservative sexual politics, it seems likely that Mary's shamefacedness, shyness, and embarrassment around Jem are supposed to testify to the goodness, truth, and social appropriateness of her love for him, in contrast to the dangerous, unashamed boldness of her flirtation with Harry.



When the day comes for Mary to travel home, she is terribly sad to leave Ben Sturgis and Mrs. Sturgis, who have been so kind to her. By the time Mary and Jem reach Manchester on the train, she is extremely pale, trying to gather her courage to see John if he's home. She's terrified to live with a murderer, yet her love for her father makes her long to tend to his moral and psychological "wounds." When she and Jem reach their neighborhood, she asks him to go and wait for her at Job's place; if she doesn't come find him in half an hour, he should go to Mrs. Wilson. When Jem protests her coldness, she tells him she loves him as much now as when she proclaimed her love, but she must do what's right or regret it her whole life.

Mary hurries into her house, where she finds John sitting frozen by the cold fire grate, his face skull-like and miserable. Mary immediately sees John, though a murderer, as her "dear father" and tries to tend to him. She goes out to buy food for him with money she received for serving as a witness. On her way home, she stops in to Margaret and Job's, where Margaret greets her happily. When Job mentions that Mary is regaining some of her color after her illness but looks more like her father now, Mary blanches. She tells them that her father is home but seems unwell.

Job wants to visit John right away, but Mary tells him that John is too unwell and that he and Margaret should wait to visit until Mary gives the go-ahead. She kisses them goodbye and flees home. For the next three days, Mary tends to a weak, nearly silent John. After three days, Mary goes to Margaret and Job's again. There she runs into Jem, who lovingly asks her to come visit Mrs. Wilson. She says must return to her father.

On the fourth day, Mary spies through the window Sally coming to visit. Rather than let her in, Mary meets her at the door. Sally, seeing John over Mary's shoulder, is happy enough not to enter, but she wants to question Mary, a "heroine" in the papers, about the trial. When she asks whether Mary regrets not borrowing her black scarf, Mary snaps that she wasn't thinking about it at the time. Sally replies that she'd forgotten Mary was "all for" Jem and says that if she testified at a trial, she'd "pick up a better beau than the prisoner."

Sally tells Mary to come back to Miss Simmonds's to work. When Mary indirectly alludes to the possibility that she'll marry Jem, Sally informs her that Jem has been fired: his coworkers didn't want him there even if he had an alibi. Sally leaves, and Mary is rushing to go see Jem when John abruptly speaks, asking Mary to tell Jem to come at eight that night.

Mary's attachment to Ben Sturgis and Mrs. Sturgis reminds readers of how much these two virtual strangers did to help Mary, another subplot that insists on the respectable working class's pragmatic and altruistic morality. Mary's belief that her father must be suffering moral "wounds," meanwhile, indicates her implicitly Christian belief that committing evil acts like murder spiritually harms the person who commits the acts. Thus, precisely because he is a murderer, John is in need of help.



John's skeletal appearance hints that the violent revenge he took on Harry has damaged his spirit so badly that it has made him physically sick. John's sickness accords with the novel's implicitly Christian idea that sinful acts like murder corrode the spirit of the sinner, harming them and causing them to suffer.



Job's desire to visit the sick John shows his practical, altruistic morality: his first reaction to an ailing friend is to try to see and cheer up said friend. Yet when Mary deflects Job's offer, it suggests that she thinks John's crime has to some degree exiled him from the moral community to which he once belonged.



Sally, in her superficiality, serves as a foil for Mary in a way that makes Mary look better to readers. Though Mary flirted with Harry, she is not obsessed with public opinion, clothes, and finding "a better beau" the way that Sally is. Thus, the novel positions Mary as a good girl who made a mistake with Harry, in contrast with the dangerously shallow Sally.



Here, the novel teases out the ongoing dangers of romantic intrigue not only to girls and women but also to working-class men like Jem: though Jem was acquitted of Harry's murder, his association with the murder through the Harry-Mary-Jem love triangle has lost him the job with which he was supporting not only himself but also his aging mother.



CHAPTER 35

Mary runs into Jem on the Wilsons' street and immediately asks whether it's true. After a pause, he says that if she's talking about his firing, then yes: some men at the foundry no longer wanted to work with Jem and talked to the owner about it. When Mary protests that people who know Jem ought to believe in his innocence, Jem says that the overlooker does and is working with the owner, Mr. Dunscombe, to get him a job outside Manchester. He asks whether Mary would be willing to move away from Manchester; the overlooker has a family connection in Canada. Mary says she would go anywhere with Jem, but she can't yet. She tells Jem that John wants him to come visit that night.

Jem persuades Mary to visit Mrs. Wilson before going home. When they arrive, Mrs. Wilson is annoyed that Jem didn't come home sooner. He has hidden his firing from her; she likes to make him food to serve as soon as he gets home from "work," and it annoys her when he doesn't arrive promptly to appreciate the food. Yet when Jem and Mary arrive looking radiantly pleased with each other, Mrs. Wilson is only annoyed for a moment before she hugs Mary, blesses her, and asks her to make Jem happy.

After the visit to Mrs. Wilson, Jem and Mary walk to Mary's house. When they arrive, Mr. Carson and Job are there with John. Mr. Carson is demanding to know whether he heard John correctly: is John really confessing to Harry's murder? If so, Mr. Carson swears to have him executed even though he confessed. John snaps back that execution would be a blessing: he has felt such guilt for the two weeks since the murder that he nearly committed suicide, and death would be easy punishment in comparison. He "would go through hellfire" to expiate his sin and sometimes thinks that, if he were really in a world with a God, God would help him know morality.

John, exhausted, sits. Mary hurries to him. He asks for Jem. When Jem steps forward, John apologizes for letting Jem be arrested; he refuses to bless Jem because a blessing from him would help nothing, but he says, "Thou'lt love Mary, though she is my child."

Jem's tentative suggestion that he and Mary move to Canada reveals just how much economic danger the trial has put Jem in: he may have to move all the way across the Atlantic to get a stable job again! Mary's response—that she can't move yet—suggests that she, like Jem, is trying to balance the demands of individual romance with family- and community-oriented morality: she can't leave England while her father is guilty and ailing.



Mrs. Wilson's impulse to bless Mary—a religious action—shows how Christian belief is intertwined with various characters' positive emotions and relationships, while her ability to put aside her annoyance in the face of Mary and Jem's happiness shows her fundamental altruism and generosity despite her occasional fractiousness.



John's confession, his claim that death would be an easy punishment in comparison with his guilt, and his desire to burn in "hellfire" to pay for his sin all dramatically illustrate how, in the novel's worldview, vengefully straying from the path of religious righteousness leads to terrible suffering. Thus, John's suffering serves to suggest indirectly that if Mr. Carson succeeds in getting legal vengeance on John, it won't improve Mr. Carson's life or alleviate his grief.



Though Christianity teaches that God is radically forgiving to anyone who repents, John—like Esther—is harsher with himself than orthodox Christianity would be: he won't bless Jem because he thinks, as a sinner, he has no right to give religious blessings. Nevertheless, he instructs Jem to love Mary "though" she's John's daughter—suggesting that Mary's family would be a reason to hate her were it not for Jem's romantic love of her.



Mr. Carson walks to the door, pauses, and announces that he's going to the police to have John and his "accomplice" arrested—and soon enough to have John hanged. Mary grabs Mr. Carson's sleeve, points out that John seems to be dying, and begs Mr. Carson to let John die at home with her. John, standing with effort, says that he'll die where Mr. Carson wants—it doesn't matter where he dies—but that Jem is innocent. When John tells Mr. Carson that his hair is gray "with suffering," Mr. Carson interrupts to remind John of his own suffering: his beloved only son Harry, his "sunshine," has been killed, leaving him in perpetual "night." John weeps; Mr. Carson is feeling the same pain John felt for his baby Tom.

John no longer sees Mr. Carson as an owner, an employer, and an enemy but as a fellow human being. He wants to comfort Mr. Carson, but he feels he can't because he's the cause of Mr. Carson's suffering. Moreover, he no longer sees his killing of Harry as part of a war against an exploiting class but as the murder of a human being with a family: "a man, and a brother." Every time Mr. Carson sobs, it hurts John. John whispers that he didn't realize what he was doing, throws himself at Mr. Carson's feet, and begs for forgiveness for his sin. Job quotes the Lord's Prayer: "Forgive us our trespasses as we forgive them that trespass against us." Mr. Carson declares that he would rather remain unforgiven himself and have vengeance. Then he leaves.

Mary, Jem, and Job raise John from the floor and take him to bed. Meanwhile, Mr. Carson hurries unsteadily down the street. He pauses, braces himself against a railing, and looks at the sky; then he seems to hear a sad voice repeating back to him his own words about preferring vengeance to forgiveness. Feeling sick, he decides to go home for the night rather than directly to the police. On the way, he sees a coarse errand boy, about 10 years old, knock into a prettily dressed little girl, causing her to fall and bleed from the face. The girl's nurse grabs the boy and threatens him with the police, but the little girl intervenes, holding back tears and insisting that the boy didn't mean it—he didn't know what he was doing.

When Mr. Carson refers to John's "accomplice," he clearly means Jem. By implication, Mr. Carson's irrational vengefulness has made him unwilling to consider that Jem is entirely innocent even though someone else has just confessed to the murder! This irrationality bolsters the novel's implicitly Christian suggestion that vengeance is an entirely negative phenomenon, making vengeful people act wrongly and suffer. Meanwhile, Mr. Carson's evocative description of his grief—that his son Harry was his "sunshine" whose death has left him in eternal "night"—allows John to draw a parallel between his loss of his son Tom and Mr. Carson's loss of Harry. Thus, John is finally able to understand and empathize with Mr. Carson despite their class differences.



The transformation of John's attitude toward Mr. Carson makes clear that only John's lack of empathy for the employer class—his blindness to their humanity and individuality—allowed him to murder Harry. As soon as John begins to see Harry and Mr. Carson as individuals rather than as representatives of their economic class, he is horrified by his own violence. This horror clearly has a religious dimension: John's recognition that Harry was not only a fellow human being but "a brother" to him accords with Christian doctrine according to which all human beings are spiritually siblings because all are children of God. Job's quotation of the Lord's Prayer, meanwhile, makes clear that the Christian thing for Mr. Carson to do would be to forgive his son's murder; thus, the novel casts Mr. Carson's vengefulness as inherently unchristian.



Though the sad voice that Mr. Carson hears may not literally represent the voice of God, it seems clear that his (implicitly Christian) conscience is troubled and revolted by his own desire for violent revenge. The scene between the two young children, in which the girl insists that the boy only hurt her out of ignorance, suggests a parallel to John's murder of Harry: John was only able to kill Harry because he saw Harry as a representative of Harry's class, did not recognize Harry's individual humanity, and thus failed to empathize with him.



The phrase “I did not know what I was doing” reminds Mr. Carson of John’s whispered pleas—and of a quotation from the Bible. He hurries home and opens his family Bible, only to see the names and birthdays of his children—including Harry—written on the first page. He lays his head on the Bible and cries. Oddly, he feels he cannot hate guilty, dying John as much as he hated the murderer when he thought the murderer was young, strong, and defiant. He had noted the extreme poverty of John’s house, different from the “decent” poverty of his own early life. He turns to the Gospels looking for a particular quotation: “They know not what they do.” He ends up reading the entire Gospels and debating what he should do.

Meanwhile, Mary, Jem, and Job are watching over John as he raves in bed that he never learned right from wrong, because even though he had access to the moral teachings of the Bible, the people around him never followed them, which made him think the Bible was a “sham” to con the poor and uneducated. The happiest part of his life was when he was trying to live a Christian life, but then his son Tom died, and he couldn’t manage to witness the sufferings of the poor and love the employer class at the same time, and finally he despaired, becoming worse and worse. He cries aloud that he hadn’t thought Mr. Carson would be such an old man, and he wishes Mr. Carson had offered him forgiveness.

Eventually, Job goes home, and Jem steps out to buy some medicine, leaving Mary alone with John. John’s breathing falters. Mary tries to lift him up, but she isn’t strong enough. Mr. Carson walks in, sees the situation, and lifts John in his own arms. Mary kneels and begs Mr. Carson to pray for them. Mr. Carson prays: “Forgive us our trespasses as we forgive them that trespass against us!” John dies, and Mary faints. When she comes to consciousness, Job has returned; he and Mr. Carson are talking. Mr. Carson says goodbye, and Job comments that God has comforted Mr. Carson.

In the Christian Gospel (Luke 23:34), Jesus Christ asks God to forgive the people who have crucified him while he is dying on the Cross: “Forgive them, father, for they know not what they do.” The allusion to Jesus forgiving his executioners makes clear that forgiving one’s enemies is literally Christlike behavior. Mr. Carson’s engagement with his family Bible makes clear that a desire for vengeance is pulling him in one direction, while his Christian beliefs are pulling him in another. Additionally, when he contrasts John’s miserable poverty with the “decent” poverty he experienced as a working-class man, it implies that he is realizing and coming to empathize with the economic desperation that fueled John’s crime.



This passage makes explicit that John’s life deteriorated because he fell away from Christian teaching, thus emphasizing that—in the novel’s worldview—Christian faith forms the bedrock of a good and Christian life. Yet John fell away from Christianity precisely because of the unchristian, exploitative behavior of the employer class, a fact that implicitly blames working-class sin and violence on rich people’s immoral refusal to help the poor. Finally, John’s lament that he hadn’t recognized Mr. Carson would be so old shows John coming to empathize with Mr. Carson’s frailty and grief despite their class differences.



Mr. Carson prays the Lord’s Prayer—the same Christian prayer that Job quoted when trying to get Mr. Carson to forgive John—as John is dying. The prayer suggests that God will forgive sinners exactly in proportion to sinners’ willingness to forgive others; thus, Mr. Carson’s use of the prayer implies that he has forgiven or is trying to forgive John and thus that, having abandoned revenge, he is returning to the fold of Christianity. Job’s final comment that God has comforted Mr. Carson suggests that Mr. Carson’s religious forgiveness is not only morally right but also emotionally healing.



CHAPTER 36

Subconsciously, Mary has believed since she got back from Liverpool that guilt was killing John and that death might be a relief to him. After John's death, she is grief-stricken. Jem, Margaret, and Job support her and begin planning the funeral. When Jem returns home the evening of John's death, Mrs. Wilson tells him Job informed her of the death and asks how John passed. Jem realizes that Mrs. Wilson hasn't heard about John's murder confession and decides not to tell her about it, as he expects that his mother's peevish temper might lead her to discuss John's crime in ways that would upset Mary. Yet he doesn't know whether Mr. Carson will publicize John's guilt or not. When Mrs. Wilson insists on talking more about John's death, Jem flees to his bedroom.

The next morning, Jem goes to see his ex-employer Mr. Duncombe at the foundry. As he waits for Mr. Duncombe to arrive, many of his ex-coworkers, entering the foundry, snub him. The snubbing makes Jem think that he and Mary had better leave the country: while Jem could eventually live down the accusation against him, Mary would be known forever as a murderer's daughter if the truth about John emerged. When Jem talks to Mr. Duncombe, Mr. Duncombe agrees that Jem had better leave England and connects him with a job as an "instrument-maker" at an agricultural college in Toronto, Canada.

Jem goes to talk to Mary about immigrating. At her house he runs into Margaret and Job, the latter of whom has received a letter from Mr. Carson requesting that Job and Jem come talk to him. Job worries that Mr. Carson may want to trick Jem somehow into implicating himself as an accomplice, but Jem insists on going with Job to see Mr. Carson.

Meanwhile, Mrs. Wilson goes to visit the mourning Mary. When Mary, seeing Mrs. Wilson, begins to lament John's death, Mrs. Wilson comforts her not only by mentioning Jem but also by promising to love her like a daughter. She had intended to offer Mary some religious platitudes, but her spontaneous expression of love is "heart's piety [...] true religion."

Mary's sense that only death can bring the guilty John relief underscores how, in the novel's view, sin, violence, and violations of Christian teaching all cause the sinner himself to suffer. Goodness is not only the right but the ultimately more pleasant path to take. Meanwhile, yet again, the aid that Mary's friends and neighbors offer her in planning John's funeral exemplify the practical, altruistic morality of the novel's working-class.



Though Mary and Jem's community is working-class and Christian, Jem's speculations that Mary could never live down her father's crime suggests that there are limits to the community's Christian forgiveness and moral generosity: even though Mary herself committed no crime, the community would never fully forgive her for her family connection to a man who committed a violent crime.



Job's fear that Mr. Carson is trying to entrap Jem reminds readers that, despite Mr. Carson's apparent Christian conversion, Mr. Carson harbored violently vengeful feelings for Jem even after he had an alibi. This reminder heightens suspense around the meeting between Mr. Carson and Jem.



The narrator's claim that Mrs. Wilson's embrace of Mary is "true religion" makes Christianity central to the women's relationship while also suggesting that apparently faithful Christians may be hypocritical or insufficiently religious if their actions are not motivated by real love.



After this moment, Mrs. Wilson almost never vents her temper at Mary. Far in the future, Jem will learn that on this day, Mary mentions to Mrs. Wilson that John murdered Harry on the assumption that Mrs. Wilson already knew; Mrs. Wilson, though peevish in small matters, is generous in large matters, and she never criticizes Mary or John with respect to Harry's murder. When Jem realizes that his mother has kept silent, he loves and esteems her more than ever.

Mrs. Wilson's Christian love effects a large and lasting change in her previously irritable behavior toward Mary, just as Mr. Carson's Christian forgiveness reversed his vengeful attitude toward John. Both incidents reemphasize the power of Christianity (in the novel's worldview) to change people's characters.



CHAPTER 37

Harry's sudden death forces Mr. Carson to think hard about his own life because it makes the wealth and status Mr. Carson has been chasing for years seem suddenly unimportant. Trying to determine what would make his life worthwhile, Mr. Carson realizes that he wants to know what motivated John's crime. That's why he asks Job and Jem to visit him. When they arrive, Mr. Carson tries so hard to control his deep emotion that he seems "one of the hardest and most haughty men" they've ever met.

In a sense, John and Mr. Carson made the same mistake in reasoning: just as John took Mr. Carson to be a mere representative of his class rather than an individual human being, so Mr. Carson for a long time supposed that gaining and maintaining class status was the most important thing in life. Harry's murder made both men realize their mistakes. Meanwhile, Job and Jem's misjudgment of the emotionally struggling Mr. Carson as "hard" and "haughty" shows how a lack of communication—Mr. Carson is hiding his feelings—impedes empathy.



Mr. Carson tells Job and Jem that he visited Mr. Bridgnorth to ask about the murder and wants a few further questions answered. He encourages them to tell the truth, reassuring them that he won't repeat anything they say and that, in any case, no one can be tried twice for the same crime. Annoyed, Job snaps that it's good manners to suppose others truthful until they've proven otherwise—and that he and Jem will either tell the truth or refuse to speak. Mr. Carson apologizes and then asks how John got his hands on Jem's gun. Jem explains that John asked to borrow the gun two days before the murder; Jem didn't tell anyone after the murder because he didn't want to get John, his beloved Mary's father, arrested.

Mr. Carson's insulting reassurances and Job's snappish response show that Mr. Carson expects working-class men to lie and that Job is insulted by this class stereotyping—another instance of how the employer class alienates the working class through condescension, rudeness, callousness, etc. Meanwhile, readers are reminded yet again that Jem nearly died to protect his beloved's father, emphasizing the passion and dangerousness of romantic love.



Mr. Carson asks Job whether he had any idea that John was guilty before John confessed. Job says he had no idea—he assumed Jem was guilty, as Jem had a motive and John didn't. Mr. Carson asks whether John knew Harry was pursuing Mary. Jem says John didn't, and Job adds that the reasons John gave for his crime were motive enough. To clarify, Mr. Carson asks whether Job means John wanted revenge on the employers for their treatment of the workers, especially considering Harry's actions during the strike. Job says John never spoke to him about that particular case, but that John struggled to reconcile the existence of income inequality with Christianity.

Job's claim that John struggled to reconcile huge wealth disparities with Christianity reminds readers that Christian doctrine criticizes wealth and the hoarding of wealth: Mr. Carson's rich and ungenerous life is thus blameworthy in Christian terms—not least because it causes religious confusion and despair among poor men like John, who don't understand why their supposedly Christian social superiors won't help them.



When Mr. Carson asks whether John was an “Owenite, all for equality and community of goods,” Job says no: for John, the problem was that the rich seemed not to care about the material or spiritual well-being of the poor; it drove him crazy to see suffering that the employers could have alleviated if they tried. Mr. Carson denies that employers could alleviate suffering, claiming that employers don’t determine market demand for work. Job concedes this point but states that, nevertheless, rich men just cut back on luxuries in hard times while poor men’s children starve. When Mr. Carson says that economic disruption created by new technology is inevitable, Job again concedes the point but says that the rich still have a God-given duty to help the poor during times of disruption.

Mr. Carson says that Job is right but asks how his point relates to Mr. Carson’s own behavior. Job says that the employers must answer to their own consciences about whether they do enough to mitigate the suffering of the workers by whose labor the employers accrue wealth. John thought the employers didn’t do enough, and it drove him to insanity and murder, though he truly repented.

After a long pause, Mr. Carson thanks Job and Jem for coming. He also editorializes that neither he nor Job has changed the others’ mind about employers’ ability to help workers. Job replies that workers care less about employers’ ability to help than they do about employers’ “inclination” to help—even if employers tried and failed to help, it would matter to the workers that they’d tried. He also argues that his and Mr. Carson’s conversation has been productive even if they don’t agree because they now know each other’s point of view. He says that he’ll pray for Mr. Carson in the future and says goodbye. Job and Jem stand and bow, newly sympathetic to Mr. Carson as one who is fighting his way through deep grief and pain.

An “Owenite” is a follower of Robert Owen (1771-1858), a Welsh philanthropist and labor reformer who founded a short-lived utopian-socialist intentional community. When Mr. Carson asks whether John was an Owenite, he is essentially asking whether John was a socialist who believed in communal ownership of material “goods.” Job denies that John was this much of a political radical: rather, it was the hypocrisy of the nominally Christian but ungenerous rich that drove him to violence. In other words, according to Job, it was the moral failings of the employer class rather than political radicalism per se that drove John to murder. Notably, Mr. Carson claims that employers couldn’t help their employees even though the novel represents working-class characters helping one another with fewer resources all the time. This claim suggests that Mr. Carson thinks of help in terms of alleviating absolutely all suffering, whereas Job (as well as John before him) is thinking of ordinary, practical aid like gifts of food, clothing, time, etc.



When Mr. Carson asks how the general point about callous employers reflects on him, it implies he has the inklings of a guilty conscience about his own failure to help the working-class people around him. In response, Job says Mr. Carson must answer to his own (implicitly Christian) conscience but reiterates that the unchristian behavior of the employer class motivated John’s violence, suggesting that Mr. Carson and his social class do have something to answer for.



Job frames the conflict between the employers and their working-class employees as an essentially personal and emotional one rather than a matter of structural class conflict: the employees just want to know that their employers have an “inclination” to help their employees—even if that inclination doesn’t result in entirely effective action. Job also suggests that mutual understanding and empathy are goods in themselves: even if he and Mr. Carson don’t agree, it’s good that they now know one another’s thoughts.



Some people, after suffering a great pain, move from considering their individual circumstances to thinking about how to prevent the same pain from afflicting other people. Mr. Carson becomes one such person. Due to his superficial personality traits, people who know him only a little still think he's chilly and standoffish, but people who know him well realize that he badly wants to save others from the pain he suffered and to improve relations between employers and workers: "to acknowledge the Spirit of Christ as the regulating law between both parties." He effects much labor reform in Manchester.

Mr. Carson's earlier claim that the employer class couldn't help the working class suggested that he fundamentally misunderstood what kind of help the working class wanted: not a total alleviation of suffering, but some good-faith practical aid. Having come to empathize with working-class suffering through his own tragedy and through his dialogue with Job, Mr. Carson reforms as an individual, centers "the Spirit of Christ" in his dealings with employees, and thereby ends up improving working conditions in Manchester generally. This outcome implies that labor conditions would improve if employers were morally better individuals—it is a personal rather than structural take on political and economic change.



CHAPTER 38

Shortly after John's funeral, Jem finally proposes the Canada-immigration plan to Mrs. Wilson one evening, she agrees to come, saying she's had no great affection for England ever since it arrested a good boy like Jem. Another evening, an embarrassed Mary asks how Jem learned about her flirtation with Harry. When Jem admits that Esther told him, Mary suggests they go visit her—and Jem, realizing that Mary doesn't know about Esther, gently explains that Esther is in fact a homeless sex worker. Mary, horrified, insists they must find and help Esther. Jem searches for Esther, but the closest he gets is a landlady who tells them that Esther was dying and that she wanted to be in the open air when she did.

Esther didn't reveal her true profession and situation to Mary because she assumed that Mary would be disgusted. Yet when Mary learns that Esther is a homeless sex worker, she immediately wants to help Esther—whereas when she thought Esther was a well-off housewife, she was repulsed by Esther's apparent coldness. Thus, the novel suggests that knowing the facts of someone else's situation is central to empathizing with them and wanting to help them. Given that Mary is positioned as a "good" character, the novel—despite its sexual conservatism—also suggests that helping rather than condemning sex workers is the right thing to do.



Then one night, Mary and Jem are sitting together at the Bartons' house when Esther's face appears in their window. They rush outside and find her collapsed. Job and Margaret come by, and the four of them get Esther into bed. Later in the night, Esther wakes and asks, "Has it been a dream, then?" Upon touching her locket, which holds a lock of her dead daughter's hair, she realizes it hasn't been a dream. She holds the locket, cries, and eventually dies. The mourners bury her in the same grave with John Barton, under a tombstone with a quotation from Psalm 103: "For He will not always chide, neither will he keep his anger forever."

Esther dies without getting her life back on track, a conclusion to her storyline that emphasizes the danger of premarital sexual activity and sex work for Victorian women even as the novel presents Esther as a good-hearted and sympathetic character. That Esther and John share a grave suggests a parallel between their "sins." Although—per Psalm 103—both characters can expect eventual forgiveness from a merciful God, Esther's sex work and John's violence permanently exiled them from the less forgiving Victorian society that surrounded them in this life.



Once in Canada, Mary, Jem, and Mrs. Wilson live in a wooden cottage with a garden and an orchard. Mary and Wilson have a son named Johnnie. One day, Jem comes in with letters bearing good news: Margaret's cataracts have been removed, she can see again, and she and Will are getting married. Will is planning to bring Margaret with him on his next voyage to America, and Job will come too.

The story ends on a note of successful community- and family-oriented life, suggesting that—for those characters who did not commit "sins" like sex work or murder—honest labor, Christian faithfulness, and working-class morality are enough to ensure people a reasonably happy ending.





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